

FOR INDIAN LEARNERS

# SPOKEN ENGLISH IN 100 DAYS

---

From hesitation to clear, confident,  
internationally understood English.

Built around the problems Indian speakers actually have:  
mother tongue influence, stress and rhythm, the article  
system, Indianisms, and speaking under pressure.

## A COMPLETE SELF-STUDY WORKBOOK

100 daily lessons · 10 stage reviews · 8 reference appendices

Mother tongue trap tables for nine Indian languages

Name \_\_\_\_\_

Start date \_\_\_\_\_

# Spoken English in 100 Days

A practical, self-study speaking course for Indian learners.

---

**The goal is clarity, not a foreign accent.** This book will not try to make you sound American or British, and you should be suspicious of anything that promises it. Indian English is a legitimate, fully-developed variety spoken by more people than live in most countries. What costs you opportunities is not having an Indian accent; it is being *hard to follow* — wrong syllable stressed, flat rhythm, words run together, endings dropped, sentences that wander. Every drill here targets intelligibility and confidence. Your accent stays yours.

**Why a pronunciation respelling instead of phonetic symbols.** Most learners cannot read the International Phonetic Alphabet, and a book you cannot use is worthless. So sounds are written in plain letters (*thin* = tongue between the teeth, *ship* versus *sheep*) and the stressed syllable is written in CAPITALS: *phoTOgrapher*, *DEvelop*, *imPORTant*. The key is on page 5. If you already read phonetic symbols, you lose nothing — the sounds are the same sounds.

**This is a workbook, not a reader.** Every day has a drill that must be done *out loud*. Reading about pronunciation silently produces no change whatsoever — your mouth learns by moving, and your ear learns by hearing you.

**On sources.** The course structure follows the sequence used by established teaching institutions (sounds and stress before rhythm, rhythm before fluency, fluency before performance) and the mother tongue influence framing used across Indian training practice. Sources and further reading are listed in Appendix H.

**Scope.** This book teaches speaking. It is not a stammering or speech-disorder treatment, and it is not an exam guide — though Stage 9 will help with the speaking sections of IELTS-style tests and with visa and placement interviews. If you have a suspected speech or hearing difficulty, see a speech-language pathologist alongside this practice.

---

Printable A4 workbook. Print double-sided at actual size.

# How to Use This Course

You already know more English than you can speak. That gap — between what you understand and what comes out of your mouth — is not a knowledge problem, so more grammar study will not close it. It closes with mouth practice, ear practice, and speaking when you are slightly nervous. This course is built entirely around that.

## THE SHAPE OF A DAY

|                              |                                                            |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Focus</b>                 | The single thing today changes about your speech.          |
| <b>Why it matters</b>        | Two minutes of reading. Why this costs you something now.  |
| <b>Learn</b>                 | The rule or sound, with the detail you need to apply it.   |
| <b>Instead of / Say this</b> | Side-by-side correction of the specific mistake.           |
| <b>Practice today</b>        | The drill. Out loud. Ten to twenty minutes.                |
| <b>Model sentences</b>       | Sentences to copy exactly until they are automatic.        |
| <b>Mother tongue trap</b>    | How your first language pulls you off target, and the fix. |
| <b>Journal</b>               | One line, in English, before you close the book.           |

## THE FIVE RULES THAT DECIDE WHETHER THIS WORKS

- 1. Speak every drill out loud.** Whispering and reading in your head train nothing. If you live somewhere you cannot speak freely, use a bathroom, a terrace, a bike ride, or a walk with earphones in so it looks like a call.
- 2. Record yourself every week.** Sixty seconds on your phone, same question every time. Your ear cannot hear your own mouth in real time — the recording is the only honest feedback you have, and it is free.
- 3. Use English with a human being every day.** One sentence counts. A shopkeeper, an auto driver, a colleague, a cousin. Ninety days of drills with no human contact produces a fluent reader, not a fluent speaker.
- 4. Do not translate from your mother tongue.** Translation is what makes you slow and makes your sentences sound wrong. Stage 6 trains you to build English from English chunks instead.
- 5. Repair, do not restart.** When you make a mistake mid-sentence, say the correct version and continue. Confident speakers correct and move on; hesitant speakers apologise and start again.

## IF YOU ARE SHORT ON TIME

Do the drill and skip the reading. Twelve minutes of speaking beats forty minutes of studying, every single day.

# The Pronunciation Key

Everything in this book uses ordinary letters. Learn these six conventions once and the whole course is readable.

## THE SIX CONVENTIONS

1. **CAPITALS mark the stressed syllable.** *imPORTant, DEvelop, phoTOgrapher, hosPItal*. Stress is the single biggest cause of “I could not follow him”, so it appears on almost every page.
2. **A sound is named by a common word.** The *ship* sound and the *sheep* sound. The *cot* sound and the *caught* sound. If you can say the word, you know the sound.
3. **The weak sound is written *uh*.** English reduces most unstressed vowels to a lazy *uh*: *aBOUT* is *uh-BOWT*, *supPORT* is *suh-PORT*. This one habit does more for your rhythm than anything else.
4. **Hyphens split syllables.** *com-FOR-tuh-bul*. Say each piece, then join them at speed.
5. **Bold marks the part being drilled.** In *de**velop***, the bold is where your attention goes.
6. **Nothing here is an accent instruction.** Keep your own voice; change only what stops people understanding you.

## THE EIGHT SOUNDS INDIAN SPEAKERS MOST OFTEN NEED

|                           |                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>v and w</b>            | <b>v</b> an / <b>w</b> ine. For <b>v</b> , top teeth touch bottom lip. For <b>w</b> , round the lips, teeth touch nothing. |
| <b>the two th</b>         | <b>thin</b> (air, no voice) and <b>this</b> (voiced). Tongue tip lightly between the teeth, not behind them.               |
| <b>t and d</b>            | <b>top</b> , <b>dog</b> . Tongue on the ridge just behind the top teeth, not curled back on the roof of the mouth.         |
| <b>p and f</b>            | <b>pan</b> / <b>fan</b> . For <b>f</b> , teeth on lip and let air hiss; no lip pop.                                        |
| <b>s and sh</b>           | <b>sip</b> / <b>ship</b> . <b>sh</b> is wider, with the tongue pulled back.                                                |
| <b>z</b>                  | <b>zoo</b> , <b>rose</b> , <b>his</b> . English uses <b>z</b> far more than the spelling suggests.                         |
| <b>the cat sound</b>      | <b>cat</b> , <b>bad</b> , <b>man</b> . Wider and flatter than the vowel in most Indian languages.                          |
| <b>uh, the weak sound</b> | <b>about</b> , <b>doctor</b> , <b>suffer</b> . The most common vowel in spoken English.                                    |

Every one of these gets a full day of its own in Stages Two and Three. This page is only so you can read the notation.

## Where You Are Now

Tick every statement that is true today. Be honest — nobody sees this, and an inflated score just wastes your next hundred days.

### TICK WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I can introduce myself for a full minute without preparing.
- ☐ I can speak on the phone in English without dreading it.
- ☐ People rarely ask me to repeat myself.
- ☐ I can tell a story about my weekend for two minutes.
- ☐ I can disagree with someone in English without going silent.
- ☐ I know which syllable is stressed in words like *comfortable* and *photographer*.
- ☐ I can hear the difference between *ship* and *sheep* when someone else says them.
- ☐ I use *a*, *an* and *the* without thinking about it.
- ☐ I can speak in a meeting of ten people.
- ☐ I can take a job interview in English and expect to do well.
- ☐ I think in English for at least part of the day.
- ☐ I can explain my work to someone outside my field, in English, in one minute.

### READ YOUR SCORE

#### 0 to 3 ticks

**Start at Day 1 and do not skip.** Your foundation is the sound system and basic patterns. Expect Stages One to Four to feel slow and to matter enormously. Give yourself extra days when a sound will not come.

#### 4 to 7 ticks

**Start at Day 1 anyway**, but move faster through Stage One. Your gap is usually rhythm, articles and confidence under pressure — Stages Four, Five and Nine are where your score will change.

#### 8 to 10 ticks

**Skim Stages One to Three for the sounds you personally fail** (record yourself first, Day 1), then work properly from Stage Four. Your remaining accent is fine; your remaining problem is precision and performance.

#### 11 or 12 ticks

**You do not need a beginner book.** Work Stages Four, Six, Eight, Nine and Ten in full, use the appendices as reference, and put your effort into Stage Ten's shadowing programme.

Whatever your score, do Day 1 today. The recording you make is the only way you will ever be able to prove to yourself that this worked.

# The Daily Twenty Minutes

A fixed routine removes the daily decision about what to do, which is where most self-study dies.

## THE ROUTINE

1. **Two minutes — warm up the mouth.** Say the day's sound ten times slowly, then ten times fast. Stretch your jaw, hum, and read one sentence aloud twice.
2. **Four minutes — read the day.** Focus, why, learn. Say every example aloud as you read it; never read an example silently.
3. **Ten minutes — do the drill.** Out loud, standing if you can. Record it whenever the day asks you to.
4. **Two minutes — use it with a human.** One real sentence to a real person, today, using what you just practised.
5. **Two minutes — journal in English.** One or two lines. Mistakes allowed and expected; this is practice, not an exam.

## WHAT YOU NEED

- **A phone**, for recording your voice and for listening practice.
- **Earphones.** Real listening practice needs them; laptop speakers hide exactly the sounds you are trying to hear.
- **A notebook** for the journal and the written drills.
- **A mirror**, for the sound days. Watching your own lips and teeth is how *v* and *w* finally separate.
- **A speaking partner, if possible.** A friend, a sibling, a colleague, an online partner. About a third of the drills are better with one; all of them work alone.

## WHERE TO FIND LISTENING MATERIAL FREE

You need natural English audio with transcripts for the shadowing work. Public broadcaster learning services, TED talks with transcripts, and any podcast that publishes a transcript all work. Choose speakers you would be happy to sound like, and choose material you would listen to anyway — interest beats prestige, because you will actually finish it.

## A WORD ABOUT FEELING EMBARRASSED

Practising sounds out loud feels ridiculous. Everyone who speaks excellent second-language English went through exactly this stage, usually alone in a room, feeling stupid. The embarrassment is not a sign that it is not working. It is the sign that it is.

# Contents

|                                                               |               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
| <b>How to Use This Course</b>                                 | <b>3</b>      |
| <b>The Pronunciation Key</b>                                  | <b>4</b>      |
| <b>Where You Are Now</b>                                      | <b>5</b>      |
| <b>The Daily Twenty Minutes</b>                               | <b>6</b>      |
| <b>Your 100-Day Tracker</b>                                   | <b>10</b>     |
| <br><b>Stage One · How English Actually Sounds</b>            | <br><b>11</b> |
| Day 1 · Record Your Baseline Today                            | 12            |
| Day 2 · English Has a Beat. Learn It.                         | 13            |
| Day 3 · Count the Syllables                                   | 14            |
| Day 4 · Put the Stress on the Right Syllable                  | 15            |
| Day 5 · The Weak Sound That Carries English                   | 16            |
| Day 6 · Finish Every Word                                     | 17            |
| Day 7 · Slow Down and Open Your Mouth                         | 18            |
| Day 8 · Speak in Chunks, Not Words                            | 19            |
| Day 9 · Stop Translating in Your Head                         | 20            |
| Day 10 · Repair, Do Not Restart                               | 21            |
| <i>Stage One Review</i>                                       | 22            |
| <br><b>Stage Two · The Consonants That Change Meaning</b>     | <br><b>23</b> |
| Day 11 · *V* and *W*: Two Different Sounds                    | 24            |
| Day 12 · The Two *TH* Sounds                                  | 25            |
| Day 13 · *T* and *D* Belong on the Ridge                      | 26            |
| Day 14 · *P* and *F*, *B* and *V*                             | 27            |
| Day 15 · The *S* Family: *S*, *SH*, *CH*, *J*                 | 28            |
| Day 16 · Voice the Ends: *S* Versus *Z*                       | 29            |
| Day 17 · Aspiration: The Puff of Air                          | 30            |
| Day 18 · Consonant Clusters Without Extra Vowels              | 31            |
| Day 19 · *L* and *R*, Light and Dark                          | 32            |
| Day 20 · Silent Letters and Words That Lie                    | 33            |
| <i>Stage Two Review</i>                                       | 34            |
| <br><b>Stage Three · Vowels: The Long and the Short of It</b> | <br><b>35</b> |
| Day 21 · *Ship* and *Sheep*                                   | 36            |
| Day 22 · *Full* and *Fool*                                    | 37            |
| Day 23 · *Bad* and *Bed*                                      | 38            |
| Day 24 · *Cot*, *Caught* and *Coat*                           | 39            |
| Day 25 · *Cut*, *Cart* and the Weak *Uh*                      | 40            |
| Day 26 · Diphthongs: Vowels That Move                         | 41            |
| Day 27 · The Vowels English Spells With *R*                   | 42            |
| Day 28 · Spelling Is Not Sound                                | 43            |
| Day 29 · The Pairs That Ruin Meetings                         | 44            |
| Day 30 · Vowel Length Before Voiced Endings                   | 45            |
| <i>Stage Three Review</i>                                     | 46            |

|                                                                      |           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Stage Four · Rhythm, Music and Connected Speech</b>               | <b>47</b> |
| Day 31 · Stress the Word That Matters                                | 48        |
| Day 32 · Weak Forms of the Small Words                               | 49        |
| Day 33 · Use Contractions                                            | 50        |
| Day 34 · Link Your Words Together                                    | 51        |
| Day 35 · The Sounds That Disappear                                   | 52        |
| Day 36 · Fall at the End of Statements                               | 53        |
| Day 37 · Rise for Questions and Politeness                           | 54        |
| Day 38 · Sounding Polite, Not Blunt                                  | 55        |
| Day 39 · Pause in the Right Places                                   | 56        |
| Day 40 · Your First Shadowing Session                                | 57        |
| <i>Stage Four Review</i>                                             | 58        |
| <b>Stage Five · The Grammar You Actually Speak</b>                   | <b>59</b> |
| Day 41 · *A*, *An*, *The*: The Article System                        | 60        |
| Day 42 · Stop Saying *I Am Having*                                   | 61        |
| Day 43 · *I Did* or *I Have Done*                                    | 62        |
| Day 44 · Ask Questions the English Way                               | 63        |
| Day 45 · The Prepositions Indian English Changes                     | 64        |
| Day 46 · Drop the *Isn't It*                                         | 65        |
| Day 47 · Modals: Sounding Sure, or Careful                           | 66        |
| Day 48 · Reporting What Others Said                                  | 67        |
| Day 49 · Words That Have No Plural                                   | 68        |
| Day 50 · The Dozen Errors That Mark You Most                         | 69        |
| <i>Stage Five Review</i>                                             | 70        |
| <b>Stage Six · Patterns and Chunks: Speaking Without Translating</b> | <b>71</b> |
| Day 51 · Twenty Patterns That Say Almost Anything                    | 72        |
| Day 52 · Giving an Opinion                                           | 73        |
| Day 53 · Agreeing and Disagreeing                                    | 74        |
| Day 54 · Explaining and Clarifying                                   | 75        |
| Day 55 · Describing and Comparing                                    | 76        |
| Day 56 · Cause, Effect and Sequence                                  | 77        |
| Day 57 · Softeners and Hedges                                        | 78        |
| Day 58 · Buying Time Without Fillers                                 | 79        |
| Day 59 · Numbers, Quantities and Trends                              | 80        |
| Day 60 · Questions That Keep It Going                                | 81        |
| <i>Stage Six Review</i>                                              | 82        |
| <b>Stage Seven · Everyday Conversation</b>                           | <b>83</b> |
| Day 61 · Greetings and Openings                                      | 84        |
| Day 62 · Small Talk That Does Not Stall                              | 85        |
| Day 63 · On the Phone                                                | 86        |
| Day 64 · Shops, Autos, Restaurants, Travel                           | 87        |
| Day 65 · Offices, Banks, Hospitals                                   | 88        |
| Day 66 · Telling a Story                                             | 89        |
| Day 67 · Talking About Family Clearly                                | 90        |
| Day 68 · Explaining India to Outsiders                               | 91        |
| Day 69 · Light Humour and Warmth                                     | 92        |
| Day 70 · Ending Well and Staying in Touch                            | 93        |



|                                                                        |            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <i>Stage Seven Review</i>                                              | 94         |
| <b>Stage Eight · English at Work</b>                                   | <b>95</b>  |
| Day 71 · Drop the Office Indianisms                                    | 96         |
| Day 72 · The Standup and the Status Update                             | 97         |
| Day 73 · Client Calls With Global Teams                                | 98         |
| Day 74 · Speaking Up in Meetings                                       | 99         |
| Day 75 · Asking for Help and Clarification                             | 100        |
| Day 76 · Feedback, Both Directions                                     | 101        |
| Day 77 · Saying No and Pushing Back                                    | 102        |
| Day 78 · Presenting to a Room                                          | 103        |
| Day 79 · Speech Versus Writing                                         | 104        |
| Day 80 · Talking to Seniors and Across Cultures                        | 105        |
| <i>Stage Eight Review</i>                                              | 106        |
| <b>Stage Nine · When It Counts: Interviews and High-Stakes English</b> | <b>107</b> |
| Day 81 · *Tell Me About Yourself*                                      | 108        |
| Day 82 · Six Stories in STAR Form                                      | 109        |
| Day 83 · Strengths, Weaknesses, Why You                                | 110        |
| Day 84 · Salary and Offer Conversations                                | 111        |
| Day 85 · Group Discussions                                             | 112        |
| Day 86 · The HR Round and Campus Placement                             | 113        |
| Day 87 · Visa and Consular Interviews                                  | 114        |
| Day 88 · Speaking Tests                                                | 115        |
| Day 89 · Introducing Yourself at Events                                | 116        |
| Day 90 · When You Go Blank                                             | 117        |
| <i>Stage Nine Review</i>                                               | 118        |
| <b>Stage Ten · Fluency, Polish and the Next Hundred Days</b>           | <b>119</b> |
| Day 91 · The Thirty-Day Shadowing Programme                            | 120        |
| Day 92 · Listening for Meaning, Not Words                              | 121        |
| Day 93 · Read Aloud Every Day                                          | 122        |
| Day 94 · Vocabulary That Comes Out of Your Mouth                       | 123        |
| Day 95 · Formal, Neutral and Casual                                    | 124        |
| Day 96 · Idioms and Phrasal Verbs, Carefully                           | 125        |
| Day 97 · The Fear That Stops Your Mouth                                | 126        |
| Day 98 · Measure Yourself Honestly                                     | 127        |
| Day 99 · Your Capstone: Speak for Five Minutes                         | 128        |
| Day 100 · Your Next Hundred Days                                       | 129        |
| <i>Stage Ten Review</i>                                                | 130        |
| <b>Appendices</b>                                                      | <b>131</b> |
| A. The Sound Drill Bank                                                | 131        |
| B. Mother Tongue Trap Tables                                           | 133        |
| C. Indianisms and International English                                | 136        |
| D. The Chunk Bank                                                      | 139        |
| E. Situation Scripts                                                   | 142        |
| F. Spoken Grammar Quick Reference                                      | 145        |
| G. The Practice Plan and Partner Guide                                 | 147        |
| H. Self-Assessment, Sources and Further Reading                        | 149        |

# Your 100-Day Tracker

Write the date in each box as you finish. Each row is one stage of the course.

|    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|-----|
| 1  | 2  | 3  | 4  | 5  | 6  | 7  | 8  | 9  | 10  |
| 11 | 12 | 13 | 14 | 15 | 16 | 17 | 18 | 19 | 20  |
| 21 | 22 | 23 | 24 | 25 | 26 | 27 | 28 | 29 | 30  |
| 31 | 32 | 33 | 34 | 35 | 36 | 37 | 38 | 39 | 40  |
| 41 | 42 | 43 | 44 | 45 | 46 | 47 | 48 | 49 | 50  |
| 51 | 52 | 53 | 54 | 55 | 56 | 57 | 58 | 59 | 60  |
| 61 | 62 | 63 | 64 | 65 | 66 | 67 | 68 | 69 | 70  |
| 71 | 72 | 73 | 74 | 75 | 76 | 77 | 78 | 79 | 80  |
| 81 | 82 | 83 | 84 | 85 | 86 | 87 | 88 | 89 | 90  |
| 91 | 92 | 93 | 94 | 95 | 96 | 97 | 98 | 99 | 100 |

## MY WEEKLY RECORDING LOG

Record the same sixty seconds every week: “Tell me about yourself and what you do.” Note the date and the one thing you hear that you want to fix.

---

---

---

---

---

---

---

---

*Missing a day is normal. Missing three in a row is the point where people quit — if it happens, do a five-minute version of the next day rather than trying to catch up.*

## PART ONE

---

# How English Actually Sounds

DAYS 1-10

Indian languages and English are built on different rhythms. Most Indian languages give every syllable roughly equal weight and time. English does the opposite: it stresses a few syllables hard and squashes the rest almost out of existence. That single difference causes most of the “sorry, could you repeat that?” moments — far more than any individual sound does. This stage rebuilds your rhythm, then adds four speaking habits that stop you freezing.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Hear and produce the difference between stressed and unstressed syllables.
- Put the stress on the right syllable in the words you use every day.
- Use the weak *uh* sound instead of giving every vowel full value.
- Finish the ends of your words so people stop mishearing you.
- Speak in chunks and repair your own mistakes without starting the sentence again.

## DAY 1

DAY 1 OF 100

## Record Your Baseline Today

*Focus:* Make the sixty-second recording you will compare with on Day 100.

You cannot hear your own English while you are speaking it. Your brain is busy making sentences, so it edits out what your mouth is actually doing. A recording removes that filter. It will be uncomfortable, and it is the single most useful thing you will do in this entire course, because on Day 100 it becomes proof instead of a feeling.

**LEARN**

- **One take, no script.** A prepared answer hides your real speaking. Speak as you would to a stranger who just asked.
- **Listen three times, for one thing each time.** First for speed. Second for word endings. Third for whether a listener could follow your point.
- **Write down what you hear, not what you feel.** “I said *actually* eleven times” is useful. “I sound terrible” is not.

**PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES**

1. Open the voice recorder on your phone. Answer this out loud for sixty seconds, in one take: “*Tell me about yourself and what you do.*”
2. Do not re-record it, however bad it feels. Save it in a folder called *Day 1*.
3. Play it back three times, once for each of the three focuses above. Write one line of notes per listen.
4. Count two things exactly: how many times you paused for more than two seconds, and how many times you used a filler such as *actually, basically, means, you know, na*.
5. Write the three things you most want to change by Day 100. Keep this page; you will use it in Stage Ten.

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

“My name is \_\_\_\_\_. I work as a \_\_\_\_\_ in \_\_\_\_\_, and right now I am working on \_\_\_\_\_.”

“The part of my job I enjoy most is \_\_\_\_\_, because \_\_\_\_\_.”

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

Almost everyone hates their first recording, and Indian learners often report hearing “too much accent.” Ignore the accent completely. Judge only three things: speed, word endings, and whether a stranger could follow you. Those are what this course changes.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

*Write three lines in English: what I heard, what surprised me, what I want to fix first.*

## DAY 2

DAY 2 OF 100

## English Has a Beat. Learn It.

*Focus:* Stress a few syllables hard and squash the rest.

Most Indian languages are syllable-timed: each syllable takes roughly the same time, like a steady drum. English is stress-timed: strong beats carry the meaning and everything between them gets compressed. When you give every syllable equal weight, English speakers lose the beat and stop being able to predict your words — which is what “hard to follow” actually means.

### LEARN

- **Content words get the beats.** Nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, question words, numbers. These are the words a listener needs.
- **Grammar words get squashed.** *a, an, the, of, to, for, is, are, was, can, and, that, in.* Say them quickly and quietly.
- **The number of beats stays similar, the number of syllables does not.** “I **WANT** to **GO** to the **MARKet**” has three beats however fast you say it.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Tap the table on each capitalised beat and say these slowly, squashing everything else: “I **NEED** a **CUP** of **TEA**.” “The **MEE**ting **STAR**ted at **NINE**.” “She **WORKS** in a **BANK** in **PUNe**.”
2. Say each one five times, keeping the taps evenly spaced. The unstressed words must get faster to fit.
3. Now take four sentences you say at work every day. Write them out and underline only the words a listener truly needs.
4. Say each one tapping the underlined words. Record two of them and check whether the beats are audible.
5. Compare: say one sentence with every syllable equal, then with the beats. Keep both recordings; the difference is the whole point of this stage.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I **SENT** the **RE**port to the **CLI**ent **YES**terday.”

“Can you **SEND** me the **FILE** be**FO**RE **LUNCH**?”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Speakers of Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Bengali, Hindi and Marathi all tend toward equal-weight syllables, for the same structural reason — it is how your first language works. This is not a personal flaw and it is not laziness. It is a rhythm habit, and rhythm habits respond very well to tapping drills.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which sentence sounded most different when I used the beats?*

## DAY 3

DAY 3 OF 100

## Count the Syllables

*Focus:* Say the right number of syllables, no more and no fewer.

Before you can stress the right syllable, you have to know how many there are. Indian speakers frequently add a syllable inside consonant clusters (*film* becoming *fil-um*, *school* becoming *is-kool*) or lose one in longer words. Both make a familiar word unrecognisable, which is why a listener stalls on a word you use correctly.

## LEARN

- **One vowel sound equals one syllable.** *Film* has one vowel sound, so one syllable, however hard the *lm* feels.
- **Clusters are single units.** *st*, *sk*, *sp*, *pl*, *str*, *ks* are one movement of the mouth, not two syllables. Practise them slowly at first, never by inserting a vowel.
- **Long words lose syllables in normal speech.** *Comfortable* is usually three (*COMF-tuh-bul*), *vegetable* three (*VEJ-tuh-bul*), *every* two (*EV-ree*). Saying all the written syllables sounds over-careful.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*fil-um*, *fil-am* (2 syllables)

**film** — one syllable, ending *lm* together

*is-kool*, *is-tudy*

**school**, **study** — start with *sk*, *st*; no vowel before it

*cric-ket-uh*, *thanks-uh*

**cricket**, **thanks** — stop cleanly, no extra vowel at the end

*com-for-ta-ble* (4)

**COMF-tuh-bul** (3)

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Clap once per syllable and say: *film* (1), *school* (1), *strength* (1), *sixth* (1), *asked* (1), *world* (1).
2. Now the trap words: *sports*, *sprint*, *screen*, *glimpse*, *months*, *texts*. One clap each. Say each ten times slowly.
3. Practise the compressed long words: *COMF-tuh-bul*, *VEJ-tuh-bul*, *EV-ree*, *IN-tres-ting*, *BIZ-nis*, *FAM-lee*, *CHOC-lit*.
4. Read this aloud five times, clapping the syllables: "The school sports team asked for six months of practice."
5. Record it. Listen for any extra vowel you have inserted; that is the habit to break.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I watched the cricket match on the big screen at school."

"It is an interesting business, and the family runs it."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Inserting a vowel to break up clusters is standard in Hindi, Punjabi, Gujarati, Bengali and Marathi speech, because those clusters do not exist in the same positions in those languages. Fix it by slowing down and holding the two consonants together, not by speeding up.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which cluster words do I add a vowel to? List three.

## DAY 4

DAY 4 OF 100

## Put the Stress on the Right Syllable

*Focus:* Learn the stress of the two hundred words you use most.

Stressing the wrong syllable is the fastest way to be misunderstood — faster than any consonant error. English listeners identify words largely by their stress shape, so *deVELOpment* said as *DEvelopment* can genuinely fail to register. The good news: stress is a fact you can look up and memorise, like spelling.

### LEARN

- **Two-syllable nouns usually stress the first; verbs the second.** *RE-cord* (the thing) but *re-CORD* (the action). Same for *PRE-sent* / *pre-SENT*, *OB-ject* / *ob-JECT*.
- **Words ending in *-tion*, *-sion*, *-ic*, *-ical*, *-ity* stress the syllable just before the ending.** *inforMAtion*, *deCIision*, *ecoNOmic*, *poLIitical*, *respons-iBility*.
- **Look it up once, then drill it.** Any dictionary app marks stress. One minute of checking prevents years of a wrong habit.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*DEvelopment*

**deVELOpment**

*PERcentage*

**perCENTage**

*COMputer*

**comPUter**

*ENgineer*

**engiNEER**

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say these ten times each, exaggerating the capital: *imPORTant*, *deVELOp*, *comPUter*, *engiNEER*, *inforMAtion*, *deCIision*, *respONSible*, *ecoNOmic*, *oppoRTUnity*, *exPERience*.
2. Write the twenty words you say most at work. Look up the stress of each in a dictionary app that shows it.
3. Mark the stressed syllable in CAPITALS in your notebook, then say each word five times.
4. Test yourself on the noun-verb pairs: *RE-cord* / *re-CORD*, *PRE-sent* / *pre-SENT*, *IN-crease* / *in-CREASE*, *PER-mit* / *per-MIT*. Use each in a sentence.
5. Record yourself saying your twenty work words. Check three against the dictionary; if any is wrong, drill it twenty times today.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“It is an *imPORTant* *oppoRTUnity* for the whole *deVELOpment* team.”

“I need to *preSENT* the *PREsent* figures to the *comMITtee*.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Tamil and Malayalam speakers often place stress on the first syllable regardless of the English pattern; Telugu and Odia speakers may lengthen the last syllable instead. Both produce a flat or oddly-shaped word. Drill with the capitals exaggerated — over-doing it in practice produces the right amount in real speech.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which three words had I been stressing wrongly for years?*

## DAY 5

DAY 5 OF 100

# The Weak Sound That Carries English

*Focus:* Replace unstressed vowels with a lazy *uh*.

The most common vowel sound in spoken English is not written anywhere: it is the weak *uh* that unstressed syllables collapse into. *About* is *uh-BOWT*. *Doctor* is *DOC-tuh*. *Support* is *suh-PORT*. If you give unstressed vowels their full spelling value, your English sounds heavy and effortful even when every word is correct.

## LEARN

- **Any unstressed vowel can become *uh***, whatever the spelling: the *a* in *about*, the *o* in *doctor*, the *e* in *problem*, the *u* in *suppose*, the *io* in *fashion*.
- **This is not sloppiness.** It is how careful, educated English speakers speak, including newsreaders. Full-value vowels are the marked, unnatural version.
- **The stressed syllable gets *more value in exchange*.** You are not weakening the word; you are moving its energy to one place.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*a-BOU*T, with a full *a*

**uh-BOWT**

*DOC-tor*, with a full *o*

**DOC-tuh**

*sup-PORT*, with a full *u*

**suh-PORT**

*PROB-lem*, with a full *e*

**PROB-luhm**

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each of these five times, deliberately making the unstressed part lazy: *uh-BOWT*, *uh-GEN* (again), *suh-PORT*, *PROB-luhm*, *DOC-tuh*, *TEE-chuh* (teacher), *BAN-uh-nuh* (banana), *FOTuh-graf* (photograph).
2. Say the pair out loud and hear the difference: full-value *ba-na-na*, then English *buh-NAH-nuh*.
3. Take the twenty work words from yesterday. Mark the stressed syllable, then write *uh* over every unstressed vowel you can weaken.
4. Read this five times: "The doctor asked about the problem and supported our decision." Weaken every unstressed syllable.
5. Record it. If it sounds slightly casual to you, you are doing it right.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I was *uh-BOWT* to call the *DOC-tuh uh-BOWT* the report."

"We need *suh-PORT* from the manager *buh-FORE* Friday."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Indian language writing systems mostly say what they mean: each written vowel is pronounced. That habit transfers straight into English, where it is wrong roughly half the time. Expect this to feel like "not speaking properly" for about a week. It is the opposite.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Write three words where I have been giving an unstressed vowel too much value.



## DAY 6

DAY 6 OF 100

## Finish Every Word

Focus: Say the final consonant, especially *s*, *t*, *d* and *ed*.

Dropped endings are one of the biggest causes of misunderstanding, because in English the ending often carries the grammar. *He work* and *he works*, *I walk* and *I walked*, *book* and *books* differ only at the end. When endings disappear, listeners have to guess your tense and number, and you sound less educated than you are.

## LEARN

- **The -ed ending has three sounds.** *t* after unvoiced sounds (*asked* = *askt*, *stopped* = *stopt*); *d* after voiced (*called* = *calld*); *id* only after *t* or *d* (*wanted* = *WON-tid*, *needed* = *NEE-did*).
- **The -s ending has two.** *s* after unvoiced (*books*, *stops*); *z* after voiced (*jobs* = *jobz*, *files* = *filez*, *comes* = *cumz*).
- **A final consonant need not be loud, but it must exist.** Touch the position and release lightly; do not add a vowel after it.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*He work in Delhi*

**He works** in Delhi (*works* with a clear *s*)

*I finish it yesterday*

**I finished it** yesterday (*finisht*)

*Two file are missing*

**Two files** are missing (*filez*)

*I have complete the task*

**I have completed** the task (*com-PLIE-tid*)

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each group ten times, exaggerating the ending: *askt*, *stopt*, *workt*, *helpt* — *calld*, *playd*, *cleand*, *arrivd* — *WON-tid*, *NEE-did*, *star-tid*, *deci-did*.
2. Then the plurals: *books*, *stops*, *cats* (*s* sound) and *jobs*, *files*, *comes*, *names* (*z* sound).
3. Read aloud five times: "I finished the work, called the client, and sent three files." Every ending audible.
4. Record thirty seconds about your day yesterday, using past tense throughout. Play it back and count the endings you dropped.
5. Pick your worst three verbs and say each in a full past-tense sentence ten times.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I callD the client and finishT the report yesterday."

"She workS in Chennai and handleS two accountS."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many Indian languages do not end words in these consonant sounds, so the mouth simply stops early. The commonest results are a missing third-person *s* and a missing past tense — both of which listeners notice immediately. Slow down at the end of the word rather than at the start.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which ending do I drop most: the *s*, the *ed*, or both?

## DAY 7

DAY 7 OF 100

## Slow Down and Open Your Mouth

*Focus:* Speak more slowly and move your lips and jaw more.

Nervous speakers speed up, and speed plus a closed mouth equals mumbling in any language. Indian English is often spoken fast with limited lip movement, which blurs exactly the sounds listeners depend on. Slowing down by a fifth and opening your mouth more will improve your intelligibility today, before you learn a single new sound.

### LEARN

- **Speed is not fluency.** Fluency is smoothness and the right stress. Fast, flat speech is the least fluent-sounding thing you can do.
- **Aim for around 130 to 150 words a minute.** That is about 25 words in ten seconds. Anything above 180 is where clarity collapses.
- **Open the jaw on the stressed syllable.** English vowels need more mouth space than the equivalents in most Indian languages.
- **Pause at full stops, and breathe there.** If you can say four sentences on one breath, you are rushing.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Read any 150-word paragraph aloud while timing yourself. Sixty seconds is the target; note your actual time.
2. Read it again twenty percent slower, breathing at every full stop, and opening your mouth wider on every capitalised beat.
3. Do the mirror check: read four sentences watching your lips. If they barely move, exaggerate until they do.
4. Speak for sixty seconds about your morning, deliberately slowly. Record it and count the words; adjust until you land near 140.
5. In one real conversation today, slow your first two sentences on purpose.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Let me explain the whole thing slowly, so nothing gets missed.”

“Give me one minute — I want to say this properly.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many learners speak fast on purpose, believing speed proves fluency and hides a weak accent. It does the reverse: speed amplifies every unclear sound and removes the listener's processing time. Confident speakers are slower than nervous ones, in every language.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*How many words per minute was I? What happened when I slowed down?*

## DAY 8

DAY 8 OF 100

## Speak in Chunks, Not Words

*Focus:* Build sentences from ready-made word groups.

Fluent speakers do not assemble sentences one word at a time. They use stored blocks — *to be honest, as far as I know, the thing is, I was about to say* — and slot content into them. This is why they sound smooth and why they can think and talk simultaneously. Learning chunks instead of single words is the fastest route to fluency that exists.

### LEARN

- **A chunk is a group of words you say as one unit**, with one stress pattern. *I was going to* is four written words and one spoken movement.
- **Chunks buy you thinking time legitimately.** While your mouth says *the thing is*, your brain finds the content. That is not filler; that is how fluency works.
- **Learn verbs with their partners.** Not *decision* alone but *take a decision, make a decision, reach a decision*. Not *interested* but *interested in*.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Learn these ten chunks by heart, saying each five times as one smooth unit: *to be honest · as far as I know · the thing is · I was about to · what I mean is · it depends on · I would say that · the reason is · in that case · as I said earlier*.
2. Use each one in a sentence about your own work, out loud.
3. Take one paragraph of anything you read today. Underline every group of words that travels together.
4. Speak for one minute on “my work this week” using at least five of the ten chunks. Record it.
5. Start a chunk page in your notebook. Add three chunks a day for the rest of this course; by Day 100 you will have nearly three hundred.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*To be honest, the thing is, we are still waiting for approval.*”

“*As far as I know, it depends on the client. I would say Friday at the earliest.*”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

If you learn isolated words from a vocabulary list, you will produce combinations that are grammatically correct but that nobody says — the main reason otherwise-strong Indian English sounds translated. Always record the words that come with a new word.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which chunk felt most natural? Write two sentences using it.*

## DAY 9

DAY 9 OF 100

## Stop Translating in Your Head

*Focus:* Build the sentence in English from the start.

If you compose in your mother tongue and translate, you pay twice: once in delay, once in word order that sounds foreign. Most Indian languages put the verb at the end and mark things differently, so a translated sentence arrives late and slightly wrong. Thinking directly in English is trainable, and it starts with very short sentences.

### LEARN

- **Short sentences first.** You cannot think directly in English in long sentences yet. Four to eight words, one idea, full stop. Then the next one.
- **Fix the English word order:** subject, verb, object. *I sent the file.* Your first language may allow other orders; English is strict about this one.
- **Name things in English silently all day.** Walking, eating, commuting: *the bus is late, this tea is too sweet, I need to reply to that message.* Free practice, zero risk.
- **Accept simpler content.** Saying something simple in fluent English beats saying something clever in broken English. You will get the clever version back later.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Spend ten minutes narrating your own actions silently in English. Every time a word does not come, use a simpler one and continue — do not stop to look it up.
2. Then narrate five minutes out loud, alone: what you are doing, seeing, deciding.
3. Practise the short-sentence habit: describe your route to work in ten sentences of under eight words each.
4. When a word is missing, use the workaround out loud: *“the thing you use to \_\_\_\_”* or *“I do not know the word — it is like a \_\_\_\_.”*
5. Note the five words you kept needing and did not have. Look them up now; those are your real vocabulary needs, unlike any list in a book.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I do not know the English word for it. It is the thing you use to open a tin.”

“Let me say it in a simpler way. We are late. The client knows. I will fix the date.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Hindi, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Marathi and Gujarati all place the verb near the end of the sentence. Translating keeps that shape and produces sentences like *“I office going”* or *“this file I have sent already.”* Say the subject, then the verb, immediately, before you know how the sentence ends.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which five words did I need today and not have?*

## DAY 10

DAY 10 OF 100

## Repair, Do Not Restart

*Focus:* Correct yourself mid-sentence and keep going.

The habit that most marks a hesitant speaker is not making mistakes; it is stopping, apologising and starting the sentence again. Native speakers make errors constantly and simply repair them on the move. Learning to repair is what turns your accuracy work into actual fluency, and it removes most of the fear of speaking.

### LEARN

- **Say the correct version and continue.** “She go — she goes to Bangalore on Mondays.” No apology, no restart.
- **Never say sorry for your English.** Apologising tells the listener to expect problems and makes them evaluate you instead of listening.
- **Have three repair phrases ready:** *what I mean is, let me put it another way, sorry, I will say that again more clearly.* Use them for meaning, not for guilt.
- **Finish the sentence even when it goes wrong.** An imperfect finished sentence communicates; an abandoned perfect one does not.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Sorry, my English is not good...*

**“Let me put that another way.”**

*Sorry sorry, I mean, actually, no...*

**“What I mean is \_\_\_\_.”**

*Stopping and starting the sentence over*

Saying the corrected word and continuing

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Speak for two minutes on any topic with one rule: you may not stop or restart. Repair on the move and continue. Record it.
2. Practise the repair out loud ten times: “He don’t — he doesn’t have the file.” “I am working here since — I have been working here since 2021.”
3. Learn the three repair phrases by heart. Say each five times.
4. Ban the apology for one week starting today. Every time you feel it coming, use a repair phrase instead.
5. In one real conversation today, deliberately repair a mistake without apologising, and notice that nothing bad happens.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“We was — we were planning to launch in June.”

“What I mean is, the delay is on our side, not theirs.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many Indian learners have been corrected harshly at school or work and have learned to fear the mistake more than the silence. That fear is the actual thing holding your speaking back — more than grammar, sounds or vocabulary. Repairing in public is how you unlearn it.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Where did I apologise for my English today? What could I have said instead?*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage One Review

You have the foundation now: the beat of English, syllable counts, word stress, the weak *uh*, finished endings, a workable speed, chunks instead of words, thinking in English, and repair instead of restart. Nothing here is advanced, and everything above it depends on these.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I have a Day 1 recording saved and I have listened to it three times.
- ☐ I can tap the beats of a sentence and squash the words in between.
- ☐ I say *film* and *school* with one syllable and no extra vowel.
- ☐ I have checked and drilled the stress of at least twenty words I use daily.
- ☐ I use the weak *uh* in *about*, *doctor*, *support*, *problem*.
- ☐ My -s and -ed endings are audible when I speak carefully.
- ☐ I speak at roughly 140 words a minute, not 190.
- ☐ I know ten chunks by heart and use them.
- ☐ I have narrated ten minutes of my own day silently in English.
- ☐ I repaired a mistake without apologising for my English.

## RECORDING TEST

Record ninety seconds describing what you did yesterday, in the past tense. Then listen with a pen and mark four things: every dropped ending, every wrongly stressed word, every place you restarted a sentence, and your words per minute. Write the four counts down. You will repeat this exact test at every stage review, and these numbers are your progress.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Rhythm and beats

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Word stress accuracy

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Word endings

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Speed and mouth movement

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Repairing without stopping

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If the rhythm work will not click, do only the tapping drill for five minutes a day for a week before moving on. It is the load-bearing skill of this whole book, and everything in Stages Two to Four gets easier once the beat is in your body.

## PART TWO

---

# The Consonants That Change Meaning

DAYS 11-20

Not all pronunciation errors matter. Some are simply your accent and you should keep them. Others change one word into a different word, and those are worth ten days of your life. This stage covers only the consonants where an Indian speaker's habit can genuinely produce the wrong word: *v* and *w*, the two *th* sounds, *t* and *d*, *p* and *f*, the *s* family, final voicing, aspiration, clusters and the two *l* sounds. Each day is one sound, a mirror, and repetition.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Produce *v* and *w* as two clearly different sounds, on demand.
- Say both *th* sounds with the tongue between the teeth.
- Make *t* and *d* on the ridge behind your teeth instead of curled back.
- Separate *p* from *f*, *b* from *v*, and *s* from *sh*.
- Say consonant clusters without inserting an extra vowel.

## DAY 11

DAY 11 OF 100

**V and W: Two Different Sounds**

*Focus:* Teeth on lip for *v*; round lips and no teeth for *w*.

Most Indian languages have one sound where English has two, so *vest* and *west*, *vine* and *wine*, *very* and *wary* collapse into one. This is the most recognised Indian English feature worldwide and it genuinely causes confusion in names, addresses and spellings on calls. It is also one of the easiest to fix, because you can see it in a mirror.

**LEARN**

- **For *v*:** top teeth touch the bottom lip and the sound buzzes through. You should feel vibration in your lip. It is a continuous sound, not a tap.
- **For *w*:** push your lips forward into a small circle, as if starting to whistle or blow out a candle. Teeth touch nothing at all.
- **Use the mirror, not your ear.** Your ear cannot yet tell them apart, which is why they merged. Your eyes can: teeth visible on the lip, or lips rounded.

**INSTEAD OF****SAY THIS***very good, visit, wote***very** good, **visit**, **vote** (teeth on lip)*vater, ve will, wait***water**, **we** will, **wait** (rounded lips)*advice, newer (never)***advice**, **never***Wijay, Vednesday***Vijay**, **Wednesday****PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES**

1. In front of a mirror, say *v-v-v-v-v* for five seconds, watching your top teeth rest on your bottom lip. Then *w-w-w-w-w* with rounded lips and no teeth. Alternate ten times.
2. Say these pairs twenty times, checking the mirror on every word: *vest / west, vine / wine, veal / wheel, vary / wary, verse / worse, vet / wet*.
3. Now words with both: *we have, very well, we visit, will she vote, twelve winners, vivid winter*. Ten times each, slowly.
4. Read aloud five times: "We will visit the vendor on Wednesday, and Vijay will wait with the van."
5. Record it. Play it back and mark every word where the two sounds swapped. Drill those five words twenty times each.

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

"We have twelve vacancies, and we will review every application."

"Vijay went to the village on Wednesday with the white van."

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

Hindi, Marathi, Gujarati, Punjabi, Telugu and Kannada speakers usually merge the two toward a single sound made with a light lip contact. Bengali speakers face a different version of the problem: *v* often becomes *b* (*bery* for *very*), so pair today's drill with Day 14.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

*Which words with *v* or *w* do I use daily? Write five and mark which sound each needs.*



## DAY 12

DAY 12 OF 100

The Two *TH* Sounds

*Focus:* Tongue tip lightly between the teeth, not behind them.

No Indian language has the English *th*, so it is usually replaced by a *t* or *d* made behind the teeth. That turns *think* into *tink*, *three* into *tree*, and *they* into *day*. The sound appears in the most common words in the language — *the, this, that, they, there, think, thing, three* — so the substitution shows up several times per sentence.

## LEARN

- **Unvoiced *th* (as in *think, three, both, mouth*):** tongue tip just touching or slightly past the teeth, push air out, no voice. It should feel breathy and slightly silly.
- **Voiced *th* (as in *this, they, mother, other*):** same tongue position, now add voice. You will feel buzzing on your tongue tip.
- **Exaggerate in practice.** Let your tongue stick out visibly during drills. In real speech it becomes a small movement, but only after the big one is learned.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*tink, tree (for three), tanks***think, three, thanks***dis, dat, dey, dere***this, that, they, there***wid, bot (for both)***with, both***mudder, broder***mother, brother**

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Mirror: put your tongue tip between your teeth and blow. Hold *thhhhh* for five seconds. Then add voice for *thhhhh* as in *this*. Ten times each.
2. Unvoiced set, twenty times: *think, thing, three, thirty, thousand, thank you, both, month, mouth, health*.
3. Voiced set, twenty times: *this, that, these, those, they, there, then, mother, brother, other, weather, together*.
4. Minimal pairs, ten times each: *think / tink, three / tree, thin / tin, they / day, then / den, breathe / breed*.
5. Read aloud five times, tongue visible: "I think these three things are worth thirty thousand rupees, and both of them agree with that." Record and check.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"Thank you — I think this is the third time this month."

"My mother and my brother both live there together."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Tamil, Malayalam, Telugu and Kannada speakers often replace *th* with a dental *t* that is very close, which is why nobody corrected you; Hindi and Bengali speakers often use *t/d* or the aspirated *th* of their own script, which is a different sound entirely. In all cases the fix is identical: tongue *between* the teeth.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Count how many *th* words you said in one minute of speaking. Which ones came out as *t* or *d*?

## DAY 13

DAY 13 OF 100

**T and D Belong on the Ridge**

*Focus:* Touch the ridge behind your top teeth, not the roof of your mouth.

This single habit is the strongest marker of an Indian accent to foreign ears, and the most common reported cause of “I could not understand him” on international calls. Indian languages have retroflex *t* and *d*, made by curling the tongue back to the roof of the mouth. English uses a flatter sound made further forward, on the small ridge behind your top teeth.

**LEARN**

- **Find the ridge.** Run your tongue tip back from your top teeth; the small bump immediately behind them is the alveolar ridge. Every English *t*, *d*, *n*, *l*, *s* and *z* is made there.
- **Do not curl the tongue back.** If the tongue tip goes up to the dome of your palate, you are making the Indian retroflex sound. Keep it forward and flat.
- **Practise the contrast deliberately.** Say a retroflex *t*, then the English *t*, alternating. Feeling the difference is more than half the work.

**PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES**

1. Tongue on the ridge, say *t-t-t-t-t* then *d-d-d-d-d*, twenty times each. Keep the tip forward, almost touching your teeth.
2. Words with *t* and *d*, ten times each: *time, table, take, ten, today, better, water, letter, matter, city* — *day, dark, door, decide, medium, ready, order, model*.
3. Alternate a retroflex version and an English version of *ta / da* ten times so you can feel exactly where each is made.
4. Read aloud five times: “The letter arrived today, and I told the director to order better water bottles.”
5. Record and listen for the *t* in *better, water, letter, city*. This is the sound to keep working on for the next month.

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

“I told the director I would send the letter today.”

“It took a little time to get the data ready.”

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

Retroflex *t* and *d* exist in nearly every Indian language, so this affects everyone equally, from Punjab to Kerala. It is also the change that most reduces listener effort abroad, which makes it the highest-value ten minutes in this stage. Do not expect it in one day; expect it in a month.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

*Can I feel the difference between the two positions? Which words still curl back?*

## DAY 14

DAY 14 OF 100

**P and F, B and V**

*Focus:* Teeth on lip for *f* and *v*; lips together for *p* and *b*.

*P* and *F* are made in completely different places, but many speakers substitute one for the other, turning *fan* into *pan* and *coffee* into *coppee*. The *b/v* swap does the same to *best* and *vest*. These pairs matter because they change everyday words, including names and email addresses read out over the phone.

**LEARN**

- For ***f* and *v***, the top teeth touch the bottom lip and air passes through continuously. *F* has no voice; *v* buzzes.
- For ***p* and *b***, both lips press together and release with a small pop. Nothing touches the teeth.
- **Watch your own mouth.** In the mirror, *f* and *v* show your teeth on your lip. If you see two lips meeting, you are making *p* or *b*.

**INSTEAD OF****SAY THIS***coppee, pone (phone), pood***coffee, phone, food***bery good, bisit, adbice***very good, visit, advice***pull (for full), pace (for face)***full, face***ebery, nebber***every, never****PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES**

1. Mirror: alternate *f-f-f* (teeth on lip) and *p-p-p* (lips together) twenty times. Then *v-v-v* and *b-b-b* twenty times.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *fan / pan, fine / pine, coffee / copy, four / pour, face / pace* — *vest / best, van / ban, very / berry, vote / boat*.
3. Words with both, slowly: *perfect, powerful, beautiful, favourite, September, offer, before, after, difficult*.
4. Read aloud five times: "I prefer coffee before the phone call, and every fine offer is verified first."
5. Record it and mark any swap. Drill each swapped word twenty times.

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

| "Please confirm the phone number before Friday."

| "Very few of the offers are verified, but every file is complete."

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

The *b-for-v* substitution is strongly associated with Bengali and Assamese speakers, whose languages lack *v* entirely; *p-for-f* appears among speakers of several languages where *f* is not native and enters only through loanwords. If both apply to you, drill *f/v* first — they share the same mouth position.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

Which pair is my real problem: *p/f*, *b/v*, or both?

## DAY 15

DAY 15 OF 100

## The S Family: S, SH, CH, J

*Focus:* Separate four sounds that sit close together in the mouth.

S, sh, ch and j are made in nearby positions, and many speakers merge two of them: *sip* and *ship*, *chair* and *share*, *jam* and *zam*. In some regions s becomes ch before certain vowels, and in others sh becomes s. The result is words that sound almost right, which is worse for a listener than words that sound clearly wrong.

## LEARN

- **S:** tongue near the ridge, narrow channel, thin hiss. Like a small leak of air.
- **SH:** tongue pulled slightly back, lips a little rounded, wider and lower hiss.
- **CH** is a t plus sh released together as one push; **J** (as in *June*) is a d plus the buzzy version of sh.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*ship when you mean sip*

**sip** (thin, narrow hiss)

*sare / chare for share*

**share** (wide hiss, rounded lips)

*jero, zero confusion; yob for job*

**job, June, journey** with a firm j

*eshpecially, ishtudy*

**especially, study** (clean s plus t)

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each sound alone for five seconds: sssss, shhhhh, ch-ch-ch, j-j-j. Note how your tongue moves back from s to sh.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *sip / ship, said / shed, sort / short, seat / sheet, sock / shock* — *chair / share, cheap / sheep, watch / wash, chin / shin*.
3. J words, ten times: *job, June, journey, judge, manager, message, project, village, knowledge, arrange*.
4. Read aloud five times: "She should share the short list, especially the project manager's message."
5. Record and check the four sounds separately. Drill whichever two merged.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"She will share the short summary of the project in June."

"The manager sent a message about the change in the schedule."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Bengali speakers often move s toward sh (*shix* for *six*), which is a systematic feature of the language, not carelessness. Some Tamil and Telugu speakers insert a short vowel before initial s clusters (*ishtudy*). Both are fixed by starting the word from the consonant with no run-up.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Record ten s and sh words. Which two sounds do I merge?

## DAY 16

DAY 16 OF 100

## Voice the Ends: S Versus Z

*Focus:* Use the buzzing z where English requires it.

English uses the z sound far more than the spelling suggests: *rose, is, was, has, jobs, files, names, uses* all end in a buzz, not a hiss. Many Indian speakers use a clean s everywhere, which is intelligible but immediately marks the speech as non-native, and occasionally changes meaning (*price* against *prize*).

## LEARN

- **Same mouth position, voice added.** Say sssss, then switch on your voice without moving your tongue. That buzz is z.
- **The rule for plural and verb -s:** after a voiced sound, it is z (*jobz, filez, namez, comez, needz*). After an unvoiced sound, it stays s (*books, stops, cats*).
- **Common z words hide behind an s spelling:** *is, was, has, does, rose, nose, easy, busy, music, husband, reason, present, choose, use*.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*jobss, filess, namess with a hiss*

**jobz, filez, namez**

*iss, wass, hass*

**iz, woz, haz**

*bissy, eassy, mussic*

**bizzy, eezy, myoozic**

*prize and price said the same*

**prize** with a buzz, **price** with a hiss

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Hold sssss then zzzzz for five seconds each, five times, feeling the vibration switch on and off.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *price / prize, ice / eyes, bus / buzz, place / plays, race / raise, loss / laws*.
3. Plural drill: say *books, cats, stops* (hiss) then *jobs, files, names, dogs, plans, ideas* (buzz). Ten times each set.
4. Read aloud five times: "He is busy because his job needs these files and those names by Tuesday."
5. Record and count how many z sounds you produced as s.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"He is busy, so his colleagues chose these five names."

"The prize is bigger than the price of the ticket."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Most Indian languages have the z sound only in loanwords, or replace it with j (*jero* for *zero*, *jip* for *zip*). Watch for both errors in yourself: replacing z with s, and replacing z with j. They need different fixes — the first needs voicing, the second needs a continuous, non-stopping airflow.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

List five words I say with s that should have a z.

## DAY 17

DAY 17 OF 100

## Aspiration: The Puff of Air

*Focus:* Put a small puff after *p*, *t* and *k* at the start of stressed syllables.

In English, *p*, *t* and *k* at the beginning of a stressed syllable come with a small breath of air: *pot*, *top*, *come*. Without it, English listeners often hear *b*, *d* and *g* instead — so *pot* becomes *bot* and *coat* becomes *goat*. Indian languages have aspiration too, but distributed by different rules, so it lands in the wrong places.

### LEARN

- **Test with paper.** Hold a thin sheet of paper in front of your mouth and say *pot*. The paper should move. Say *spot* and it should barely move.
- **Aspirate at the start of a stressed syllable**, not everywhere: *toDAY* has a puff on the second *t* of *today*, and *STOP* has almost none after the *s*.
- **Do not over-aspirate in the middle or end.** A heavy puff on every *t* sounds theatrical and tiring to listen to.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Hold a sheet of paper and say ten times each, making it move: *pot*, *pen*, *park*, *pay*, *top*, *time*, *take*, *tell*, *come*, *key*, *car*, *call*.
2. Now the contrast where there is little puff: *spot*, *stop*, *sky*, *speak*, *star*. The paper should hardly move.
3. Pairs, ten times each: *pot* / *bot*, *pin* / *bin*, *tie* / *die*, *town* / *down*, *coat* / *goat*, *cold* / *gold*.
4. Read aloud five times: "Please take the paper copy to the park at ten past two."
5. Record and check whether your *p*, *t* and *k* could be mistaken for *b*, *d* and *g*.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

| "Please call the client and confirm the time."

| "I took the papers to the terrace at two."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Speakers of Tamil, Malayalam, Telugu and Kannada often under-aspirate initial stops, because their languages do not use aspiration to separate words. Speakers of Hindi, Bengali, Punjabi and Marathi have aspirated letters in their alphabets but apply them by their own rules. The paper test works for everyone.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Did the paper move on pot and stay still on spot?*

## DAY 18

DAY 18 OF 100

## Consonant Clusters Without Extra Vowels

*Focus:* Say two or three consonants together with nothing between them.

English piles consonants together at the start and end of words: *street*, *sixths*, *asked*, *world*, *films*, *texts*. Most Indian languages break such groups with a small vowel, giving *is-treet* and *fil-ums*. That extra syllable changes the shape of the word, and shape is what listeners use to recognise it.

### LEARN

- **Start the word on the consonant.** For *street*, begin with the *s* already hissing, then slide into *tr*. Do not begin with a vowel before it.
- **End clusters need each consonant touched, not released loudly.** In *asked* you need *sk* then a light *t*, with no vowel anywhere.
- **Slow is the fix, not fast.** Say the cluster in slow motion until the sequence is right, then speed up. Speeding up first is what inserts the vowel.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*is-tation, is-kool, is-treet*

**station, school, street**

*fil-um, for-um (form)*

**film, form**

*ask-ed as two syllables*

**askt, one syllable**

*six-ith, month-us*

**sixth, months**

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Initial clusters, ten times each: *street*, *strong*, *spring*, *school*, *speak*, *small*, *snake*, *plan*, *price*, *twelve*, *question*.
2. Final clusters, ten times each: *film*, *form*, *world*, *help*, *milk*, *asked*, *worked*, *next*, *text*, *months*, *sixth*, *strength*.
3. The hardest combination, twenty times slowly: *sixths*, *texts*, *strengths*, *twelfths*. Slow motion first.
4. Read aloud five times: "The school film about world sports lasted six months and twelve texts arrived."
5. Record and listen for inserted vowels. Any word where you hear one, drill twenty times slowly.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I asked the school for the strength of the whole team."

"The next text explains the world sports schedule."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

This is one of the most persistent Indian English habits and it affects almost every language group, because the syllable structure of Indian languages does not permit these clusters in the same positions. The cure is slow, deliberate repetition, not effort or willpower.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which three cluster words do I still break with a vowel?

## DAY 19

DAY 19 OF 100

## L and R, Light and Dark

*Focus:* Two versions of *l*, and an *r* that does not roll.

English has a light *l* at the start of words (*light, love*) and a dark, hollow *l* at the end (*full, people, well*), which many speakers replace with the light one. English *r* is also not rolled or tapped: it is a smooth, curled sound with no tongue contact. A rolled *r* is intelligible but it is the single most audible accent feature after retroflex *t*.

### LEARN

- **Light *l*:** tongue tip on the ridge, sound comes out around it. Used before vowels: *light, alive, believe*.
- **Dark *l*:** the tip still touches, but the back of the tongue lifts, giving a hollow *ul* quality. Used at the end and before consonants: *full, well, people, help, milk*.
- **English *r*:** curl or bunch the tongue slightly, close to the ridge but *touching nothing*, and round the lips a little. No roll, no tap, no flap.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*A rolled or tapped r in very, road*

A smooth non-touching *r*: *veh-ree, rrrroad* without the roll

*ful, wel, peepal with a light l*

**full, well, people** with a hollow dark *l*

*worl-ed, hel-ep*

**world, help** with no vowel inserted

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Light *l*, ten times: *light, love, let, list, later, believe, colleague, only*.
2. Dark *l*, ten times, exaggerating the hollow sound: *full, well, will, tell, people, table, little, milk, help, cool, school*.
3. For *r*: say *er* and hold it for five seconds, tongue touching nothing. Then *red, right, road, run, around, three, price, market*. Ten times each.
4. Read aloud five times: "The whole world will tell you that people prefer a really careful reply."
5. Record it and listen only to your *r*. If you hear a tap or roll, hold the *er* drill for a week.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"The whole team will be ready for the review on Friday."

"People really prefer a clear reply to a fast one."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

A tapped or trilled *r* is standard in most Indian languages and transfers directly. Whether to change it is genuinely your choice: it rarely causes misunderstanding, so it is a polish item rather than a clarity item. The dark *l*, by contrast, is worth fixing, because it affects very common words.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Can I hear the difference between my *l* in light and in full?



## DAY 20

DAY 20 OF 100

# Silent Letters and Words That Lie

*Focus:* Stop pronouncing letters that English does not say.

English spelling is not a reliable guide to English sound, and if you learned most of your English by reading — as the majority of Indian learners did — you will be pronouncing letters that native speakers do not. Saying the *b* in *doubt* or the *l* in *salmon* is a pure reading habit, and it is fixed in one day of listing.

## LEARN

- **Common silent letters:** *b* in *doubt, comb, climb*; *k* in *know, knife*; *w* in *write, wrong, answer*; *l* in *half, walk, could, salmon*; *t* in *listen, often, castle*; *h* in *hour, honest*.
- **Whole words that mislead:** *Wednesday* is *WENZ-day*; *February* is usually *FEB-you-ree*; *business* is *BIZ-nis*; *vegetable* is *VEJ-tuh-bul*; *chocolate* is *CHOK-lit*; *comfortable* is *COMF-tuh-bul*.
- **Check, do not guess.** Any dictionary app plays the word. Two seconds of listening beats a lifetime of a confident wrong version.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Wed-nes-day, Feb-ru-ary*

**WENZ-day, FEB-you-ree**

*ans-wer, lis-ten, ha-lf*

**AN-suh, LIS-un, haaf**

*busi-ness, choco-late*

**BIZ-nis, CHOK-lit**

*deter-mine as dee-ter-mine*

**di-TER-min**

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times without the silent letter: *doubt, comb, climb, know, knife, write, wrong, answer, half, walk, could, listen, often, hour, honest*.
2. Then the liar words, ten times each: *WENZ-day, FEB-you-ree, BIZ-nis, VEJ-tuh-bul, CHOK-lit, COMF-tuh-bul, REST-runt (restaurant), JEN-ruh-lee (generally)*.
3. Make your own list: write down ten words you are unsure about, then listen to each in a dictionary app and write the respelling in CAPITALS for the stress.
4. Read aloud five times: "On Wednesday I will answer honestly about the business, and half the vegetables were comfortable in the restaurant." (Deliberately silly, deliberately useful.)
5. Record and compare each liar word against the dictionary audio.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I will answer on Wednesday, once the business figures are ready."

"It takes about half an hour, honestly."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Indian scripts are largely phonetic: you say what is written. That trained habit is exactly what produces *Wed-nes-day*. Treat English spelling as a rough hint about a word's history, not an instruction about its sound.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which five words have I been mispronouncing because of their spelling?

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Two Review

You have now worked through every consonant where an Indian speaker's habit can change the word itself: *v* and *w*, both *th* sounds, the alveolar *t* and *d*, *plf* and *b/v*, the *s* family, final voicing, aspiration, clusters, the two *l* sounds and silent letters. These do not become automatic in ten days; they become automatic with five minutes a day for a month.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I can say *vest* and *west* differently, on demand, without thinking.
- ☐ My tongue goes between my teeth for *think* and *this*.
- ☐ I can feel the ridge behind my teeth and put *t* and *d* there.
- ☐ *Coffee* and *phone* have a clear *f*; *very* has a clear *v*.
- ☐ *Sip* and *ship* are two different words when I say them.
- ☐ *Jobs*, *files* and *names* end with a buzz.
- ☐ The paper moves when I say *pot* and stays still on *spot*.
- ☐ I say *school*, *street* and *film* with no extra vowel.
- ☐ *Full* and *people* have a hollow dark *l*.
- ☐ I have checked ten words whose spelling was misleading me.

## RECORDING TEST

Record yourself reading this passage twice, once slowly and once at normal speed: *"On Wednesday the whole team asked three questions about the school project. I think we will finish both films this month, and the manager verified every file. Please call before two."* Then listen with the ten checklist items in front of you and mark each sound as clear or not. Whatever you mark unclear is your five minutes a day for the next month.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

\*V\* and \*W\*

Both \*TH\* sounds

\*T\* and \*D\* position

The \*S\* family and final \*Z\*

Clusters without extra vowels

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If a sound will not come at all, stop trying to say the whole word. Make the sound alone, for ten seconds, twenty times a day, in front of a mirror. Sounds are muscle positions before they are anything else, and a muscle that has never been in that position needs days, not effort.

## PART THREE

---

# Vowels: The Long and the Short of It

DAYS 21-30

English has around twenty vowel sounds. Most Indian languages distinguish fewer, and distinguish them differently — by length rather than by mouth shape. The result is a set of collapsed pairs: *ship* and *sheep*, *full* and *fool*, *bad* and *bed*, *cot* and *caught*. This stage separates the pairs that actually change meaning, then deals with English spelling, which is the reason you learned some of these wrongly in the first place.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Hear and produce the difference between the short and long *i* of *ship* and *sheep*.
- Separate *full* from *fool*, *bad* from *bed*, and *cot* from *caught*.
- Say the five main diphthongs as gliding sounds rather than flat vowels.
- Handle the vowels English writes with *r*: *bird*, *near*, *care*, *sure*.
- Stop trusting English spelling to tell you the vowel.

## DAY 21

DAY 21 OF 100

## Ship and Sheep

*Focus:* Two different vowels, not one long and one short.

This is the most consequential vowel pair in English for Indian speakers, because it separates dozens of common words: *sit* and *seat*, *live* and *leave*, *fill* and *feel*, *bin* and *bean*. The difference is not really length — it is mouth shape. The *ship* vowel is relaxed and slightly lower; the *sheep* vowel is tight, with the tongue high and the lips spread.

### LEARN

- **For *sheep*:** spread your lips like a small smile, tongue high and forward, muscles tense. Hold it and it stays the same sound.
- **For *ship*:** relax everything. Lips neutral, tongue slightly lower and further back, jaw loose. It is a lazier, shorter sound.
- **Do not solve it by lengthening.** A long *ship* vowel is still *ship*. Change the shape of your mouth, not the duration.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*sheet when you mean sit*

**sit** with a relaxed, lazy vowel

*leave when you mean live*

**live** (as in *I live in Pune*)

*bitch when you mean beach*

**beach** with a tense, smiling vowel

*feel and fill said identically*

**feel** (tense) and **fill** (relaxed)

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Mirror: say eeeee with spread lips for five seconds, then *ihhhh* fully relaxed. Alternate twenty times, watching your lips change.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *ship / sheep*, *sit / seat*, *fill / feel*, *live / leave*, *bin / bean*, *hit / heat*, *still / steal*, *this / these*.
3. Say the relaxed set only, ten times: *it, in, is, if, this, with, will, big, little, minute, business, women*.
4. Say the tense set only, ten times: *eat, each, even, need, please, three, team, meet, complete, believe, people, key*.
5. Read aloud five times, then record: "I live in this city and I will leave the sheet on the seat."

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I live in this city, and I will leave at three."

"Please fill in these three fields before you eat."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Most Indian languages have a single high front vowel distinguished only by length, so your ear has never needed the shape difference. Expect to hear no difference at first when *others* say these words — that is normal, and the listening improves after the speaking does, not before.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which words in my daily English use the relaxed ship vowel? List five.

## DAY 22

DAY 22 OF 100

**Full and Fool**

*Focus:* The relaxed oo and the tight oo.

The same problem as yesterday, at the back of the mouth. *Full* and *fool*, *pull* and *pool*, *could* and *cooed* differ by mouth shape and tension. Getting this wrong rarely destroys a sentence, but it does affect very frequent words — *good*, *book*, *look*, *would*, *should* — so the habit repeats constantly.

**LEARN**

- **For *fool*:** push your lips into a tight small circle, tongue high at the back, muscles tense. A long, focused sound.
- **For *full*:** relax the lips into a loose, wider rounding, tongue slightly lower. A shorter, lazier sound.
- **The relaxed group is small and very common:** *good*, *book*, *look*, *took*, *foot*, *cook*, *would*, *could*, *should*, *put*, *push*, *full*, *woman*, *sugar*. Learn the list and everything else with oo is the tense one.

**INSTEAD OF****SAY THIS**

*food when you mean **foot***

**foot** with a relaxed, short vowel

*pool when you mean **pull***

**pull**

*goood, boook with a long tense vowel*

**good, book** with a relaxed vowel

*shood, wood (would) over-lengthened*

**should, would**, relaxed and quick

**PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES**

1. Mirror: tight small circle for oooo (five seconds), then loosen the lips for the relaxed version. Alternate twenty times.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *full / fool*, *pull / pool*, *look / Luke*, *could / cooed*, *foot / food*, *should / shooed*.
3. Relaxed list, ten times: *good*, *book*, *look*, *took*, *foot*, *cook*, *would*, *could*, *should*, *put*, *push*, *sugar*, *woman*.
4. Tense list, ten times: *food*, *school*, *room*, *move*, *June*, *soon*, *choose*, *group*, *true*, *blue*, *through*, *shoe*.
5. Read aloud five times, then record: "It would be good to look at the food in the new room."

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

"It would be good to look at the book before June."

"Please put the food in the room next to the school."

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

Because Indian languages separate these by length alone, the usual result is one vowel used for both, made long. Fix the small relaxed list — fourteen words — and you have fixed most of the problem, because those words occur far more often than the tense ones.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

Say good book and food room back to back. Do they use different vowels?

## DAY 23

DAY 23 OF 100

**Bad and Bed**

*Focus:* Open your mouth wider for the *cat* vowel.

The vowel in *cat*, *bad*, *man*, *back* does not exist in most Indian languages, so it is usually replaced by the vowel in *bed* or by a long *aa*. That makes *bad* and *bed*, *man* and *men*, *sat* and *set*, *bank* and *bench* hard for a listener to separate — and these are ordinary working words.

**LEARN**

- **For the *cat* vowel:** drop your jaw more than feels natural and spread your lips slightly, as if starting to smile while yawning. It is a wide, flat, fairly long sound.
- **For the *bed* vowel:** mid-height, relaxed, shorter. Your jaw is noticeably less open.
- **A useful check:** put a finger's width between your teeth for *cat*. For *bed* you cannot fit it.

**INSTEAD OF****SAY THIS***bed when you mean bad***bad** with a wide open jaw*men when you mean man***man***sat and set said identically***sat** (wide) and **set** (mid)*bank said as benk***bank**, jaw dropped**PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES**

1. Mirror: drop your jaw and say *aaa* as in *cat* for five seconds. Then say *eh* as in *bed*. Alternate twenty times, watching the jaw move.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *bad / bed*, *man / men*, *sat / set*, *bat / bet*, *and / end*, *hand / hen*, *back / beck*, *tax / text*.
3. Cat vowel list, ten times: *cat*, *bad*, *man*, *back*, *hand*, *plan*, *thank*, *family*, *national*, *standard*, *actually*, *manage*, *apply*, *staff*.
4. Read aloud five times: "The bad plan had a bank of standard answers and the staff sat back."
5. Record it and check *bad*, *plan*, *bank*, *staff*, *actually*. These are the ones that will appear in your real speech.

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

| "The staff actually managed the bad situation very well."

| "I have a plan, and I will thank the man from the bank."

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

Speakers across all Indian language groups substitute for this vowel, most often with a long *aa*, giving *baad* for *bad*. The correction is physical: it needs more jaw opening than any vowel in your first language, so it will feel exaggerated for about a week.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

*Which everyday words of mine need the wide cat vowel?*

## DAY 24

DAY 24 OF 100

**Cot, Caught and Coat**

*Focus:* Three separate back vowels that often collapse into one.

*Cot*, *caught* and *coat* are three different words with three different vowels, and Indian English frequently merges at least two of them. The same pattern hits *not* / *naught* / *note*, *want* / *won't*, and *so* / *saw*. Because these are short, high-frequency words, the confusion arrives early in a sentence and derails the listener.

**LEARN**

- **Cot:** short, jaw open, lips barely rounded. A quick sound.
- **Caught:** longer, lips rounded more, tongue further back. Think of the vowel in *call*, *law*, *door*, *more*, *sport*.
- **Coat:** a glide, not a single vowel — it starts near *caught* and moves toward *oo*, so your lips close as you say it. *Coat* is *koh-oot* compressed.

**INSTEAD OF****SAY THIS**

*cot, caught and coat all the same*

**cot** (short), **caught** (long, rounded), **coat** (gliding)

*note said as not*

**note** with a glide to *oo*

*won't said as want*

**won't** (glide) versus **want** (short)

*so and saw identical*

**so** (glide) versus **saw** (long, rounded)

**PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES**

1. Say the three in a row twenty times: *cot* — *caught* — *coat*. Feel your lips round more each time, and close on the third.
2. Triples, ten times each: *not* / *naught* / *note*, *cost* / *caught* / *coast*, *shot* / *short* / *show*, *want* / *wall* / *won't*.
3. *Caught* group, ten times: *call*, *small*, *law*, *saw*, *door*, *more*, *board*, *report*, *important*, *morning*, *water*, *sport*.
4. *Coat* group, ten times: *go*, *no*, *so*, *know*, *phone*, *home*, *open*, *most*, *close*, *whole*, *focus*, *total*.
5. Read aloud five times, then record: "I called in the morning about the short report, so I know the whole cost."

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

"I called the office in the morning about the important report."

"I won't go home before I close the whole thing."

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

Indian English typically has one back rounded vowel doing the work of two or three, and *coat*-type words often lose their glide and become flat. The glide is the easiest fix: close your lips as the sound ends, so *no* finishes almost at *oo*.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

Say I won't want that coat. *Are all three vowels different?*

## DAY 25

DAY 25 OF 100

## Cut, Cart and the Weak Uh

*Focus:* Three central sounds that get confused with each other.

*Cut*, *cart* and the weak *uh* of *about* are close in the mouth and are frequently merged. The result is *bus* sounding like *bas*, *much* like *march*, and stressed syllables sounding unstressed. Since *cut*-type words include *but*, *just*, *much*, *come*, *some*, *money*, *month*, *one*, the effect is constant.

### LEARN

- **Cut:** short, central, mouth relaxed and slightly open. *But, just, much, cup, love, money, month, one, done, up.*
- **Cart:** long, jaw open, tongue low and back, no *r* sound in most accents. *Car, far, part, start, market, large, heart.*
- **Weak uh:** the same area as *cut* but shorter and always unstressed: *about, doctor, problem, banana.* Never give it stress.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*bas for bus, mach for much*

**bus**, **much** with a short central vowel

*cut and cart said the same*

**cut** (short) versus **cart** (long, open)

*muneɪ, mounθ*

**money** (MUN-ee), **month** (MUNTH)

*one said as own*

**one** (wun)

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say the three in a row twenty times: *cut — cart — uh*. Note that only the middle one is long and open.
2. Pairs, ten times each: *cut / cart, but / part, hut / heart, much / march, bun / barn.*
3. *Cut* group, ten times: *but, just, much, come, some, money, month, one, done, up, under, company, subject, result.*
4. *Cart* group, ten times: *car, far, start, part, market, large, hard, garden, apartment, department.*
5. Read aloud five times, then record: "I just came from the market, but the company money is under discussion."

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I just came from the market, and it was much harder than I thought."

"The company sent some money last month."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many speakers use one long *aa* for all three. Test yourself with *much* and *march*: if they sound the same, this is your day. Keep the *cut* vowel short — shortness is most of the difference.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Do much and march sound different when I say them?*



## DAY 26

DAY 26 OF 100

## Diphthongs: Vowels That Move

*Focus:* Glide from one vowel to another inside a single syllable.

Five English vowels are not single sounds at all: *day*, *my*, *boy*, *now*, *no* each start in one place and slide to another. Indian languages have fewer glides and often flatten them, so *day* becomes *de* and *no* becomes *no* with no movement. Flat diphthongs are a large part of what makes speech sound monotone.

### LEARN

- **The five to know:** *day* (eh to ee), *my* (ah to ee), *boy* (aw to ee), *now* (ah to oo), *no* (oh to oo).
- **The first part is longer, the second is a quick finish.** Do not give both halves equal time; that sounds like two syllables.
- **Your mouth must physically move.** Lips spread for the ee endings, lips close for the oo endings. If nothing moves, it is not a diphthong.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*de* for **day**, *se* for **say**

**day**, **say** gliding toward ee

*flat no*, *go*, *home*

**no**, **go**, **home** gliding toward oo

*naw* for **now**

**now** gliding from *ah* to oo

*bay* for **buy**

**buy** starting from an open *ah*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each glide slowly, in slow motion, ten times: *eh-ee* (*day*), *ah-ee* (*my*), *aw-ee* (*boy*), *ah-oo* (*now*), *oh-oo* (*no*).
2. Words, ten times each set: *day*, *say*, *make*, *take*, *wait*, *eight* — *my*, *time*, *right*, *five*, *buy*, *decide* — *boy*, *choice*, *point*, *avoid* — *now*, *how*, *about*, *house*, *doubt* — *no*, *go*, *home*, *phone*, *close*, *most*.
3. Mirror check: watch your lips move on *day* (spreading) and *no* (closing). If they stay still, exaggerate.
4. Read aloud five times: "I will decide today about the house, and I will phone you right now."
5. Record it and listen for flat vowels. Any word that sounds static, drill ten more times.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I will decide today and phone you right away."

"How about the house we saw on Monday?"

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Flattened diphthongs are a strong feature of Indian English across all regions, and they interact with rhythm: flat vowels plus equal syllables produces the monotone that listeners describe as "hard to stay with." Fixing the glides brings back some of the natural music.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which of the five glides is flattest in my speech?

## DAY 27

DAY 27 OF 100

## The Vowels English Spells With R

Focus: *Bird, near, care, sure, more* and *car*.

When *r* follows a vowel, English changes the vowel and often does not pronounce the *r* strongly at all. Indian English usually pronounces the *r* fully and keeps the vowel plain, which produces *bird* as *burd* with a hard tap. Getting these right affects extremely common words: *work, first, world, person, sir, here, there, sure, more*.

## LEARN

- The ***bird*** vowel is central and long, with the tongue bunched: *work, first, word, world, person, learn, service, thirty, Thursday*.
- Whether you sound the *r* is a choice, but do not roll it. Both a light *r* and a dropped *r* sound fine internationally; a tapped *r* is what marks the speech.
- Three glides to ***uh***: *near* (ee plus uh), *care* (eh plus uh), *sure* (oo plus uh). The vowel does the work, not the *r*.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*wark, farst, warld with a rolled r*

**work, first, world** with a central vowel

*heere, theere with a tapped r*

**here, there** gliding to *uh*

*Thars-day*

**THURZ-day**

*sar (sir) with a hard r*

**sir**, central and long

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Hold the *bird* vowel for five seconds, tongue bunched, no tap. Repeat ten times.
2. *Bird* group, ten times: *work, first, word, world, person, learn, girl, birthday, Thursday, thirty, service, prefer, occur*.
3. Glide groups, ten times each: *near, here, year, clear, idea* — *care, there, where, share, air* — *sure, tour, pure*.
4. Read aloud five times: "The first person here will learn the whole service by Thursday."
5. Record and listen only to your *r* sounds. If you hear a tap, do the *er* hold drill from Day 19 again.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"The first person I spoke to here will learn the service by Thursday."

"I am not sure where they are, but I will share the idea."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Because Indian scripts write the *r* and you learned to say what is written, the *r* usually gets full value and the vowel gets none. Reverse the emphasis: make the vowel long and let the *r* be light. That one change transforms *world* and *work*.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Say *world, work, first, Thursday*. Is the vowel long and central?

## DAY 28

DAY 28 OF 100

# Spelling Is Not Sound

*Focus:* Stop reading vowels off the page.

English spelling records a thousand years of history, not current pronunciation. The letters *ough* have at least six sounds; *ea* has four. If you learned English mainly by reading — as most Indian learners did — then a portion of your pronunciation is guesses that were never corrected. Today you find and fix them.

## LEARN

- **ough is unpredictable:** *through* (oo), *though* (oh), *thought* (aw), *tough* (uff), *cough* (off), *bough* (ow).
- **ea has four values:** *eat* (ee), *bread* (eh), *great* (ay), *heard* (ur).
- **Same spelling, different words:** *read* (present, *reed*) and *read* (past, *red*); *live* (verb, *liv*) and *live* (adjective, *lyve*).
- **Build the habit of checking.** Every time you meet a word you have only ever read, listen to it once before you say it in public.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*thruff, thou (though)*

**through** (*throo*), **though** (*thoh*)

*bred for bread? correct — but eat is eet*

**bread** (*bred*), **eat** (*eet*)

*determine as dee-ter-MINE*

**di-TER-min**

*suite as soot-eh*

**suite** (*sweet*)

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times: *through, though, thought, tough, cough, enough, thorough.*
2. The *ea* set, ten times: *eat, each, bread, breakfast, great, break, heard, learn, early.*
3. The trap list, ten times: *suite, receipt, colonel, salmon, iron, island, subtle, debt, queue, choir.*
4. Make your own list of ten words you have only read and never heard. Listen to each in a dictionary app, then write your own respelling with CAPITALS for stress.
5. Read aloud five times: “I thought the tough queue was long enough, though I heard it moved early.”

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I thought it was tough enough already, though I heard otherwise.”

“I read that report yesterday, and I will read this one today.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

This is the single biggest disadvantage of learning English through reading and examinations rather than through listening — and it is the shared experience of most Indian learners. It is not a gap in your intelligence; it is a gap in your input. Listening fixes it.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which word have I been saying wrongly for the longest time?*

## DAY 29

DAY 29 OF 100

## The Pairs That Ruin Meetings

*Focus:* Drill the confusions that cost money and time at work.

Some vowel confusions are harmless. Others change a number, a date, a name or an instruction, and in a work context that costs real time. *Fifteen* and *fifty*, *can* and *can't*, *thirteen* and *thirty*, *Tuesday* and *Thursday*: these need to be right, and they need a repair strategy for when they are not.

### LEARN

- **The -teen and -ty numbers differ by stress.** *ThirTEEN* stresses the end; *THIRty* stresses the start and ends in a quick ee. Stress carries this, not the vowel.
- **Tuesday and Thursday differ at the start:** *TYOOZ-day* against *THURZ-day*. The second begins with the *th* of Day 12.
- **Can and can't:** in most accents the negative has a longer, more open vowel and often a clipped ending. When it matters, say *cannot*.
- **Always confirm critical information a second way.** Numbers, dates and spellings should be repeated back or given twice.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*fifteen and fifty said the same*

**fifTEEN** and **FIFty**, distinguished by stress

*Tuesday and Thursday blurred*

**TYOOZ-day** and **THURZ-day**

*I can do it when you mean the opposite*

**I cannot do it** — use the full form

*thirty and thirteen guessed by the listener*

**thirTEEN**, or *one-three* to be safe

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say each pair ten times, exaggerating the stress: *thirTEEN* / *THIRty*, *fourTEEN* / *FORTy*, *fifTEEN* / *FIFty*, *sixTEEN* / *SIXty*, *eightTEEN* / *EIGHTy*.
2. Days and months, ten times: *TYOOZ-day*, *THURZ-day*, *WENZ-day*, *SAT-uh-day*, *JAN-yoo-ree*, *FEB-you-ree*, *AW-gust*.
3. Practise saying numbers digit by digit as a backup: *fifteen* — *that is one-five*; *thirty* — *that is three-zero*.
4. Say ten real numbers from your work aloud: amounts, dates, phone numbers, order references. Use the digit-by-digit confirmation each time.
5. Practise the confirm-back habit out loud: “So that is the fifteenth, one-five, at four thirty. Correct?”

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Fifteen, that is one-five, not fifty.”

“Just to confirm: Thursday the thirteenth, at two thirty.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Never rely on pronunciation alone for numbers, dates and spellings, in any accent — native speakers confirm these too, on every professional call. Building the confirm-back habit protects you far better than perfect vowels ever will.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which number or date confusion has caused me a real problem at work?*

## DAY 30

DAY 30 OF 100

## Vowel Length Before Voiced Endings

*Focus:* Lengthen the vowel before *b, d, g, v, z* and *j*.

This is the detail that separates good pronunciation from very good pronunciation. In English, a vowel is noticeably longer before a voiced consonant than before an unvoiced one: the vowel in *bad* is longer than in *bat*, in *seed* longer than in *seat*. Listeners use vowel length — not the final consonant — to tell these words apart.

### LEARN

- **Longer before voiced endings:** *b, d, g, v, z, j* and *th* as in *this*. So *bag, bad, live, prize, cab*.
- **Shorter before unvoiced endings:** *p, t, k, f, s, sh, ch*. So *back, bat, life, price, cap*.
- **This is why your endings can be quiet and still understood.** If the vowel length is right, listeners hear the correct word even when the final consonant is soft.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*bat and bad with the same vowel length*

**ba-ad** (longer) versus **bat** (short)

*seat and seed identical*

**see-ed** versus **seat**

*price and prize identical*

**pri-ize** versus **price**

*cap and cab identical*

**ca-ab** versus **cap**

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each pair ten times, deliberately stretching the first vowel of the second word: *bat / bad, seat / seed, cap / cab, back / bag, life / live, price / prize, rice / rise*.
2. Read this five times, stretching every vowel before a voiced ending: "The bad bag had five big prizes inside."
3. Then read the short version five times: "The bat sat back at eight." Notice how clipped it feels.
4. Record both. The difference in vowel length should be clearly audible on playback.
5. Apply it to your own work words: list five that end in *d, b, g, v* or *z*, and drill each ten times with a long vowel.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"We had five big prizes and one bad bag."

"I live nearby, so I will leave the file on the desk."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Nobody will ever correct this for you, because the error does not usually produce a wrong word — it produces speech that sounds slightly clipped and effortful throughout. It is therefore one of the highest-value polish items in this book, and one of the least taught.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Say *bad and bat back to back*. Is the vowel clearly longer in one?

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Three Review

The vowel pairs that actually change words are now separated: *ship* and *sheep*, *full* and *fool*, *bad* and *bed*, *cot*, *caught* and *coat*, *cut* and *cart*. You have the five glides, the *r*-coloured vowels, the spelling traps, the work-critical confusions and the vowel-length rule that most courses never mention.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ *Ship* and *sheep* are two different mouth shapes for me, not two lengths.
- ☐ I know the fourteen-word relaxed *good* / *book* / *would* list.
- ☐ I drop my jaw for *bad*, *plan*, *staff* and *bank*.
- ☐ *Cot*, *caught* and *coat* are three different sounds when I say them.
- ☐ *Much* and *march* sound different.
- ☐ My *day*, *my*, *boy*, *now* and *no* all move as I say them.
- ☐ *World*, *work* and *Thursday* have a long central vowel, not a rolled *r*.
- ☐ I have checked ten words whose spelling was misleading me.
- ☐ I say *fifTEEN* and *FIFTy* differently, and I confirm numbers digit by digit.
- ☐ My vowels are longer in *bad*, *bag* and *prize* than in *bat*, *back* and *price*.

## RECORDING TEST

Record this passage, then listen with the checklist: “*I live in this city and I will leave on Thursday the fifteenth. The staff had a bad week, but the whole team worked hard and the results are good. I am not sure about the cost, so I will call in the morning.*” Mark every vowel you are unsure about, then compare against a dictionary app word by word for the five worst.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

\*Ship\* / \*sheep\* and \*full\* / \*fool\*

The wide \*cat\* vowel

Back vowels: \*cot\* / \*caught\* / \*coat\*

Diphthong glides

Numbers, dates and confirmation habits

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If you cannot *hear* a pair even when someone else says it, do listening before speaking: find the two words in a dictionary app and play them alternately, twenty times, with earphones. Your ear was trained by your first language to ignore that difference, and it needs re-training before your mouth can target it.

## PART FOUR

---

# Rhythm, Music and Connected Speech

DAYS 31-40

This is the most important stage in the book. Individual sounds matter less than most people think; rhythm and intonation matter far more. A speaker with a strong accent but correct stress and melody is easy to follow. A speaker with perfect consonants and flat, evenly-spaced syllables is exhausting. Here you learn sentence stress, weak forms, contractions, linking, the sounds that disappear in real speech, and what your tone is telling people about your attitude.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Stress the one word in a sentence that carries your meaning.
- Use weak forms and contractions instead of full careful words.
- Link words together so your speech flows instead of stopping between words.
- Use falling and rising tone deliberately, for statements, questions and politeness.
- Run your first shadowing session and set up a daily listening habit.

## DAY 31

DAY 31 OF 100

## Stress the Word That Matters

*Focus:* Choose one word per sentence and give it the weight.

Sentence stress tells the listener what your sentence is *about*. Change the stressed word and the meaning changes completely, without changing a single word. Speakers who stress everything equally force the listener to work out the point themselves, and in a fast meeting they simply will not bother.

### LEARN

- **One main stress per short sentence.** Stressing four words is the same as stressing none.
- **The stress goes on the new or contrasted information.** Whatever the listener does not yet know is what gets the weight.
- **Stress is louder, slightly longer, and often preceded by a tiny pause.** It is not shouting.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say “*I did not say she took the money*” seven times, stressing a different word each time. Notice that you produce seven different meanings.
2. Now say these with the stress on the capitalised word, ten times each: “I sent it on **MON**day” (not Tuesday). “I **SENT** it on Monday” (I did do it). “**I** sent it on Monday” (not somebody else).
3. Take five sentences you will actually say today. Underline the one word that carries the point in each.
4. Say each one five times with that stress, and once with the stress deliberately in the wrong place so you can hear the damage.
5. Record three of them and check that the stressed word is clearly the loudest and longest.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“The problem is not the **BUDGET**, it is the **TIMELINE**.”

“I can finish it by **FRIDAY**, but not by **WEDNESDAY**.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Equal stress across a sentence is the direct consequence of the syllable-timed rhythm of Indian languages, and it is the single most common reason international colleagues describe Indian English as “fast and hard to follow.” Slowing down helps a little; correct stress helps enormously.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which word carries the point in the most important sentence I will say tomorrow?*



## DAY 32

DAY 32 OF 100

## Weak Forms of the Small Words

Focus: Squash *to*, *for*, *of*, *and*, *can*, *are*, *was*.

Grammar words have two pronunciations: a strong one used in isolation and a weak one used in real sentences. English speakers use the weak one almost always. If you give every *to*, *for* and *and* its full value, your rhythm flattens and your speech takes longer to say and longer to follow, even though every word is correct.

### LEARN

- **The commonest weak forms:** *to* becomes *tuh*, *for* becomes *fuh*, *of* becomes *uv*, *and* becomes *un* or *n*, *can* becomes *kn*, *are* becomes *uh*, *was* becomes *wuz*, *at* becomes *ut*, *them* becomes *um*.
- **Weak forms are correct, careful English**, used by newsreaders and professors. They are not slang.
- **Strong forms return when the word is stressed or final:** “Who is it **FOR**?” keeps the full *for*.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I want TO GO TO the office with full vowels*

*I want **tuh** go **tuh** the office*

*fish AND chips, both words full*

*fish **un** chips*

*a cup OF tea with a strong of*

*a cup **uv** tea*

*I CAN do it when not emphasising*

*I **kn** do it*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each phrase ten times, squashing the small word: *want tuh go*, *ask fuh help*, *cup uv tea*, *bread un butter*, *kn you come*, *they uh ready*, *it wuz fine*, *look ut this*, *tell um now*.
2. Read aloud five times, weakening every grammar word: “I wanted to talk to them about the cost of the project and the dates for delivery.”
3. Say the same sentence again giving every small word full value. Hear how heavy and slow it becomes.
4. Take a paragraph of anything. Circle every *to*, *for*, *of*, *and*, *are*, *was*, *can*, *at*, *them*. Read it aloud weakening all of them.
5. Record both versions of one sentence and keep them; this pair is a useful reference for the rest of the course.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I need *tuh* speak *tuh* the manager about a couple *uv* things.”

“They *uh* waiting *fuh* the report *un* the invoice.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Because Indian scripts are written phonetically and school English rewarded careful full pronunciation, weakening feels like being sloppy or disrespectful. It is neither. Full forms everywhere is the marked, non-native pattern.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which small word do I most over-pronounce?

## DAY 33

DAY 33 OF 100

## Use Contractions

Focus: Say *I'll*, *don't*, *we've*, *it's* in speech.

Written English uses full forms; spoken English contracts. Saying *I will not be able to* instead of *I won't be able to* is grammatically perfect and immediately sounds formal, distant and slightly old-fashioned. Contractions also fix your rhythm automatically, because they force the small words to compress.

## LEARN

- **Learn the common ones as single sounds:** *I'll*, *you'll*, *we'll*, *don't*, *doesn't*, *didn't*, *isn't*, *aren't*, *wasn't*, *won't*, *can't*, *I've*, *we've*, *it's*, *that's*, *there's*, *I'm*, *you're*, *they're*.
- **Some are hard for Indian speakers because of clusters:** *didn't* is *DID-nt*, *wouldn't* is *WOOD-nt*. Practise them as whole units, not letter by letter.
- **Keep full forms only for emphasis or formality:** “*I will not accept that*” is deliberately strong; *I won't* is normal.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*I will not be able to come*

*I **won't** be able to come*

*It is not working, is it not?*

*It **isn't** working, is it?*

*I have not received it*

*I **haven't** received it*

*We are going to do it*

*We're **gonna** do it (informal) / We're going to*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times as one unit: *I'll*, *you'll*, *we'll*, *they'll*, *don't*, *doesn't*, *didn't*, *isn't*, *wasn't*, *won't*, *can't*, *couldn't*, *wouldn't*, *I've*, *we've*, *it's*, *that's*, *there's*.
2. The difficult clusters, twenty times each slowly: *didn't*, *wouldn't*, *shouldn't*, *couldn't*, *mustn't*.
3. Convert these aloud: “*I will send it.*” “*She does not know.*” “*We have not decided.*” “*They are not coming.*” “*It is not ready.*”
4. Speak for one minute about your plans this week, using at least eight contractions. Record it.
5. Listen back and count the full forms you used where a contraction would be natural.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I'll send it today. I haven't finished the second part yet.*”

“*They're not ready, so we'll push it to Monday.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Indian school and office English strongly favours full forms, so avoiding contractions often feels more correct and more respectful. In speech it produces the opposite impression: it reads as stiff, and in interviews abroad it can read as rehearsed.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Write five sentences I say often, in their contracted form.

## DAY 34

DAY 34 OF 100

## Link Your Words Together

*Focus:* Join the end of one word to the start of the next.

English speakers do not leave gaps between words; they run them together into groups. *Pick it up* becomes *pi-ki-tup*. If you pronounce each word separately and cleanly, your speech sounds chopped, and — more importantly — you cannot understand fast English either, because you are listening for gaps that are not there.

## LEARN

- **Consonant to vowel: carry the consonant across.** *Turn it off* becomes *tur-ni-toff*. *Look at it* becomes *loo-ka-tit*.
- **Same consonant twice: say it once, slightly longer.** *Next time* becomes *nex-time*; *black coffee* becomes *bla-coffee*.
- **Vowel to vowel: a tiny y or w appears.** *Go on* becomes *go-won*; *I am* becomes *I-yam*.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Turn . it . off as three separate words*

*tur-ni-toff*, one smooth group

*Pick . it . up*

*pi-ki-tup*

*Not . at . all*

*no-ta-tall*

*This . is . an . important . issue*

*thi-si-zan-imPORtant-issue*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each phrase ten times as a single smooth unit: *pick it up*, *turn it off*, *look at it*, *not at all*, *take it away*, *an hour ago*, *all of us*, *most of it*, *half an hour*.
2. Same-consonant links, ten times: *next time*, *black coffee*, *big girl*, *want to*, *best time*, *one night*.
3. Vowel links, ten times: *go on*, *I am*, *she asked*, *do it*, *the end*, *my own*.
4. Read aloud five times, linking everything: "I picked it up an hour ago and put it all in the office."
5. Record it. If you can hear silence between words, do it again faster and smoother.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I'll pick it up in half an hour and take it to the office."

"Not at all — I'm happy to look at it again."

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Word-by-word delivery comes from reading aloud in school, where clarity meant separating words. It also explains a very common complaint: "I can read English well but I cannot understand native speakers." They are linking, and you are listening for separate words.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which linked phrase felt most unnatural? Practise it ten more times.

## DAY 35

DAY 35 OF 100

## The Sounds That Disappear

*Focus:* Drop the sounds that English drops in fast speech.

Fast English deletes sounds systematically. *Next day* loses its *t*. *Friendship* loses its *d*. *Comfortable* loses a whole syllable. You do not have to imitate this to be understood, but you must recognise it, or fast speech will remain a wall of noise. And a small amount of it makes your own speech noticeably more fluent.

### LEARN

- **A *t* or *d* between two consonants usually goes:** *next day* becomes *nex-day*, *most people* becomes *mos-people*, *hand bag* becomes *han-bag*.
- **Common reductions you will hear constantly:** *going to* becomes *gonna*, *want to* becomes *wanna*, *got to* becomes *gotta*, *kind of* becomes *kinda*, *let me* becomes *lemme*, *give me* becomes *gimme*.
- **Recognise all of them; use only some.** In professional speech, *gonna* and *wanna* are fine in conversation and better avoided in a formal presentation.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times with the sound dropped: *nex-day*, *mos-people*, *han-bag*, *san-wich* (sandwich), *fren-ship*, *las-week*, *firs-time*, *use-to* (used to).
2. Say the reductions ten times each: *gonna*, *wanna*, *gotta*, *kinda*, *sorta*, *lemme*, *gimme*, *dunno*, *whatcha*, *howzit going*.
3. Listen to sixty seconds of natural English audio with a transcript. Mark every place where a written sound was not pronounced.
4. Read aloud five times, using reductions: "I'm gonna finish it nex-week, but I dunno if I've gotta send it firs."
5. Then read the same content in full careful form, for contrast. Keep both; you need both registers.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

"I'm going to finish it next week — I don't know the exact date yet."

"I used to work there, so I know most people in that team."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Do not adopt heavy reductions to sound more native. Overdone, they sound like imitation and they reduce your clarity, which is the opposite of the goal. The listening half of this day is worth far more to you than the speaking half.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which reduction did I not recognise before today?*

## DAY 36

DAY 36 OF 100

## Fall at the End of Statements

*Focus:* Drop your pitch on the last stressed word.

In English, a falling tone at the end means “I have finished and I mean this.” A rising or flat tone at the end of a statement signals doubt, or that you have not finished — which invites people to interrupt you. Many Indian speakers end statements level or slightly rising, and are then read as tentative when they are actually certain.

### LEARN

- **Fall on the last stressed word**, not on the very last syllable if that syllable is unstressed. In “*I sent it on Monday*”, the fall is on **MON**.
- **A flat ending sounds unfinished** and is one reason speakers get talked over in meetings.
- **Recording is essential here**. Almost nobody can hear their own final pitch in real time.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I think we should wait? (rising)*

*I think we should **WAIT**. (falling)*

*My name is Rahul. (flat)*

*My name is **RA**hul. (falling on the stress)*

*The report is ready... (trailing)*

*The report is **RE**Ady. (falling, then stop)*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each statement ten times with a deliberate, exaggerated drop on the capitalised word: “My recommendation is that we **WAIT**.” “The deadline is **FR**Iday.” “I have finished the **RE**port.”
2. Say the same three as questions, with a rise, so you can feel the difference clearly.
3. Record five statements about your work. Play them back and mark each ending as falling, flat or rising.
4. Re-record the flat and rising ones with an exaggerated fall. Exaggeration in practice produces normal in speech.
5. In one real conversation today, land three statements with a clear fall and then stop talking.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“My recommendation is that we postpone it by a week.”

“I have finished the first part, and I’ll send it today.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Some Indian languages use pitch patterns at sentence ends that map onto English as uncertainty or as a question. This means confident content can arrive sounding unsure — a particular problem in interviews and client calls, where you are being assessed on confidence you actually have.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Do my statements end falling, flat or rising? What did the recording show?*

## DAY 37

DAY 37 OF 100

# Rise for Questions and Politeness

*Focus:* Use a rising tone where English expects one.

Yes-or-no questions rise. Wh-questions usually fall. Requests rise to sound polite. Lists rise on each item and fall on the last. If your questions do not rise, listeners sometimes do not realise they were questions, and answer nothing — which then reads as rudeness on their part and confusion on yours.

## LEARN

- **Yes/no questions rise:** “Are you free on Friday?” “Did you get my mail?”
- **Wh-questions fall:** “When is the meeting?” “What did he say?” A rising wh-question sounds surprised or repeats a question.
- **Requests and offers rise, which is what makes them polite:** “Could you send it today?” A falling request sounds like an order.
- **Lists: rise, rise, then fall.** “We need the invoice, the contract, and the schedule.”

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times with a clear rise: “Are you free tomorrow?” “Did you receive it?” “Is this the final version?” “Could you help me with this?”
2. Say each ten times with a fall: “When is the deadline?” “What is the status?” “Who is handling it?”
3. Do the list pattern five times: “I need the invoice, the contract, and the schedule.” Rise, rise, fall.
4. Practise the same request twice: once falling (an order), once rising (polite). Hear the difference in attitude.
5. Record five questions from your real work and check each tone.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Could you send me the file before lunch?”

“When do you need it by?”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The most costly version of this error is the falling request: “Send me the report.” said with a fall is a command in English, however polite your intention. Add the rise and a modal (*could, would*) and the same request becomes courteous.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which of my questions might not have sounded like questions?*

## DAY 38

DAY 38 OF 100

## Sounding Polite, Not Blunt

*Focus:* Soften with tone and words, not with extra formality.

Indian English politeness is often built from formal vocabulary (*kindly, respected sir, do the needful*) while the tone stays flat and the request stays direct. International English does the opposite: casual words, softened grammar, warm tone. The result is that a perfectly respectful Indian speaker can be heard as abrupt, and a casual foreign colleague as friendly.

## LEARN

- **Softening comes from modals and question forms:** *could, would, might, do you think, would it be possible, I was wondering if.*
- **Warmth comes from tone, not from formal words.** *Kindly do the needful* said flatly is colder than *Could you take a look when you get a chance?*
- **Give a reason.** “Could you send it today? I need it for the client call” is far easier to accept than the bare request.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Kindly do the needful.*

*Could you take a look and let me know?*

*Send me the report.*

*Could you send me the report when you get a chance?*

*Respected Sir, I want leave.*

*Hi Anil — could I take Friday off? Happy to hand over first.*

*You must complete this today.*

*Would you be able to finish this today? It is blocking the release.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take five direct requests you make at work. Rewrite each with a modal, a question form and a reason.
2. Say each aloud twice: once flat and direct, once with a rise and a warm tone. Record both.
3. Learn these five openers by heart: *Could you ... / Would you be able to ... / Do you think you could ... / I was wondering if ... / Would it be possible to ...*
4. Practise the disagreement softener: “*I see what you mean, but I am not sure that ...*” and “*That could work. My only concern is ...*”
5. Use two softened requests with real people today and note the response.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*Could you take a look at this when you get a chance? No rush.*”

“*I was wondering if we could move the call to Thursday — Wednesday is tight for me.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Kindly, do the needful, revert, the same* and *respected sir* are formal in Indian office English and read as either archaic or brusque elsewhere. Stage Eight, Day 71 replaces the whole set. Politeness in English lives in the grammar and the tone, not in the vocabulary.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Rewrite one request I made today in a softer form.

## DAY 39

DAY 39 OF 100

## Pause in the Right Places

*Focus:* Group words into meaning units and breathe between them.

Speech is easier to follow when it arrives in chunks with small gaps at the meaning boundaries. Pausing in the wrong place — mid-phrase, because you ran out of breath or vocabulary — breaks the sentence and forces the listener to reassemble it. Correct pausing also makes you sound thoughtful rather than hesitant, using the same amount of silence.

### LEARN

- **Pause at meaning boundaries:** after the subject group, before a *because* or *but*, between list items, at full stops. *“The client called this morning / because the invoice was wrong / so I have asked finance to fix it.”*
- **Do not pause inside a chunk.** *“I need to speak to / the manager”* is a broken sentence; *“I need to speak to the manager / about the delay”* is not.
- **Breathe at your pauses.** A pause you take deliberately sounds like control; one you take because you are out of air sounds like panic.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Mark the pauses in this sentence with slashes, then read it aloud five times: “We finished the testing last week but the client has asked for two more changes so the launch will move to the fifteenth.”
2. Read the same sentence badly on purpose, pausing in the wrong places, so you can hear the damage.
3. Take a paragraph of anything and mark the meaning groups with slashes. Read it aloud twice, breathing at each slash.
4. Speak for a minute about your work, deliberately pausing at boundaries. Record it.
5. Listen back and mark any pause that fell inside a chunk. Those are the places you ran out of language, not breath.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“We finished the testing last week / but the client asked for two changes / so the date will move.”

“Give me one second / I want to get the number right.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

When vocabulary fails mid-sentence, the instinct is to pause there and search. Instead, finish the chunk with a simpler word and pause at the boundary. Nobody will notice the simpler word; everyone notices the broken sentence.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Where did my pauses fall inside a phrase instead of between phrases?*



## DAY 40

DAY 40 OF 100

## Your First Shadowing Session

*Focus:* Copy a native speaker in real time, sound for sound.

Shadowing — listening to a short piece of natural speech and repeating it immediately, imitating everything — trains rhythm, stress, linking and intonation simultaneously, which is why it is the most efficient speaking exercise that exists. It also trains your ear, because you cannot copy what you have not heard precisely.

### LEARN

- **Choose short and interesting.** Twenty to thirty seconds of audio with a transcript. A news bulletin, a talk, a podcast, an interview.
- **Four passes:** listen only; listen while reading the transcript; read aloud along with the audio; speak along with the audio without looking.
- **Copy the music, not the accent.** You are matching stress, rhythm, pauses and pitch movement. Your own accent underneath is fine.
- **Same clip for several days.** Progress comes from repeating one clip until it is easy, not from new clips daily.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Choose a clip of twenty to thirty seconds with an accurate transcript, by a speaker you would be content to sound like.
2. Pass one: listen twice with your eyes closed. Pass two: listen twice while reading the transcript, marking the stressed words and the pauses.
3. Pass three: read aloud along with the audio, four times. You will fall behind; keep going and rejoin.
4. Pass four: play the audio in one earphone and speak along without the transcript, four times.
5. Record your final attempt and the original one after the other. Note the one difference you most want to close, then use the same clip again tomorrow.

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The commonest mistake is changing clips every day, which feels productive and teaches almost nothing. The second commonest is choosing a clip that is too long or too fast. Twenty seconds, repeated for five days, beats five minutes once.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What is the one difference between my version and the original?*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Four Review

You now have the machinery that separates fluent-sounding English from careful English: sentence stress, weak forms, contractions, linking, reductions, falling and rising tone, politeness through grammar rather than vocabulary, meaningful pausing, and a shadowing routine you will use for the rest of the course.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I can change the meaning of a sentence by moving the stress.
- ☐ I say *tuh*, *fuh*, *uv* and *un* instead of full grammar words.
- ☐ I use contractions naturally in speech, including *didn't* and *wouldn't*.
- ☐ I link words instead of separating them.
- ☐ I recognise *gonna*, *wanna*, *nex-day* and *mos-people* when I hear them.
- ☐ My statements end with a falling tone.
- ☐ My yes/no questions rise and my wh-questions fall.
- ☐ I soften requests with modals and reasons instead of formal words.
- ☐ I pause at meaning boundaries and breathe there.
- ☐ I have completed a full four-pass shadowing session.

## RECORDING TEST

Shadow the same clip again, then record yourself speaking sixty seconds on any topic. Listen to the two recordings back to back and answer three questions in writing: is my stress landing on the content words, do my statements fall at the end, and are my words linked or separated? This is the test that matters most in the whole book.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Sentence stress

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Weak forms and contractions

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Linking and flow

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Intonation: falling and rising

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Pausing and shadowing practice

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If this stage felt like the hardest so far, that is the correct reaction — it is asking you to change habits your first language installed, not to learn facts. Do the tapping drill from Day 2 and one shadowing session daily, and let everything else wait. Rhythm is worth more than the next fifty new words you could learn.

## PART FIVE

---

# The Grammar You Actually Speak

DAYS 41-50

You have studied more English grammar than most native speakers ever will, and it still comes out wrong when you speak. That is because written grammar is knowledge and spoken grammar is habit. This stage does not teach you rules you already know. It drills the eight or nine specific structures that Indian English handles differently — articles, the continuous tense, the present perfect, question forms, prepositions, tag questions and uncountable nouns — until the correct version is the automatic one.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Use *a*, *an* and *the* correctly in speech without stopping to think.
- Stop using the continuous for states: *I have* rather than *I am having*.
- Choose correctly between *I did* and *I have done*, and use *since* and *for* properly.
- Form questions and negatives without doubling the auxiliary.
- Drop the *isn't it* tag and use the correct one instead.

## DAY 41

DAY 41 OF 100

## A, An, The: The Article System

*Focus:* Put an article in front of every singular countable noun.

No major Indian language has articles, so there is nothing in your first language to transfer. The result is the most frequent and most noticeable grammatical feature of Indian English: “*I am going to office*”, “*she is doctor*”, “*give me pen*”. It never blocks understanding, and it is scored heavily in interviews and language tests, which makes it worth ten minutes a day.

### LEARN

- **Every singular countable noun needs something before it:** *a, an, the, my, this, one, each*. Never nothing. If you can count it and there is one of it, it takes a word.
- **Use *a* or *an* the first time, *the* afterwards.** “*I got a call from a client. The client wants the report today.*”
- **Use *the* when there is only one possible thing in the situation:** *the manager, the office, the sun, the government, the first one*.
- **No article for general plurals and uncountables:** “*I like dogs*”, “*water is expensive*”, “*she gives good advice*.”

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I am going to office.*

*I am going to **the** office.*

*She is doctor in Chennai.*

*She is **a** doctor in Chennai.*

*Give me pen.*

*Give me **a** pen. / Give me **the** pen.*

*I took bus to station.*

*I took **a** bus to **the** station.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say these ten times each, with the article stressed slightly so you notice it: “*I am going to the office.*” “*She is a doctor.*” “*I need a pen.*” “*The manager called me.*” “*I took an auto to the station.*”
2. Describe your room out loud in ten sentences, using an article in every one. “*There is a window on the left. The table is near the door.*”
3. Say your morning routine in ten sentences, and force an article into each one.
4. Speak for one minute about your job. Record it, then count every missing article on playback.
5. Take the five sentences where you dropped articles and say each corrected version ten times.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I got a call from a client this morning. The client wants the report by Friday.*”

“*I am going to the bank, and then to the office.*”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

This is the definitive Indian English marker and it affects every language group, because articles simply do not exist in Hindi, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Punjabi or Odia. You will not fix it by understanding it — you already understand it. You fix it by speaking slowly enough to insert them, for several weeks.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write five sentences about today, and check every article twice.*

## DAY 42

DAY 42 OF 100

## Stop Saying *I Am Having*

*Focus:* Use the simple present for states, not the continuous.

Indian English uses the *-ing* form far more widely than international English, especially with verbs of state: “*I am having two brothers*”, “*I am knowing him*”, “*she is wanting a transfer*”. These are understood, and they are the second most recognisable feature after articles. The rule is short and mechanical, so this is one of the fastest wins in the book.

### LEARN

- **State verbs do not take *-ing*:** *have, know, understand, want, need, like, love, hate, believe, remember, prefer, own, mean, seem, agree.*
- **Say *I have, I know, I want, I understand*.** Present simple, always.
- ***Have* takes *-ing* only when it means an activity:** *having lunch, having a meeting, having a shower* are correct. *Having a brother* is not.
- **Action verbs do take *-ing* for right now:** “*I am working on it*”, “*she is calling the client*.” That use is fine and useful.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I am having two brothers.*

*I **have** two brothers.*

*I am knowing him since 2019.*

*I **have known** him since 2019.*

*She is wanting a transfer.*

*She **wants** a transfer.*

*I am not understanding the question.*

*I **do not understand** the question.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times: “*I have two brothers.*” “*I know him well.*” “*I want to change teams.*” “*I do not understand this part.*” “*I need more time.*” “*I remember the meeting.*”
2. Learn the state-verb list by heart and say it aloud three times: *have, know, understand, want, need, like, love, hate, believe, remember, prefer, own, mean, seem, agree.*
3. Contrast drill, ten times: “*I am having lunch*” (activity, correct) against “*I have a sister*” (state, correct). Feel which is which.
4. Describe your family, your preferences and your current work in ten sentences, using state verbs correctly.
5. Record one minute about what you like and dislike about your work. Count every wrong *-ing* on playback.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I have two sisters, and I know the area well.*”

“*I am having a meeting at four, and I need the figures before that.*”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The continuous is used far more broadly in Indian languages, so “*I am having*” feels natural and even more polite. Learn the fifteen-word state list and this error disappears almost entirely, because it is caused by that small closed set of verbs.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which state verb do I most often put into the *-ing* form?*

## DAY 43

DAY 43 OF 100

***I Did or I Have Done***

*Focus:* Use the present perfect for unfinished time, past simple for finished.

Indian English tends to use the past simple where international English uses the present perfect, and *since* with the wrong tense: “*I am working here since 2020*”. Getting this right matters because it is scored in interviews and tests, and because the two tenses genuinely mean different things: one says it is over, the other says it is still true.

**LEARN**

- **Past simple for a finished time:** *yesterday, last week, in 2019, this morning* (if the morning is over). “*I sent it yesterday.*”
- **Present perfect when the time is not finished or not stated:** “*I have sent it*” (some time before now, still relevant), “*I have worked here for five years*” (and I still do).
- **Since plus a point in time; for plus a length of time.** *since 2020, since Monday, since I joined I for five years, for two days, for a long time.*
- **With *since* or *for*, use *have been* plus *-ing* for ongoing activity:** “*I have been working here since 2020.*”

**INSTEAD OF****SAY THIS**

*I am working here since 2020.*

*I **have been** working here since 2020.*

*I am in this company for five years.*

*I **have been** in this company **for** five years.*

*Did you finish it? — Yes, I finish it.*

*Yes, I **have finished** it. I **finished** it yesterday.*

*I have sent it yesterday.*

*I **sent** it yesterday.*

**PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES**

1. Say each ten times: “*I have been working here for three years.*” “*I have been in this role since April.*” “*I have finished the first part.*” “*I sent it yesterday.*”
2. Contrast drill: say “*I have sent the report*” then “*I sent the report on Monday.*” Ten times. Note that adding a finished time forces the past simple.
3. Answer these aloud about yourself, five times each: *How long have you worked there? How long have you lived in this city? What have you finished this week? What did you do yesterday?*
4. Say ten sentences with *since* and ten with *for*, about your own life.
5. Record ninety seconds about your career so far, then check every *since* and *for* on playback.

**MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES**

“*I have been working in analytics for four years, and I joined this company in 2022.*”

“*I have finished the testing. I sent the summary yesterday evening.*”

**MOTHER TONGUE TRAP**

The “*since*” sentence is the one to fix first, because it appears in the first two minutes of every job interview: “*I am working here since 2020*” should be “*I have been working here since 2020.*” Drill that single sentence shape until it is automatic.

**JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH**

Write two true sentences about yourself with *since*, and two with *for*.

## DAY 44

DAY 44 OF 100

## Ask Questions the English Way

*Focus:* Invert once, and do not double the auxiliary.

Question formation is where careful speakers slip most, because English reorders the sentence and Indian languages usually do not. Two errors dominate: keeping statement order (“*You are coming?*” as a real question) and doubling the auxiliary (“*What did he said?*”). Both are noticed instantly in interviews.

## LEARN

- **Yes/no questions: put the auxiliary first.** “*Are you free?*” “*Did you send it?*” “*Have you finished?*” “*Can you help?*”
- **With *do/does/did*, the main verb goes back to its base form.** “*Did he **send** it?*” not *did he sent*. “*Does she **know**?*” not *does she knows*.
- **Wh-questions: question word, then the same inversion.** “*When did you send it?*” “*Why is he leaving?*”
- **Indirect questions do NOT invert.** “*Could you tell me where the office **is**?*” not *where is the office*. This is the polite form, so it matters.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*What did he said?*

*What did he **say**?*

*Where you are going?*

*Where **are you** going?*

*You are coming tomorrow?*

***Are you** coming tomorrow?*

*Can you tell me where is the station?*

*Can you tell me where **the station is**?*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times: “*Did you send the mail?*” “*Does she know about it?*” “*Have you spoken to him?*” “*Are they coming today?*” “*Can you check this?*”
2. Base-form drill, ten times: “*Did he **say** that?*” “*Did she **go**?*” “*Did they **send** it?*” “*Did you **take** the call?*”
3. Wh-questions, ten times: “*When did you join?*” “*Why is it delayed?*” “*How did you handle it?*” “*What does he want?*”
4. Indirect forms, ten times: “*Could you tell me where the meeting room is?*” “*Do you know when he is coming?*” “*May I ask what the budget is?*”
5. Ask a partner, or your recorder, fifteen questions in a row about anything. Play back and check every one for double auxiliaries.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*Did you get a chance to look at the file?*”

“*Could you tell me when the results will be out?*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Indian languages form questions largely by tone or by a question particle, without reordering the sentence. So statement order with a rising tone feels like a complete question — and in casual English it is acceptable. In interviews and formal speech, invert properly.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write five questions I asked today, corrected.*

## DAY 45

DAY 45 OF 100

# The Prepositions Indian English Changes

Focus: Fix the fifteen combinations that differ.

Prepositions are arbitrary in every language, and Indian English has settled on a set of combinations that differ from international usage: *discuss about*, *order for*, *cope up with*, *married with*. These are understood but they read as errors on paper and in interviews, and there are only about fifteen of them that matter, so this is a memorisation job with a clear end.

## LEARN

- **Some verbs take no preposition at all:** *discuss something*, *order something*, *request something*, *reach a place*, *join a company*, *marry someone*, *contact someone*, *answer something*.
- **Some are fixed and must be memorised:** *good at*, *interested in*, *depend on*, *listen to*, *wait for*, *apologise for*, *arrive at* (a place), *arrive in* (a city), *married to*.
- **Time prepositions:** *at* for clock times, *on* for days and dates, *in* for months, years and long periods.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*We discussed about the project.*

We **discussed** the project.

*I will revert back to you.*

I will **get back to** you.

*He is married with a doctor.*

He is **married to** a doctor.

*I am coping up with the work.*

I am **coping with** the work.

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each corrected form ten times: *discuss the plan*, *order a coffee*, *request a change*, *reach the office*, *join the company*, *contact the client*, *answer the question*, *marry her*.
2. Fixed pairs, ten times: *good at English*, *interested in the role*, *depends on the budget*, *listen to the recording*, *wait for the reply*, *apologise for the delay*, *arrive at the office*, *arrive in Mumbai*, *married to*.
3. Time drill, ten times: *at four o'clock*, *on Monday*, *on the fifteenth*, *in June*, *in 2026*, *in the morning*, *at night*.
4. Write ten sentences from your own work using these. Say each aloud twice.
5. Record thirty seconds describing a meeting you had, and check every preposition on playback.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“We discussed the budget on Monday and I will get back to you in the morning.”

“It depends on the client, but I am good at handling these calls.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Discuss about* and *revert back* are so widespread in Indian offices that they sound correct, and colleagues will not correct you. Both are marked as errors in international writing and in language tests. Fix these two first; they are the most frequent.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which three preposition habits do I need to break?



## DAY 46

DAY 46 OF 100

Drop the *Isn't It*

*Focus:* Use the matching tag question, or a neutral checker.

Indian English uses one all-purpose tag — *isn't it?*, *no?*, *na?* — at the end of any sentence. International English matches the tag to the verb, which is fiddly. The good news: you can avoid the whole system with two safe alternatives, and use the correct tags only when you want to.

## LEARN

- **The rule, if you want it: reverse the auxiliary.** Positive sentence, negative tag: “*You are coming, aren't you?*” “*He sent it, didn't he?*” “*She can help, can't she?*”
- **Negative sentence, positive tag:** “*You haven't finished, have you?*”
- **The two safe escapes:** “*right?*” and “*is that correct?*” Both work after any sentence and neither is wrong.
- **Or simply ask a full question:** “*Am I right in thinking the deadline moved?*”

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*You are coming tomorrow, isn't it?*

*You are coming tomorrow, **aren't you?** / ... **right?***

*He sent the file, isn't it?*

*He sent the file, **didn't he?***

*The meeting is at four, no?*

*The meeting is at four, **isn't it?** / ... **right?***

*We can start now, na?*

*We can start now, **can't we?***

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times: “*You are coming, aren't you?*” “*He sent it, didn't he?*” “*She can help, can't she?*” “*They have finished, haven't they?*” “*It is ready, isn't it?*”
2. Now the reverse direction, ten times: “*You haven't seen it, have you?*” “*He doesn't know, does he?*”
3. Practise the safe escape twenty times: take five statements and add “*right?*” to each.
4. Speak for a minute checking facts with a partner or your recorder, using a correct tag or *right?* each time.
5. Ban *isn't it* and *na* for the next week. Note every time you catch one.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*The deadline moved to the fifteenth, didn't it?*”

“*So we are meeting at four, right?*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Isn't it* as a universal tag comes straight from the single-form tag in Hindi and several other Indian languages, and *na* comes with it. It is harmless in India and instantly identifiable outside it. If the matching system feels like too much load while speaking, just use *right?* — it is correct everywhere.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*How many times did I catch myself saying isn't it or na today?*

## DAY 47

DAY 47 OF 100

# Modals: Sounding Sure, or Careful

*Focus: Use could, would, might and should deliberately.*

Modal verbs are how English expresses degree — of certainty, of obligation, of politeness. Speakers who use only *will* and *must* sound either over-certain or commanding, which is a common and unfair impression of Indian English in global teams. Modals are also the cheapest politeness tool available.

## LEARN

- **Certainty scale:** *will* (certain) > *should* (expected) > *may / might / could* (possible). “*It will be ready*” is a promise; “*it should be ready*” is an expectation.
- **Politeness scale for requests:** *can* < *could* < *would you be able to*. All three are fine; the later ones are softer.
- **Advice and obligation:** *should* (advice), *have to* (external requirement), *must* (strong, often written rules). In speech, prefer *should* and *have to*; *must* can sound harsh.
- **Past possibility:** *could have*, *should have*, *might have*. “*We should have told the client earlier.*”

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*You must send it today.*

*Could you send it today? / You'll need to send it today.*

*It will definitely be done by Friday (when unsure)*

*It **should** be done by Friday.*

*I want leave tomorrow.*

*Could I take tomorrow off?*

*You have to do like this.*

*I **would** do it this way. / You **could** try ...*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say the certainty ladder aloud ten times, about one real task: “*It will be ready. It should be ready. It might be ready.*” Feel the drop in commitment.
2. Say each request form ten times: “*Can you ... Could you ... Would you be able to ... Do you think you could ...*”
3. Take five instructions you give at work and rewrite each with *could* or *would*. Say each aloud.
4. Practise hedged estimates, ten times: “*It should take about two days.*” “*It might slip to Monday.*” “*We could probably manage Thursday.*”
5. Use three modals in real conversations today and note the reaction.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*It should be ready by Thursday, but it might slip if the data is late.*”

“*Could you take a look at this today? It would really help.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Direct translation from Indian languages often produces *must*, *have to* and bare imperatives where English expects a modal question. The words are correct; the effect is bossy. Adding *could* costs one syllable and changes how you are perceived by colleagues who do not share your context.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Rewrite two instructions I gave today using *could* or *would*.

## DAY 48

DAY 48 OF 100

## Reporting What Others Said

*Focus:* Shift the tense back, and drop the quotation habit.

You will report other people's words constantly at work: what the client said, what your manager wants, what the team decided. Indian English often reports in the present (*"He is saying that he will send it"*) or keeps the original words with *that*. The international pattern shifts the tense back one step, and it is quick to learn.

## LEARN

- **Shift back one step:** *is* becomes *was*, *will* becomes *would*, *can* becomes *could*, *have* becomes *had*, present becomes past.
- **Drop the pronoun change carefully:** *"I will send it"* becomes *"He said he would send it."*
- **Questions lose the inversion when reported:** *"When is the meeting?"* becomes *"She asked when the meeting was."*
- **Useful reporting verbs beyond said:** *told me, mentioned, explained, asked, confirmed, agreed, suggested, promised.*

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*He is saying that he will send it.*

He **said** he **would** send it.

*She told that the client is angry.*

She **told me** the client **was** angry.

*He asked me that when is the meeting.*

He asked me **when the meeting was.**

*Manager is telling to do it today.*

The manager **asked me to** do it today.

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times: *"He said he would send it."* *"She told me the client was unhappy."* *"They confirmed the date had changed."* *"He explained that the system was down."*
2. Reported questions, ten times: *"She asked when the meeting was."* *"He asked whether I had finished."* *"They asked how long it would take."*
3. Reported requests, ten times: *"He asked me to send it."* *"She told me not to wait."* *"They advised us to postpone."*
4. Take a real conversation you had today and report it out loud in five sentences, shifting every tense back.
5. Record it and check each verb.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"The client said they would confirm by Friday, and asked whether we could hold the price."*

*"She explained that the delay was on their side, and suggested we move the call."*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*"He told that ..."* is extremely common in Indian English. *Tell* needs a person: *told me, told the client, told us*. *Say* does not: *said that*. Fixing this one verb pattern removes a large share of reported-speech errors.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Report three things people said to me today, with the tense shifted.*

## DAY 49

DAY 49 OF 100

## Words That Have No Plural

*Focus:* Stop adding -s to uncountable nouns.

*Informations, furnitures, equipments, advices, staffs, luggages* are among the most recognisable Indian English forms. In English these nouns cannot be counted, so they never take -s and never take a. The list is short and closed, which makes this a one-day fix that pays off for the rest of your life.

### LEARN

- **The main uncountables:** *information, furniture, equipment, advice, luggage, baggage, staff, machinery, stationery, homework, work, research, feedback, progress, traffic, news, money, software, evidence, permission, accommodation.*
- **To count them, add a counting phrase:** *a piece of information, an item of furniture, a piece of advice, a bit of feedback, two pieces of equipment.*
- **News looks plural but is singular:** *"The news is good."*
- **Staff is a group:** *"The staff are ready" or "the staff members are ready." Never staffs.*

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I need some informations.*

*I need some **information**. / a piece of information*

*He gave me many advices.*

*He gave me a lot of **advice**. / several pieces of advice*

*We ordered new furnitures and equipments.*

*We ordered new **furniture** and **equipment**.*

*Our staffs are trained.*

*Our **staff** are trained. / staff members*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say the list aloud three times, then use each in a sentence: *information, furniture, equipment, advice, luggage, staff, feedback, progress, research, software, traffic, news, money.*
2. Counting-phrase drill, ten times: *a piece of information, a piece of advice, a bit of feedback, an item of furniture, two pieces of equipment, a lot of progress.*
3. Say each ten times: *"The news is good." "The staff are ready." "The feedback was useful." "We made good progress."*
4. Write ten sentences from your own work using these nouns correctly, and say each aloud twice.
5. Record thirty seconds about a project update, using at least five of these words.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"I need some more information before I can give you feedback."*

*"We have made good progress, and the staff are trained on the new software."*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

These forms are used in Indian newspapers, offices and even official documents, so they feel entirely standard. They are the fastest thing to correct in this whole stage, because the list is closed: learn twenty words and the error is gone permanently.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which three of these words have I always pluralised?*

## DAY 50

DAY 50 OF 100

## The Dozen Errors That Mark You Most

*Focus:* Audit yourself against the full list, and pick your three.

You now know the individual rules. This day is the audit: the twelve structures that international listeners, interviewers and examiners notice most in Indian English. You will not fix twelve habits at once. You will find your own three and drill only those, which is how habit change actually works.

### LEARN

- **The twelve:** missing articles; *am having* for states; *since* with the wrong tense; double auxiliary in questions; *discuss about* and *revert back*; *isn't it* as a universal tag; *informations* and *advices*; *told that*; missing third-person s; missing past-tense endings; *myself* used as *I*; *do the needful* and *kindly*.
- **Three is the maximum.** Choose the three that appear most in your own recording, and ignore the rest for now.
- **Drill with sentences, not rules.** Say ten correct sentences a day containing your three targets. Understanding is already done; installation is what remains.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Myself Rajesh, I am from Pune.*

*I'm Rajesh, and I'm from Pune.*

*Please do the needful and revert.*

*Could you take a look and let me know?*

*He don't have the file.*

*He **doesn't** have the file.*

*Yesterday I go to the client office.*

*Yesterday I **went** to the client's office.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Record two minutes answering: "Tell me about your current work and one problem you are dealing with."
2. Transcribe it. Actually write it out, word for word. This is slow, and it is the most valuable ninety minutes in the course if you do it properly.
3. Mark every instance of the twelve errors in your transcript. Count them.
4. Choose your top three by frequency. Write ten correct sentences for each, using your own real content.
5. Say those thirty sentences aloud, and keep the page. This is your personal error list for the rest of the course.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

| "I'm Rajesh. I have been working in logistics for six years, and I look after the Pune warehouse."

| "We discussed the delay yesterday, and I told the client we would confirm by Friday."

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Do not try to eliminate all twelve. Working on everything produces slow, anxious, self-monitoring speech, which is worse than fluent speech with three errors in it. Three at a time, for three weeks each.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What are my three errors? Write them as sentences, correct version only.*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Five Review

You have drilled the specific structures where Indian English differs: articles, state verbs, the present perfect with *since* and *for*, question inversion, prepositions, tag questions, modals, reported speech and uncountable nouns — and you have an audited personal list of your own three worst habits.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I put an article before every singular countable noun when I speak slowly.
- ☐ I say *I have, I know, I want* — not *I am having*.
- ☐ I can say *I have been working here since 2021* without thinking.
- ☐ I do not double the auxiliary: *What did he say?*
- ☐ I say *discuss the plan* and *get back to you*.
- ☐ I have stopped using *isn't it* and *na* as universal tags.
- ☐ I use *could, should* and *might* to soften and to hedge.
- ☐ I say *told me* with a person, and *said that* without one.
- ☐ I never add *-s* to *information, advice, equipment* or *staff*.
- ☐ I have transcribed two minutes of my own speech and chosen my three errors.

## RECORDING TEST

Record two minutes on “*What I do, and what I am working on now.*” Transcribe it fully. Count your errors against the twelve. Write the number and the date; you will do this again at the end of Stage Ten, and the change in that single number is the most objective measure of progress in this book.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Articles

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Tenses and *\*since\** / *\*for\**

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Question forms

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Prepositions and collocations

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Countable and uncountable nouns

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If accuracy collapses the moment you speak at normal speed, that is expected and it is not a failure. Accuracy comes back at speed only after weeks at slow speed. Speak deliberately slowly for two weeks with your three targets in mind, and let speed return on its own afterwards.

# Patterns and Chunks: Speaking Without Translating

DAYS 51-60

Fluent speakers do not build sentences word by word. They have several thousand ready-made word groups stored whole, and they slot content into them. This is why they can think and talk at the same time, and it is the real difference between someone who knows English and someone who speaks it. This stage gives you roughly two hundred high-value chunks organised by what you need to do with them: give an opinion, agree, disagree, explain, compare, soften, buy time and keep a conversation moving.

## BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Use twenty core sentence patterns to say almost anything.
- Give, support and soften an opinion without pausing to translate.
- Agree and disagree in a way that keeps the conversation comfortable.
- Explain, clarify and rephrase when you are not understood.
- Buy thinking time in English instead of falling silent.

## DAY 51

DAY 51 OF 100

## Twenty Patterns That Say Almost Anything

*Focus:* Learn twenty frames and fill them with your own content.

A pattern is a sentence with a hole in it. Once the pattern is automatic, your brain only has to supply the content, which is half the work and a quarter of the delay. Twenty patterns, properly drilled, will carry most of your daily speaking — and every one you learn frees attention for pronunciation and listening.

### LEARN

- **The pattern is fixed, the content changes.** “I am trying to \_\_\_\_\_”, “The problem is that \_\_\_\_\_”, “I was about to \_\_\_\_\_”.
- **Say each pattern with five different fillers.** One repetition teaches you a sentence; five teach you the pattern.
- **Choose patterns you actually need.** A pattern you will never use is vocabulary homework, not fluency training.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Learn these ten by heart, saying each five times with your own content: *I am trying to \_\_\_\_\_ · I was about to \_\_\_\_\_ · The problem is that \_\_\_\_\_ · What I need is \_\_\_\_\_ · I am not sure whether \_\_\_\_\_ · It depends on \_\_\_\_\_ · I would rather \_\_\_\_\_ · I am supposed to \_\_\_\_\_ · There is no point in \_\_\_\_\_ · The reason I \_\_\_\_\_ is that \_\_\_\_\_.*
2. Now these ten: *Would you mind \_\_\_\_\_? · I was wondering if \_\_\_\_\_ · Do you happen to know \_\_\_\_\_? · As far as I know, \_\_\_\_\_ · From what I understand, \_\_\_\_\_ · It looks like \_\_\_\_\_ · I have been meaning to \_\_\_\_\_ · It turned out that \_\_\_\_\_ · What surprised me was \_\_\_\_\_ · If I were you, I would \_\_\_\_\_.*
3. Take five patterns and use each in three sentences about your own work. Say all fifteen aloud.
4. Speak for two minutes on “my week so far” using at least eight of the twenty patterns. Record it.
5. Write the twenty patterns on one page and keep it where you will see it. Add five more each week from real English you hear.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I was about to send it, but the problem is that the figures changed.”

“As far as I know it depends on the client, so I would rather wait until Monday.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Learning single words from lists produces sentences that are grammatical but that nobody says — the main reason otherwise-strong Indian English sounds translated. Patterns and chunks fix this at the root, because you are learning English in the units English actually comes in.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which three patterns will I use tomorrow, and in what sentences?*



## DAY 52

DAY 52 OF 100

## Giving an Opinion

*Focus:* Say what you think, with the right level of confidence.

“What do you think?” is the most common invitation you will get in meetings, interviews and group discussions, and it is where hesitant speakers lose ground. Having six opinion openers ready means you begin speaking immediately, which buys you the time to work out what you actually think.

## LEARN

- **Neutral:** “I think ...” “In my opinion ...” “My view is that ...” “The way I see it ...”
- **Strong:** “I am convinced that ...” “I have no doubt that ...” “I strongly feel that ...”
- **Careful:** “I tend to think ...” “It seems to me that ...” “I could be wrong, but ...” “My instinct is that ...”
- **Then support it.** An opinion with no reason invites argument; an opinion with one reason invites discussion. Use *because*, *the main reason is*, *for example*.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*According to me, ...*

*In my opinion, ... / The way I see it, ...*

*I am thinking that we should wait.*

*I **think** we should wait.*

*As per my thinking ...*

*My view is that ...*

*It is my humble opinion only.*

*This is just my view, but ...*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say each opener five times with your own real content: *I think* · *In my opinion* · *My view is that* · *The way I see it* · *I tend to think* · *It seems to me that*.
2. Give an opinion plus a reason on five topics, out loud: your current project, working from home, your city's traffic, a film you saw, a tool your team uses.
3. Practise the confidence ladder on one topic: say your opinion strongly, then neutrally, then carefully. Hear the difference.
4. Answer “What do you think?” five times in a row, each time starting within two seconds and speaking for thirty seconds.
5. Record two of them and check that you began immediately and gave one reason.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“The way I see it, the risk is in the handover, not in the build. The main reason is that nobody owns it after release.”

“I could be wrong, but my instinct is that we should test with ten users first.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*According to me* is a direct translation pattern that is very common in Indian English and is not used by international speakers — *according to* is for other people and sources, not yourself. Also drop *humble* and *as per*; both make you sound smaller than you are.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my opinion on one work question, with one supporting reason.*

## DAY 53

DAY 53 OF 100

# Agreeing and Disagreeing

*Focus:* Have language ready for both, especially disagreement.

Most learners can agree and go silent when they disagree, because disagreement needs more language and carries social risk. That silence gets read as having no opinion, which costs you credibility over time. Six phrases remove the problem entirely, and softened disagreement is safer in English than blunt agreement is in most Indian offices.

## LEARN

- **Agreeing:** “Exactly.” “That is a fair point.” “I agree with that.” “You are right about ...” “That makes sense.”
- **Partly agreeing — the most useful category:** “I agree up to a point, but ...” “That is true, although ...” “I see what you mean, but ...” “There is something in that, though ...”
- **Disagreeing politely:** “I am not sure I agree.” “I see it slightly differently.” “I would question whether ...” “My concern with that is ...”
- **Always acknowledge before you disagree.** The acknowledgement is what makes the disagreement acceptable.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*No no, that is wrong.*

*I see it slightly differently — my concern is ...*

*I am not agreeing with you.*

*I am not sure I agree.*

*Same to same, I also think.*

*I agree — and I would add that ...*

*Silence when you disagree*

*Can I offer a different view?*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say each phrase five times: *That is a fair point · That makes sense · I agree up to a point, but · I see what you mean, but · I am not sure I agree · I see it slightly differently · My concern with that is.*
2. Take five statements you disagree with and respond aloud to each using acknowledge-then-disagree.
3. Practise the strongest polite form five times: *“I understand the logic, and I still think we should wait. Here is why.”*
4. With a partner, or your recorder, take a position and argue the opposite side for one minute using these phrases.
5. Use one softened disagreement with a real person today and note that nothing bad happens.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“That is a fair point, and my concern is the timeline. Two weeks is tight for testing.”

“I see what you mean, but I would question whether the client will accept it.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

In many Indian workplaces, disagreeing with a senior directly is genuinely risky, so silence is a rational habit rather than a language gap. Practise the softened forms first with peers and in low-stakes settings; they are designed so that disagreement costs you nothing.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What did I disagree with today and not say? Write the sentence I could have used.*

## DAY 54

DAY 54 OF 100

## Explaining and Clarifying

*Focus:* Rephrase when you are not understood, instead of repeating louder.

You will be misunderstood regularly, in any language, at any level. The skill is not avoiding it; it is recovering smoothly. Repeating the same words more loudly almost never works. Rephrasing with different, simpler words works nearly always, and it takes four stock phrases.

## LEARN

- **Signal the rephrase:** “Let me put it another way.” “What I mean is ...” “In other words ...” “To put it simply ...”
- **Change the words, not the volume.** If “we need to escalate” did not land, try “we need to tell someone more senior.”
- **Use an example.** “For example, last week ...” rescues more explanations than any definition.
- **Ask for clarification too:** “Sorry, do you mean ...?” “Could you say that again a bit more slowly?” “I did not catch the last part.”

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*What? What? Say again?*

*Sorry, I did not catch that — could you repeat it?*

*Repeating the same sentence louder*

*Let me put it another way.*

*You are not understanding.*

*I do not think I explained that well. Let me try again.*

*I told you already.*

*Sorry, I may not have been clear earlier.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say each five times: *Let me put it another way* · *What I mean is* · *In other words* · *To put it simply* · *For example*.
2. Take three technical things from your work and explain each twice: once normally, once as if to a ten-year-old.
3. Practise the asking phrases five times each: “Sorry, do you mean ...?” “Could you say that more slowly?” “I did not catch the last part.”
4. Explain your job in three versions, out loud: thirty seconds for a colleague, thirty for your grandmother, thirty for a client.
5. Record the grandmother version. If it contains any jargon, do it again.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Let me put it another way. We are not late — we are waiting for someone else.”

“Sorry, I did not catch the last part. Could you say it again?”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many learners feel that asking someone to repeat themselves exposes weak English, so they nod and guess. Guessing is the expensive option: you then act on the wrong information. Asking for a repeat is what confident professionals do, in every language.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*When did I nod without understanding today? What could I have asked?*

## DAY 55

DAY 55 OF 100

## Describing and Comparing

*Focus:* Describe things precisely and compare them clearly.

Describing and comparing are the backbone of work talk: this option against that one, this quarter against last, this tool against the alternative. They are also the most common tasks in speaking tests. Precise comparison language makes you sound analytical rather than vague, using the same information.

## LEARN

- **Comparatives need the right form:** *bigger, more expensive, better, worse, further*. Never *more bigger* or *more better*.
- **Degree words carry the precision:** *slightly, a bit, much, far, considerably, significantly*. “*Slightly cheaper*” and “*far cheaper*” are different arguments.
- **Similarity and difference:** “*the same as ...*” “*similar to ...*” “*different from ...*” “*whereas ...*” “*compared to ...*”
- **Describe in a fixed order:** size, age, colour, material, purpose. “*a small old blue plastic storage box*.” Native speakers follow this order automatically.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*This one is more better.*

*This one is **better**. / much better*

*It is different than that.*

*It is **different from** that.*

*Compare to last year, sales is up.*

***Compared to** last year, sales **are** up.*

*This is more cheap.*

*This is **cheaper**.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say each ten times: *slightly cheaper · much faster · far more expensive · significantly better · a bit slower · considerably higher*.
2. Compare five real pairs out loud, with a degree word and a reason: two phones, two cities, two tools at work, two months of results, two job offers.
3. Practise the description order: describe five objects near you using at least three adjectives in the correct order.
4. Speak for one minute comparing this year with last year at your work, using at least five comparison phrases.
5. Record it and check every comparative form.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*This option is slightly more expensive, but it is considerably faster, so it works out cheaper overall.*”

“*Compared to last quarter, complaints are down by about a third.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*More better, more cheaper* and *different than* are common and harmless in conversation, but they are marked in interviews and tests. Also avoid “*Compare to*” as a sentence opener; the correct form is “*Compared to*.”

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Compare two things at my work in three sentences, using degree words.*

## DAY 56

DAY 56 OF 100

## Cause, Effect and Sequence

*Focus:* Join your ideas so the listener can follow the logic.

A list of facts is not an explanation. The connectors — *because, so, therefore, which means, as a result, first, then, finally* — are what turn facts into an argument a listener can follow and remember. Speakers who omit them force the listener to work out the relationships, which is exactly the effort that makes people stop listening.

## LEARN

- **Cause:** *because, since, as, due to, owing to*. Use *because of* plus a noun, *because* plus a clause.
- **Effect:** *so, therefore, as a result, which means, consequently*. In speech, *so* and *which means* do most of the work.
- **Sequence:** *first, then, after that, once that is done, finally*. Essential for explaining any process.
- **Contrast:** *but, however, although, even though, on the other hand*. *However* starts a new sentence; *although* joins two clauses.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Due to the client asked, we changed it.*

**Because** the client asked, we changed it. / **Due to the client's request**, ...

*Although it was late, but we finished.*

*Although it was late, we finished.* (no *but*)

*Because of he was absent.*

**Because he was absent.** / **Because of his absence.**

*Firstly, secondly, thirdly, fourthly ...*

*First ... then ... finally ...*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each connector five times inside a real sentence about your work: *because · so · which means · as a result · although · however · first · then · finally*.
2. Explain one work process in five steps aloud, using *first, then, after that, once that is done, finally*.
3. Explain one problem and its consequence in three sentences, using *because* and *which means*.
4. Practise the contrast pair correctly ten times: “*Although the data was late, we finished on time.*” “*The data was late. However, we finished on time.*”
5. Record ninety seconds explaining something that went wrong at work, with causes and effects made explicit.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“The data arrived on Thursday, *which means* testing started two days late. As a result, we will need until the fifteenth.”

“First we validate the file, then we upload it, and finally the client approves it.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

“*Although ... but ...*” in one sentence is a direct transfer from several Indian languages, where the pair is correct. In English you use one or the other, never both. Also prefer *first / then / finally* over *firstly / secondly*, which sounds like a written essay.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Explain one thing that happened today using *because* and *which means*.

## DAY 57

DAY 57 OF 100

## Softeners and Hedges

*Focus:* Take the edge off statements that could sound blunt.

English carries politeness in small softening words that Indian English often omits: *a bit, quite, might, seems, I am afraid, to be honest*. Without them, factual statements can land as criticism, and international colleagues sometimes read Indian directness as rudeness — while Indian speakers read the softening as vagueness. Both readings are wrong, and both are fixable.

## LEARN

- **Soften an assessment:** “*It is a bit late*” rather than “*it is late*”; “*there seems to be a problem*” rather than “*there is a problem*.”
- **Soften bad news:** “*I am afraid ...*” “*Unfortunately ...*” “*It looks like we will not ...*”
- **Soften a correction:** “*Actually, I think it was Thursday*” rather than “*no, it was Thursday*.”
- **Do not over-hedge.** Three softeners in one sentence makes you sound unsure. One is enough.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Your calculation is wrong.*

*I think there might be an error in the calculation.*

*That is not possible.*

*That would be difficult, I am afraid.*

*You did not send it.*

*I do not think I received it — could you check?*

*No, it was Thursday.*

*Actually, I think it was Thursday.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each five times: *a bit · quite · slightly · it seems · I am afraid · unfortunately · it looks like · to be honest · I think there might be*.
2. Take five blunt statements and soften each aloud. Use real examples from your own work.
3. Practise delivering bad news three times: “*I am afraid we will not make Friday. It looks like Monday is realistic.*”
4. Practise the soft correction five times: “*Actually, I think ...*” Note that *actually* here means *let me correct this gently*.
5. Use two softeners in real conversations today and notice how they are received.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I am afraid there might be a problem with the invoice — could you take a look?*”

“*It is a bit tight, to be honest. Monday would be safer.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

There is a real cultural asymmetry here, and it runs in both directions. Indian English is often more direct in stating facts and more formal in showing respect; British and American English are the reverse. Neither is better. Knowing the difference lets you choose.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Soften one blunt thing I said today.*

## DAY 58

DAY 58 OF 100

## Buying Time Without Fillers

*Focus:* Fill your thinking pauses with real English, not *aaa* or *means*.

Everyone needs thinking time while speaking. The question is what you put in the gap. Indian English commonly uses *actually*, *basically*, *means*, *like that only*, *you know*, *na*, which mark the speech and add nothing. Native speakers use stalling phrases that sound thoughtful and buy the same time.

### LEARN

- **Legitimate stallers:** “That is a good question.” “Let me think for a second.” “The short answer is ...” “It depends, really.” “I would say ...”
- **Repeat the question to buy two seconds:** “Why did we choose that supplier? Mainly cost.”
- **Or use silence.** Two seconds of quiet reads as consideration. It always feels longer to you than to the listener.
- **Kill the specific fillers you actually use.** You cannot remove all of them at once; target your top two.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Actually, basically, means ...*

*The short answer is ...*

*Like that only.*

*Something like that. / More or less.*

*What I am saying is, na ...*

*What I mean is ...*

*Aaa ... mmm ... aaa ...*

*[two seconds of silence] / Let me think.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Record two minutes explaining how you do something at work. Count your fillers and write the number.
2. Learn five stallers by heart: *That is a good question* · *Let me think for a second* · *The short answer is* · *It depends, really* · *I would say*.
3. Re-record the same two minutes. Every time a filler starts, close your mouth and pause for one beat instead.
4. Count again. Most people halve the number in one sitting.
5. Practise the question-repeat technique with ten questions, out loud.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“That is a good question. The short answer is cost — the longer answer is that we already had the licence.”

“Let me think for a second. I would say about three weeks.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Means*, *like that only*, *na*, *no?* and *only* used for emphasis (“yesterday only I sent it”) are the distinctively Indian fillers. They are completely fine within India and immediately noticeable outside it. Replace your top two, not all of them.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

What are my top two fillers, and what will I say instead?



## DAY 59

DAY 59 OF 100

## Numbers, Quantities and Trends

*Focus:* Say numbers and describe change accurately.

Numbers are where miscommunication becomes expensive, and Indian English has genuine differences: *lakh* and *crore* are not understood internationally, and *thousands* and *millions* need conversion. Add the vowel confusions from Day 29 and a single figure can derail a call. This day makes your numbers safe.

### LEARN

- **Convert for international listeners:** one lakh is a hundred thousand; ten lakh is one million; one crore is ten million. Say both if it helps: *“fifty lakh — that is five million.”*
- **Decimals and fractions:** *“three point five”, “two and a half”, “about a third”, “roughly half”.*
- **Trend verbs:** *rose, increased, went up, doubled / fell, dropped, declined, halved / stayed flat, levelled off.* Add a degree: *sharply, slightly, gradually, steadily.*
- **Approximating is professional, not weak:** *“around, roughly, about, just over, just under, in the region of.”*

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Sales is increased by 20 percent.*

*Sales **increased** by 20 per cent. / Sales **have** increased ...*

*Two lakhs fifty thousand to a foreign client*

*Two hundred and fifty thousand (or 0.25 million)*

*It is 15, not 50. (said unclearly)*

*Fifteen — one-five — not fifty.*

*The graph is going upside.*

*The trend is going **up**. / It is **rising steadily**.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Say ten real numbers from your work aloud, then repeat each digit by digit as confirmation.
2. Convert five Indian-format figures into international format, out loud: *five lakh, twenty lakh, one crore, three crore, fifty thousand.*
3. Trend drill, ten times: *rose sharply · increased slightly · fell steadily · dropped by about a third · stayed roughly flat · more than doubled.*
4. Describe one real trend from your work in five sentences, with numbers and degree words.
5. Record it and check that every figure would be unambiguous to a stranger.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“Complaints fell from about forty a week to twelve — that is a drop of roughly seventy per cent.”*

*“The budget is fifty lakh, which is about five hundred thousand US dollars.”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Lakh* and *crore* are correct English words in India and simply unknown to most listeners elsewhere. In an international meeting, lead with the international figure. Also avoid *“the same is enclosed”* and *“revert with figures”*; say *“I have attached it”* and *“send me the numbers.”*

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write three numbers from my work in international format.*



## DAY 60

DAY 60 OF 100

## Questions That Keep It Going

*Focus:* Ask so the other person keeps talking.

Conversation is not a test of how much you can say. Half of fluency is asking, because a good question keeps the conversation alive while you rest, and it makes the other person enjoy talking to you. This is also the safest possible practice: you speak eight words and receive thirty seconds of listening input.

### LEARN

- **Open questions get long answers.** *What, how and why* rather than yes-or-no forms.
- **Follow up on the specific detail** they gave you, not the general topic: *“Two years in Dubai — what was that like?”*
- **Echo plus question is the easiest move in English:** repeat two of their words and add *“what was that like?”* or *“how did that go?”*
- **Have three universal questions ready:** *“How did you get into that?” “What is the hardest part?” “What would you do differently?”*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Learn eight questions by heart, saying each five times: *What do you mean exactly? · How did you get into that? · What is the hardest part? · What happened next? · How long have you been doing that? · What made you choose that? · What would you do differently? · How is that going now?*
2. Practise the echo move ten times with invented answers: *“Six months in Chennai — how was that?”*
3. Have a five-minute conversation with someone where you ask at least eight questions and go three levels deep on one topic.
4. Count your share of the talking. Aim for well under half.
5. Write down one thing you learned that you would not have heard without the second question.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

| *“How did you get into this field in the first place?”*

| *“You said it was mostly fine — what was the part that was not?”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Learners often believe they must perform, and so they talk and talk while their accuracy collapses. Asking questions is not avoidance; it is what good conversationalists do in every language, and it gives you free listening practice with a real human.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which question got the longest answer today?*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Six Review

You now have roughly two hundred chunks and twenty patterns covering opinions, agreement, disagreement, explanation, comparison, logic, softening, stalling, numbers and questions. This is the stage that most reduces the delay between thinking and speaking, because you are no longer building sentences from individual words.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I know twenty sentence patterns by heart and use them.
- ☐ I can give an opinion within two seconds of being asked.
- ☐ I can disagree politely instead of going silent.
- ☐ I rephrase instead of repeating louder when I am not understood.
- ☐ I use degree words: *slightly, much, considerably*.
- ☐ I connect ideas with *because, so, which means, although*.
- ☐ I soften bad news with *I am afraid* and *it looks like*.
- ☐ I have replaced my top two fillers with real English stallers.
- ☐ I can give any figure in international format and confirm it digit by digit.
- ☐ I have eight follow-up questions ready to use.

## RECORDING TEST

Have a real ten-minute conversation, in English, with a person. Your targets: one opinion with a reason, one softened disagreement, one rephrase, one comparison with a degree word, three follow-up questions, and no more than three fillers. Afterwards write which of the six you managed. This is the first stage where the review is a real conversation rather than a recording — that is deliberate.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Patterns and chunks

Opinions and reasons

Agreeing and disagreeing

Explaining and rephrasing

Filler control

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If the chunks are not coming out in real conversation, you have learned them as a list rather than as speech. Fix it by over-using a single chunk for a whole day — use “*The thing is*” twenty times today, in every conversation. Overuse for one day installs it better than balanced practice for a week.

## PART SEVEN

---

# Everyday Conversation

DAYS 61-70

Everything so far has been training. This stage is where you take it outside. These ten days cover the conversations you actually have — greetings, small talk, phone calls, shops and autos, offices and hospitals, telling a story, explaining your family, explaining India to people who have never been here, joking, and getting out of a conversation politely. Each day gives you the exact language and then sends you out to use it with a real human being.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Greet and open a conversation with anyone, in any register.
- Make small talk for five minutes without running out of things to say.
- Handle a phone call in English without dread.
- Tell a two-minute story with a beginning, a middle and a point.
- Explain your family, your festivals and your country to someone with no context.

## DAY 61

DAY 61 OF 100

## Greetings and Openings

*Focus:* Match your greeting to the situation, Indian or international.

The first ten seconds set the tone, and Indian English has its own greeting conventions that are warm and correct here but read oddly abroad — “*What is your good name?*”, “*Respected sir*”, “*Myself Rajesh*.” You need both registers: one for your own context, one for the international room.

## LEARN

- **Introducing yourself:** “*Hi, I am Rajesh*” or “*I’m Rajesh — nice to meet you.*” Never “*Myself Rajesh.*”
- **Asking a name:** “*Sorry, what was your name?*” Never “*your good name.*”
- **Neutral openers that work anywhere:** “*How are you?*” “*How is it going?*” “*How have you been?*” “*Good to see you.*”
- **Answer and return.** “*Good, thanks — and you?*” The return question is not optional in English; leaving it out sounds abrupt.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Myself Rajesh. What is your good name?*

*Hi, I’m Rajesh. Sorry, what was your name?*

*Respected Sir, good morning.*

*Good morning, Mr Sharma. I Morning, Anil.*

*I am fine and you? (flat, automatic)*

*Good, thanks — how about you?*

*Where do you stay? (meaning live)*

*Where do you live?*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each five times: “*Hi, I’m \_\_\_\_\_ — nice to meet you.*” “*Sorry, what was your name?*” “*How is it going?*” “*Good, thanks — and you?*” “*Good to see you again.*”
2. Rehearse a thirty-second self-introduction: name, what you do, one specific detail, then a question back.
3. Practise it three times in the mirror, then record it once.
4. Use a real greeting-and-return with five different people today, in English if possible.
5. Note which greeting felt most natural, and use that one as your default.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*Hi, I’m Priya. I look after the support team here. How about you — which team are you in?*”

“*Good to see you again. How have you been?*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Good name, myself, do the needful, out of station and stay for live* are all standard Indian English and completely appropriate within India. Outside it they mark you immediately. Keep both sets and switch consciously; that is bilingual skill, not correction.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my thirty-second self-introduction, in full.*

## DAY 62

DAY 62 OF 100

## Small Talk That Does Not Stall

*Focus:* Four topic territories you can never exhaust.

Small talk is not pointless chatter; it is how strangers become people you can ask for things. The fear is running out of topics, and four categories remove that fear permanently: family, occupation, recreation and plans. They work in Bengaluru and in Boston.

### LEARN

- **Family:** who they live with, where they are from, their home town. Handle gently and follow their lead.
- **Occupation:** what they do, how they got into it, the best and worst parts. *“How did you get into that?”* is the strongest question here.
- **Recreation:** weekends, sport, food, films, travel. The safest and richest ground.
- **Plans:** what is coming up — a trip, a festival, a move, a course. Instantly more interesting than the present.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write two questions for each territory in your own words. Eight questions total.
2. Say each aloud five times so they come out without hesitation.
3. Practise the topic change out loud: pick up something they said, then move category. *“You said you moved here for work — what do you do at weekends?”*
4. Have a five-minute conversation covering at least three of the four territories. With a partner, a colleague, or a stranger.
5. Note which territory dried up fastest. Write two better questions for it.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

- | *“Are you from Pune originally, or did you move here for work?”*
- | *“Anything planned for the long weekend?”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Two adjustments for international small talk: questions about salary, marital status, religion and caste are normal in some Indian contexts and are considered intrusive in most Western professional settings. And *“What is your native place?”* becomes *“Where are you from originally?”*

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which of the four territories do I find hardest? Write two questions for it.*

## DAY 63

DAY 63 OF 100

## On the Phone

*Focus:* Handle a call without seeing the other person's face.

The phone is the hardest everyday speaking situation: no lips to watch, no gestures, compressed sound, and often a bad line. It is also where most work English happens. The fix is partly pronunciation and mostly structure — knowing exactly what to say at each stage means you are never composing under pressure.

## LEARN

- **Open with three things:** who you are, why you are calling, how long it will take. *“Hi, this is Rajesh from Acme. I need five minutes on the invoice — is now okay?”*
- **Spell and confirm everything critical.** Use the phonetic habit: *“P for Papa, R for Romeo.”* Repeat numbers digit by digit.
- **Say when you cannot hear.** *“Sorry, the line is breaking up — could you repeat that?”* Normal on every call, everywhere.
- **Close by summarising:** *“So I will send the revised invoice today and you will confirm by Friday. Thanks for your time.”*

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Hello, who is this? Tell me.*

*Hi, this is Rajesh from Acme — am I speaking to Ms Rao?*

*Hello? Hello? Not audible.*

*Sorry, you are breaking up — could you repeat that?*

*Ok ok, bye bye. (abrupt)*

*Thanks for your time — I will send that across today. Bye.*

*One minute, hold.*

*Could you hold for a moment, please? I will be right back.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write and rehearse your standard call opening, three times aloud: name, company, purpose, time needed.
2. Practise spelling your own name, your company and your email address aloud, letter by letter, five times.
3. Learn four line-trouble phrases by heart: *“You are breaking up.” “Could you speak up a little?” “I missed the last part.” “Shall I call you back?”*
4. Make one real phone call in English today, however small. Record your side if you can, and check your opening and closing.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“Hi, this is Priya from the support team. I am calling about ticket four-five-two-one. Is now a good time?”*

*“Just to confirm: Thursday the fifteenth, at two thirty. Correct?”*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

A phone line loses exactly the sounds from Stage Two: *th*, *v* and *w*, *f* and *p*, and final consonants. Slow down twenty per cent on calls and over-articulate word endings.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What went wrong on my last English phone call? What would I say differently?*

## DAY 64

DAY 64 OF 100

## Shops, Autos, Restaurants, Travel

*Focus: Low-stakes practice with strangers, every single day.*

Strangers you will never meet again are the safest practice ground in the world: there is no history to protect and no consequence to a mistake. These transactions are also short, predictable and repeatable, which makes them perfect for installing habits. Two of these a day is the most reliable practice schedule in this book.

### LEARN

- **Requesting:** “Could I have ...” “Do you have ... in a larger size?” “Could you help me find ...”
- **Asking about price and quantity:** “How much is this one?” “Is that the price for both?” “Do you take cards?”
- **Travel:** “Which platform does it leave from?” “Does this bus go to ...?” “How long does it take from here?”
- **Restaurant:** “Could we get the menu?” “What would you recommend?” “Is it very spicy?” “Could we get the bill, please?”

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Give me one coffee.*

*Could I have a coffee, please?*

*How much this?*

*How much is this?*

*Bill please, fast.*

*Could we get the bill when you have a moment?*

*This bus going Andheri?*

*Does this bus go to Andheri?*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Say each request five times: “Could I have ...” “Do you have ...” “How much is ...” “Could you help me find ...” “What would you recommend?”
2. Rehearse three complete transactions aloud: buying something, ordering food, asking directions. Play both roles.
3. Go out and do two real transactions in English today. A shop, a cafe, a chemist, a driver, a security guard.
4. Add one extra sentence beyond the transaction — a comment or a question. That extra sentence is where the practice actually is.
5. Note what happened. If someone replied in your first language, that is fine and common; continue in English anyway.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

| “Could I have a masala chai and one plain dosa, please?”

| “Sorry, does this train stop at Dadar?”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many learners avoid English with Indian strangers because it can feel like showing off, and because the reply often comes in the local language. Neither matters. You are training your mouth, not conducting an exam, and nobody is grading you.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*How many real English sentences did I say to strangers today?*

## DAY 65

DAY 65 OF 100

## Offices, Banks, Hospitals

*Focus:* Handle formal transactions where the details matter.

These are high-consequence conversations — a bank form, a medical appointment, a government office, a landlord dispute — where being unclear costs you money or health. They also have predictable structures, so you can prepare almost the whole conversation in advance.

## LEARN

- **State your business in one sentence.** *“I am here to update the address on my account.”* Then wait.
- **Ask about the process, not just the answer:** *“What documents do I need?” “How long does it usually take?” “Who should I follow up with?”*
- **Describe a problem clearly:** what, when, what you have already tried. *“The payment failed twice, on Monday and Tuesday. I have already tried a different card.”*
- **Get it in writing.** *“Could you email me a confirmation?” “Is there a reference number for this?”*

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*I am having a problem, please solve.*

*I have an issue with my account — could you help me with it?*

*Kindly do the needful for my address change.*

*Could you update my address? I have brought the proof.*

*Doctor, my stomach is paining.*

*I have a pain in my stomach. / My stomach hurts.*

*I am not getting your point, sir.*

*Sorry, could you explain that part again?*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write your business in one sentence for three real situations you might face this year: a bank, a doctor, an office.
2. Rehearse each aloud three times, then add the three process questions.
3. Practise describing a physical symptom accurately: *“It started three days ago.” “It hurts when I move.” “It comes and goes.” “I have had a fever since Monday.”*
4. Practise the written-confirmation request five times.
5. Do one real formal transaction in English this week if you can, even a phone enquiry.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“I am here to update the address on my account. I have brought the ID proof and a rent agreement.”*

*“It started about three days ago, and it hurts most in the morning.”*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*“My head is paining”* is Indian English; international English uses *“I have a headache”* or *“my head hurts.”* With doctors especially, use the standard forms — medical staff abroad may genuinely not follow *paining*, and this is a situation where being understood matters more than usual.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write the one sentence I would use to open my next formal appointment.*



## DAY 66

DAY 66 OF 100

## Telling a Story

*Focus:* Two minutes, with a beginning, a middle and a point.

Stories are how people remember you — in interviews, at dinners, in meetings. Most learners either give a one-line summary or ramble for five minutes with no point. A simple four-part structure fixes both, and the past-tense drilling you did in Stage One pays off directly here.

## LEARN

- **Four parts:** set the scene (when, where, who), then the problem, then what happened, then the point or the result.
- **Use past tense throughout, and keep the endings audible.** This is where dropped *-ed* endings do the most damage.
- **Storytelling connectors:** *so, then, anyway, suddenly, in the end, it turned out that*. These carry the momentum.
- **Land the point.** *“So now I always check twice.”* A story without a final line feels unfinished.

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Choose one true story from your life that takes two minutes. Write the four parts in one line each.
2. Tell it aloud three times, timing yourself. Cut anything that is not scene, problem, event or point.
3. Tell it a fourth time using at least five connectors: *so, then, anyway, suddenly, in the end*.
4. Record it. Listen specifically for past-tense endings and for whether the point lands.
5. Tell it to a real person today and watch where their attention rises and falls.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“So last year we had a launch on a Friday evening. About an hour before, the payment system went down ...”

“In the end it turned out to be a config file. So now I always check that first.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Indian storytelling often gives generous background before reaching the event, which is a genuine cultural style and works well among people who share your context. International listeners — especially interviewers — expect the problem within about fifteen seconds. Cut the run-up, keep the story.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write the four parts of one story I can tell in two minutes.*

## DAY 67

DAY 67 OF 100

## Talking About Family Clearly

*Focus:* Use kinship words that international listeners understand.

Indian family vocabulary is more precise than English, and the workarounds we use — *cousin brother*, *real sister*, *co-brother*, *own uncle* — are not English at all and cause genuine confusion abroad. Family also comes up in every interview, visa interview and first conversation, so it is worth getting right once.

## LEARN

- **English has fewer kinship words, so add a description instead:** “*my cousin*”, and if it matters, “*my cousin — my father’s brother’s son.*”
- **No *real* or *own*.** Brother means brother. If you need to distinguish, say “*my older brother*” or “*my stepbrother.*”
- **Uncle and aunt cover both sides**, and are used only for actual relatives in international English — not for older strangers or neighbours.
- **In-laws:** *mother-in-law*, *father-in-law*, *brother-in-law*, *sister-in-law*. No *co-brother* or *co-sister*.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*He is my cousin brother.*

*He is my cousin. / He is my cousin — my uncle’s son.*

*She is my real sister.*

*She is my sister.*

*My co-brother is a doctor.*

*My wife’s sister’s husband is a doctor. / My brother-in-law*

*I have two sisters, both are elder to me.*

*I have two sisters, both **older than** me.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Describe your family in ten sentences aloud, using only standard English kinship words.
2. Say each five times: “*I have an older brother and a younger sister.*” “*I live with my parents.*” “*My cousin works in Bengaluru.*”
3. Practise the comparison form ten times: *older than me*, *younger than me*, *two years older*, *five years younger*.
4. Practise describing three relatives with a clarifying phrase: “*my aunt — my mother’s sister.*”
5. Record ninety seconds about your family and check every kinship word.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I have an older brother and a younger sister. My brother is three years older than me.*”

“*I live with my parents in Pune, and my cousin — my uncle’s daughter — lives nearby.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Cousin brother* and *real brother* exist because Indian languages distinguish these relationships and English does not, so they are solving a real problem — they are simply not English solutions. Use *cousin* plus a description when the detail matters.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Describe three of my relatives in correct English kinship terms.*

## DAY 68

DAY 68 OF 100

## Explaining India to Outsiders

*Focus:* Describe food, festivals and context without assuming knowledge.

In any international team you will be asked about India constantly, and it is an opportunity: you have something the other person genuinely wants to hear. But it needs translation — naming a festival is not explaining it.

## LEARN

- **Name it, then explain it in one line, then give a comparison.** “*Diwali — it is the festival of lights, the biggest holiday of the year. Think Christmas, in terms of how much it matters.*”
- **Explain food by taste and texture, not just by name:** “*dosa — a thin, crisp rice pancake, usually with a potato filling.*”
- **Convert the units:** distances in kilometres, money in dollars or euros, temperature in Celsius with a comparison.
- **Give scale by comparison:** “*My state has more people than Germany.*”

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*We have Diwali holiday. (no explanation)*

*Diwali is our biggest festival — the festival of lights. Most of the country is off for a week.*

*It is 40 degrees. (no context)*

*It is forty degrees — about a hundred and four Fahrenheit, so nobody goes out at noon.*

*My city is having one crore people.*

*My city has about ten million people — slightly more than London.*

*It is a normal food item only.*

*It is an everyday dish — most people eat it for breakfast.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Prepare three one-line explanations: one festival, one dish, one thing about your city. Include a comparison in each.
2. Say each aloud five times, keeping each under twenty seconds.
3. Practise unit conversion aloud: your city's population, your commute distance, today's temperature, a typical salary range, all in international terms.
4. Explain one Indian custom to an imaginary foreign colleague in thirty seconds. Record it.
5. Check: did you assume any knowledge? If a listener would need to ask a follow-up to understand the basics, tighten it.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*Holi is the spring festival — people throw coloured powder at each other. It is joyful and completely chaotic.*”

“*My commute is about twenty kilometres, which sounds short until you see the traffic — it takes ninety minutes.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The opposite error also exists: apologising for India, or presenting it as exotic. Describe it plainly, with specifics and a comparison, as you would describe anywhere.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my one-line explanation of one festival, with a comparison.*

## DAY 69

DAY 69 OF 100

## Light Humour and Warmth

*Focus:* Be warm in English without taking risks.

Warmth is what makes people want to talk to you again, and humour is its fastest route — but humour is also the easiest thing to get wrong in a second language and a different culture. The safe forms are shared observation and mild self-deprecation. Both work everywhere, and neither can offend anyone.

### LEARN

- **Aim at the situation, not at people:** traffic, weather, technology, meetings that could have been an email. Shared experience, no target.
- **Mild self-deprecation is the safest humour in English:** *"I have already broken the coffee machine once today."* Keep it light; heavy self-criticism makes people uncomfortable.
- **Laughing at other people's jokes counts for more than making them.** Being someone who finds things funny is most of the work.
- **Skip word-play and translated jokes.** Puns rarely survive translation, and a joke that needs explaining has already failed.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Explaining a joke after it fails*

Smiling and moving on: *"Anyway — where were we?"*

*Sarcasm about a colleague*

A comment about the situation instead

*It is a joke only, do not mind.*

*Sorry — that did not come out right.*

*Silence when others joke*

*"That is true, actually."* plus a laugh

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write three light observations about shared frustrations in your workplace or city.
2. Say each aloud until the timing feels natural. Humour is delivery, so this is worth the repetition.
3. Prepare one mild self-deprecating line about something genuinely low-stakes.
4. Use one of them with a real person today. If it does not land, move on smoothly — that recovery is the skill.
5. Spend one day noticing when others make jokes and responding warmly instead of neutrally.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"This meeting has now outlived two of my calendar invitations."*

*"I have read this document three times and I am still not sure it is in English."*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Two things travel badly: jokes that need cultural knowledge, and anything about someone's appearance, weight, marriage or family — acceptable teasing in some Indian circles, and a serious problem in most international workplaces. When unsure, aim at the situation.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What made someone smile today? What did I say?*

## DAY 70

DAY 70 OF 100

## Ending Well and Staying in Touch

*Focus:* Leave a conversation cleanly and follow up.

Fear of not being able to end a conversation is a real reason people avoid starting one. A reliable three-part exit makes the whole thing lower risk. And a short follow-up message afterwards is what turns a pleasant conversation into a contact who remembers you a year later — which almost nobody does.

## LEARN

- **Signal, value, leave.** Signal the ending, say what was worth having, state what you are doing next. Eight seconds.
- **Do not invent an excuse.** “*I am going to grab a coffee and say hello to a few more people*” is honest and entirely acceptable.
- **Add a bridge if you want to continue:** “*Can I message you about that?*” converts a conversation into a contact.
- **Follow up within two days**, referencing one specific thing they said. Four sentences is plenty.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Fading out: shorter answers, looking away*

*“I should let you go — it was good talking to you.”*

*Ok, bye. (abrupt)*

*“It was really good to meet you. I will send you that link.”*

*We will meet sometime. (vague)*

*“Are you free for a call next week?”*

*No follow-up at all*

A four-sentence message within two days

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write and memorise three exit lines: one for an event, one for the office, one for a phone call.
2. Say each five times until it comes out without hesitation.
3. Practise the bridge: exit plus one specific next step, five times.
4. Write a four-sentence follow-up message: where you met, the specific thing they said, something useful you can send, an open door.
5. Use one exit line and send one real follow-up message today.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I should let you go — it was really good talking to you. Can I message you about that course?*”

“*Thanks for your time. I will send the summary across this evening.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Ending with “*we will meet sometime*” or “*I will call you*” and then not doing it is common courtesy in some contexts and reads as an empty promise in others. Either propose something specific or close warmly without a commitment.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Who did I speak to today that I should follow up with tomorrow?*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Seven Review

You have taken the training outside. You can greet in both registers, make small talk across four territories, handle a phone call, run everyday and formal transactions, tell a structured story, describe your family and your country clearly, be warm without risk, and leave and follow up properly.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I introduce myself with “I’m \_\_\_\_\_”, never “Myself \_\_\_\_\_”.
- ☐ I can make small talk for five minutes using four topic territories.
- ☐ I have made at least one phone call in English this stage.
- ☐ I have done two real transactions in English with strangers.
- ☐ I can state my business in one sentence at a formal counter.
- ☐ I can tell a two-minute story with a point at the end.
- ☐ I say *cousin* and *older sister*, not *cousin brother* and *elder to me*.
- ☐ I can explain a festival and a dish with a comparison, in one line each.
- ☐ I have used one light, situation-based joke.
- ☐ I have used a three-part exit and sent one follow-up message.

## RECORDING TEST

Have one fifteen-minute conversation in English with a real human being, in person if possible. Include: a proper greeting with a return question, three of the four small-talk territories, one two-minute story, at least five follow-up questions, and a three-part exit. Afterwards write down what you learned about them — if you cannot remember anything, you were talking too much.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Greetings and introductions

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Small talk and follow-up questions

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Phone calls

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Storytelling

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Exits and follow-up

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If speaking to real people is still the hard part, reduce the size and raise the frequency: two thirty-second exchanges with strangers every day, for a month. Frequency removes fear; length does not. Nobody became a confident speaker by waiting until they felt ready.

## PART EIGHT

---

# English at Work

DAYS 71-80

This is the stage that changes your salary. Indian professionals are often technically stronger than their communication makes them look, and the gap costs promotions, client trust and credit for their own work. Ten days on the specific situations that matter: dropping the Indianisms that mark you in global rooms, standups, client calls, speaking up in meetings, asking for help, feedback in both directions, pushing back, presenting, and talking to seniors across cultures.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Replace the office Indianisms with international equivalents.
- Give a sixty-second status update that a manager can act on.
- Speak up in a meeting within the first ten minutes.
- Ask for help and clarification in a way that raises your credibility.
- Push back on an unreasonable request without damaging the relationship.

## DAY 71

DAY 71 OF 100

## Drop the Office Indianisms

Focus: Swap thirty phrases for their international equivalents.

Indian office English has its own well-established vocabulary — *do the needful*, *revert*, *prepone*, *out of station*, *kindly*, *the same* — which is perfectly correct within India and unknown, archaic or brusque outside it. If you work with global teams, or want to, this list is the single fastest change you can make. It takes one day and it lasts forever.

## LEARN

- **Most of these are old-fashioned rather than wrong.** *Do the needful* and *revert* were normal British business English a century ago and survived here. Outside India they sound either quaint or vague.
- **The replacement is always more specific.** *Do the needful* becomes an actual instruction: “*could you approve it and send it back?*”
- **Keep them for Indian contexts if you like.** This is register-switching, not self-correction. Two vocabularies, chosen deliberately.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Please do the needful and revert.*

*Could you approve it and let me know?*

*Can we postpone the meeting?*

*Could we move the meeting earlier?*

*He is out of station. / on leave only*

*He is out of town. / He is on leave.*

*Kindly find the same attached.*

*I have attached it. / The file is attached.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Learn these ten swaps and say each aloud five times: *do the needful* -> *take a look and confirm* · *revert* -> *reply / get back to me* · *prepone* -> *move earlier* · *out of station* -> *out of town* · *kindly* -> *please* · *the same* -> *it* · *intimate* -> *inform / let me know* · *discuss about* -> *discuss* · *cope up with* -> *cope with* · *order for* -> *order*.
2. Ten more: *myself Rajesh* -> *I'm Rajesh* · *what is your good name* -> *what was your name* · *pass out (of college)* -> *graduate* · *doubt* -> *question* · *today itself* -> *today* · *yesterday only* -> *just yesterday* · *like that only* -> *something like that* · *tell me* -> *how can I help?* · *no issues* -> *no problem* · *same to same* -> *exactly the same*.
3. Search your last twenty sent emails for these phrases. Count them; the number is usually a surprise.
4. Rewrite three real messages with the replacements, then read both versions aloud.
5. Pick your three most-used and ban them for a week.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*Could you review this and get back to me by Thursday?*”

“*I have a question about the second requirement — could we go through it?*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

*Doubt* is the one that causes real confusion: in Indian English it means *question*, but internationally “*I have a doubt*” suggests you distrust what you were told. Say “*I have a question*”. Similarly “*I passed out in 2019*” means you fainted; say *graduated*.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which three Indianisms do I use most? Write the replacement for each.



## DAY 72

DAY 72 OF 100

## The Standup and the Status Update

*Focus:* Sixty seconds: status, progress, blockers, ask.

Daily standups and weekly updates are where most people are quietly judged. Long, detailed accounts of effort read as poor prioritisation; a crisp update reads as someone who understands what matters. The same information, in a fixed order, changes how senior people see your judgement.

### LEARN

- **Lead with a status word:** *on track, at risk, blocked, done*. One word tells your manager whether to keep listening closely.
- **Report outcomes, not activity.** “*Payment flow is live for ten per cent of users*” rather than “*I worked on payments.*”
- **Name the blocker and who can clear it.** This is the entire reason the meeting exists.
- **Finish with your ask, or say there is none.** Both are useful; trailing off is not.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Yesterday I was doing the API work, then I was checking...*

*On track. The API is done and tested.*

*There is some small issue but I will manage.*

*Blocked: I need the test account from IT by Wednesday.*

*I am trying my best, sir.*

*It should be done by Thursday. I will flag it if that changes.*

*Nothing to update.*

*No change since yesterday — still on the migration, still on track.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write your real update in four lines: status word, progress, next, blocker or ask.
2. Say it aloud and time it. Cut until it is under sixty seconds.
3. Rewrite every activity phrase as an outcome. “*I was working on*” becomes “*X is now done / X is now live.*”
4. Practise the blocked version five times: “*Blocked. I need X from Y by Wednesday, otherwise the date moves.*”
5. Deliver it for real tomorrow and note whether anyone asked for more detail — if they did, the length was right.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*On track. Two of the three integrations are live and tested. Next: the third, then load testing. Nothing needed from anyone.*”

“*At risk. If I do not get sign-off by Thursday, the launch moves to the eighth. That is the whole update.*”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Two habits to unlearn: describing how hard you worked, which reads as justification rather than progress; and hiding a problem to avoid looking bad. Flagging a risk early is the single strongest credibility signal available to a junior employee anywhere in the world.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write tomorrow's update in four lines.*

## DAY 73

DAY 73 OF 100

## Client Calls With Global Teams

*Focus:* Be clear, be structured, and check understanding.

On an international client call you are dealing with three things at once: a compressed audio channel, listeners who do not share your context, and often several accents in one room. Structure carries more weight here than vocabulary, and checking understanding is not weakness — it is standard professional practice on every call in every country.

### LEARN

- **Open with the agenda and the time.** *“Three things today, about twenty minutes: the delay, the two options, and what I need from you.”*
- **Signpost each section.** *“That is the problem. Now the options.”* Listeners on a call cannot see your structure.
- **Check in every few minutes:** *“Does that make sense so far?” “Shall I go into the detail, or is the summary enough?”*
- **Summarise and confirm at the end,** with owners and dates. Then send it in writing the same day.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Starting with detail and no map*

*“Let me give you the headline first, then the detail.”*

*Yes yes, ok ok while not following*

*“Sorry, could I check one thing before we move on?”*

*I will revert with the same.*

*“I will send you the summary today.”*

*Ending with no summary*

*“So: you confirm by Friday, I send the revised plan Monday.”*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write the opening for your next real call: three items, total time, and the one decision you need.
2. Say it aloud five times until it is smooth.
3. Practise two signposting phrases and two check-in phrases, five times each.
4. Practise the closing summary: two actions with names and dates, then *“anything I have missed?”*
5. On your next real call, use the opening, one check-in and the closing summary. Note what changed.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“Before we start: three things, about twenty minutes, and I need one decision from you at the end.”*

*“Let me pause there — does that match what you are seeing on your side?”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Saying yes to show respect while not following is common and expensive, because you then act on the wrong information and the client discovers it later. Asking a clarifying question mid-call costs you nothing in international business culture and protects the relationship.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What is the opening line for my next client call?*

## DAY 74

DAY 74 OF 100

## Speaking Up in Meetings

*Focus:* Say something in the first ten minutes.

In meetings, silence is read as having nothing to contribute, whatever the real reason. The longer you wait, the higher the bar becomes in your own head. Speaking early and briefly resets it, and it is far easier than it sounds because your first contribution does not need to be brilliant.

## LEARN

- **Four low-risk entries:** ask a clarifying question; agree with a reason; build on what someone said; summarise where the discussion is.
- **Prepare two things beforehand.** One question and one point. Preparation is what makes people sound spontaneous.
- **Interrupt politely when you must:** “Can I add something here?” “Sorry, can I jump in?” “Before we move on — one thing.”
- **Say your point and stop.** Contributions over forty-five seconds get interrupted anyway.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Staying silent through the whole meeting*

“Can I check one thing before we move on?”

*Sorry sorry, excuse me, sorry...*

“Can I add something here?”

*I also feel the same as him only.*

“I agree with Sam, and I would add that ...”

*Speaking for three minutes when interrupted*

“Short point: ... Happy to say more if useful.”

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Before your next three meetings, write one question and one point you could make.
2. Say each aloud twice before the meeting. Rehearsal removes ninety per cent of the hesitation.
3. Learn the four entries by heart: “Can I check ...” “I agree with X because ...” “Adding to what X said ...” “So where we are is ...”
4. Practise the polite interrupt five times aloud, in a normal voice.
5. In your next meeting, speak within the first ten minutes, even if only to ask something.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Can I check one thing — are we assuming the budget is already approved?”

“Adding to what Ana said, the same issue applies to renewals.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Many Indian workplaces genuinely discourage juniors from speaking before seniors, so silence is often a learned professional habit rather than a language problem. In international teams the same silence is read as disengagement or weak ownership. Know which room you are in.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What did I not say in a meeting today? Write the sentence.*

## DAY 75

DAY 75 OF 100

## Asking for Help and Clarification

*Focus:* Ask in a way that shows judgement, not ignorance.

Most people avoid asking questions at work because they fear looking incapable, and instead spend hours guessing. A well-framed question does the opposite of exposing you: it shows you have thought about the problem, and it surfaces the wrong assumption before it becomes an expensive mistake.

### LEARN

- **Show your work first.** *“I have read the spec and tried two approaches. What I cannot work out is ...”* This converts a question into evidence of effort.
- **Ask about assumptions:** *“What are we assuming about the client's timeline?”* Often the highest-value question in the room.
- **Define done:** *“What does finished look like for this, and who signs it off?”* Ask this at the start of every task.
- **Ask the obvious question when nobody else will.** Frequently three other people also did not understand.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Sir, I have a doubt.*

*I have a question about the second requirement.*

*I am not able to do it.*

*I have tried X and Y. I am stuck on Z — could you point me to the right person?*

*Please explain again. (no context)*

*I followed the first part. Could you go over the data flow again?*

*Guessing and delivering the wrong thing*

*Before I start: what does done look like here?*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write the three questions you have been avoiding at work. For each, add the line *“what I have already tried is ...”*
2. Say each aloud three times, then ask one of them today.
3. Practise the assumption question and the define-done question five times each.
4. Practise the partial-understanding request: *“I followed up to the point where ... could you take it from there again?”*
5. Write down what happened when you asked. It is almost never as bad as expected.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“I have read the brief twice and tried two approaches. I am stuck on how the two systems share the customer record — who would know?”*

*“Before we commit: what are we assuming here that we have not verified?”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Asking questions you could answer with five minutes of reading is a genuine cost to colleagues; asking the question that reading exposed is a genuine contribution. And replace *doubt* with *question* — in international English, *“I have a doubt”* implies suspicion.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What question have I been avoiding? What is the cost of not asking it?*

## DAY 76

DAY 76 OF 100

## Feedback, Both Directions

*Focus:* Give it specifically; take it without defending.

Feedback conversations are where careers are shaped and relationships are damaged. Two skills cover most of it: describing a specific behaviour rather than judging a person, and receiving criticism without explaining, which is what makes people willing to tell you things in future.

## LEARN

- **Give it as behaviour, effect, request.** *"In the client call you answered before Ana finished, twice. She stopped contributing. Next time, let her finish."*
- **Never use character words:** *lazy, careless, negative, disorganised.* Describe what a camera would have recorded.
- **Receiving: pause, ask for an example, thank them, decide later.** *"Can you give me an example so I know what to watch for?"*
- **Do not explain in the moment.** *"Let me think about that and come back to you"* is a complete, strong response.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*You are always careless with the numbers.*

*Two of the figures in Friday's report were wrong. Could you double-check before sending?*

*Sir, it was not my mistake, actually the data...*

*Thank you — can you give me an example so I know what to look for?*

*Your English is bad. (as feedback you receive)*

*Which part was unclear? I would rather know.*

*Sorry sorry, I will never do it again.*

*Understood. I will add a check before sending.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write one piece of real feedback you owe someone, in behaviour-effect-request form. Remove every judgement word.
2. Say it aloud three times, then deliver it this week.
3. Write your own defensive reflex — explaining, blaming the data, going silent, over-apologising. Everyone has one.
4. Rehearse the four-step receiving response aloud until automatic: pause, example, thanks, think about it.
5. Ask one person today: *"What is one thing I could do better in our meetings?"* Then run the four steps.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

| *"Can I give you one thing from yesterday's call? It is small and specific."*

| *"That is useful, and it is fair. Can you give me one more example?"*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

In many Indian workplaces feedback arrives as blunt criticism, often publicly, so the learned response is either to apologise heavily or to defend. Both damage you in international settings. The neutral, curious response — asking for an example — reads as confidence everywhere.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What feedback do I owe someone? Write the behaviour-effect-request version.*

## DAY 77

DAY 77 OF 100

# Saying No and Pushing Back

*Focus: Decline or renegotiate without damaging the relationship.*

Saying yes to everything makes you unreliable, because you then miss things quietly. A clear no given early protects your reputation far better than a reluctant yes followed by a late delivery. This is harder in hierarchical workplaces, which is exactly why the conditional yes is the most useful tool here.

## LEARN

- **Acknowledge, decline, offer:** “I can see why this matters. I cannot take it on this week. What I can do is review the draft.”
- **The conditional yes is usually the best answer:** “Yes, if the report moves to the twentieth” or “yes, if we drop the newsletter.” It makes the trade-off visible instead of hidden.
- **Give a short, real reason.** One line. Long justifications invite negotiation.
- **Do not over-apologise.** One acknowledgement is enough; repeated apology invites them to reopen the request.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Yes sir, no problem. (when it is impossible)*

*I can do it by Wednesday, not by Monday. Which matters more?*

*I will try. (meaning no)*

*I do not think I can. Here is what I can do instead.*

*Sorry sorry, I am very sorry, actually I have...*

*I am at capacity this week. Could we look at next week?*

*That is not my work.*

*That sits with the platform team — shall I introduce you?*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. List three things you said yes to recently that you should have renegotiated.
2. Write the acknowledge-decline-offer version of each and say it aloud three times.
3. Write two conditional-yes sentences for requests you expect this week.
4. Practise the trade-off question five times: “If I take this on, which of the other two moves?”
5. Say no, or a conditional yes, to one real thing this week. Note what actually happened — usually nothing.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I can take it on if the audit moves to next week. Otherwise I will not do either properly — your call.”

“I cannot make Monday. Wednesday is realistic, and I will send a draft on Tuesday.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

“I will try” used to mean *no* is common in Indian workplaces and is understood locally. International managers hear it as *yes, probably*, and plan accordingly — then the deadline is missed and you are blamed for something you thought you had declined. Say the real answer.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

What should I have said no to this week? Write the sentence.

## DAY 78

DAY 78 OF 100

## Presenting to a Room

*Focus:* One message, three points, a designed opening and close.

Presentations are where technical people are judged as leaders. Most bad presentations are not delivery failures; they are structure failures — no clear message, too many points, and slides read aloud. Fixing the structure improves the delivery automatically, because you are no longer trying to remember what comes next.

### LEARN

- **Write the one-sentence message first:** “If they remember one thing, it should be ...” Everything that does not serve it comes out.
- **Three points, each with one example.** Announce the number at the start so listeners know how long to concentrate.
- **Never read your slides.** Six words or an image per slide; the words come from your mouth.
- **Rehearse aloud, standing, three times.** The first is a mess, the second finds the structure, the third is close to real.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Reading every word on the slide*

Slide says “Refunds: 11 days”; you explain why

*Today I am going to talk about...*

“Last month a customer waited eleven days for a four-rupee refund.”

*So, yeah, that is all. Any questions?*

“So: fix the help page before we hire. That is what I am asking for.”

*Sorry, I am not a good speaker.*

Say nothing about yourself; start with the content

### PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Take a real presentation you must give. Write the one-sentence message. Rewrite it until it is under twenty words.
2. Write three points, each with one example, on a single page. No slides yet.
3. Write and memorise the first thirty seconds and the last thirty seconds. These two are worth learning almost word for word.
4. Rehearse the whole thing aloud, standing, three times, timing each run.
5. Record the third run. Watch it once on mute for your body, once with eyes closed for your voice.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Three things, twelve minutes, and one decision I will ask you for at the end.”

“Let me finish with this: sixty per cent of our tickets are three questions we already know the answers to.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Reading slides word for word is the most common presentation habit in Indian corporate settings, and it is the fastest way to lose a room anywhere. If you need the words for safety, put them in your notes, not on the audience's screen.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What is the one sentence I want my audience to remember?*



## DAY 79

DAY 79 OF 100

## Speech Versus Writing

*Focus:* Say it simply; write it clearly. They are different jobs.

Indian professional writing tends to be more formal than international writing, while Indian speech is often more direct. Both mismatches cost you. Written English should be plainer than you think, and it must state the ask; spoken English should be softer than you think.

### LEARN

- **Write the way you would speak, then cut a third.** If you would never say a sentence aloud, do not write it.
- **Put the ask in the first line, with a deadline.** “*I need one decision from you: A or B, by Thursday.*”
- **Drop the formal shell:** *respected sir, please be advised, kindly find the same, awaiting your revert.* All can be deleted.
- **In writing, add warmth deliberately.** Text carries no tone, so readers supply their own, and under pressure they supply a negative one.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Respected Sir, Please be advised that...*

*Hi Anil — quick update on the invoice.*

*Kindly find the same attached for your perusal.*

*I have attached the file.*

*Awaiting your revert at the earliest.*

*Could you reply by Thursday? I need it for the client call.*

*Thanking you in anticipation.*

*Thanks — much appreciated.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take an email you sent recently. Read it aloud. Mark every sentence you would not say to the person's face.
2. Rewrite it: ask in the first line, deadline stated, formal shell deleted, one line of warmth added.
3. List your five most-used stock phrases and write the plain replacement for each.
4. Practise the two-line message aloud five times: purpose, then ask with a date.
5. Send one rewritten message today and compare the reply speed with your usual.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*Hi Meera — one decision needed: supplier A or B. Both costed below. Thursday would help, because the price expires Friday.*”

“*Hope the launch went well. Quick one: has the invoice gone out?*”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The formal Indian business register signals respect here and reads as either archaic or evasive elsewhere. It is not a mistake — it is a different convention. Keep it for government and traditional Indian correspondence; use plain English with international colleagues.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Rewrite one email opening from today in plain English.*



## DAY 80

DAY 80 OF 100

## Talking to Seniors and Across Cultures

*Focus:* Adjust your directness deliberately, in both directions.

Indian professional culture is generally more hierarchical and more indirect with seniors; American culture is more direct and flatter; British is indirect but informal; German and Dutch are very direct. Reading these differences is a genuine professional skill, and misreading them gets you labelled unfairly — as either aggressive or as lacking ownership.

## LEARN

- **With flat, direct cultures:** give your opinion without being asked, disagree openly with reasons, use first names, skip the honorifics. Silence is read as not caring.
- **With indirect cultures:** soften with modals, offer options rather than verdicts, read what is *not* said.
- **With seniors anywhere:** bring options and a recommendation rather than a problem. That works in every culture.
- **Ask about the norms directly.** “How do you prefer to get updates — in writing or on a call?” Nobody minds being asked.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Sir, whatever you decide is fine.*

*I would recommend B, mainly because of the timeline. Happy to go with A if you prefer.*

*As per your kind instruction, I have done...*

*Done — here is what changed.*

*Waiting to be asked for your view*

*Can I offer a view on this?*

*You are wrong. (with a direct culture, still)*

*I see it differently — here is my concern.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write down the three cultures you work with most, and one sentence about how direct each is.
2. Practise the recommendation form five times: “I would recommend X, because Y. Happy to discuss.”
3. Practise volunteering an opinion unasked, five times: “Can I offer a view on this?”
4. Ask one senior colleague how they prefer to receive updates.
5. In one meeting this week, give an unrequested recommendation with a reason.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“I would recommend option B, mainly because it protects the launch date. I am comfortable with A if you would rather.”

“Can I offer a different view? I think the risk sits in the handover.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The most common unfair label for Indian professionals in global teams is “does not take ownership” — and it usually comes from deference that reads as passivity, not from any lack of capability. Stating a recommendation instead of waiting to be asked fixes most of it.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Where did I defer today when I should have recommended?*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Eight Review

You have replaced the office Indianisms, tightened your status updates, structured your client calls, learned to speak up early, to ask questions that build credibility, to give and take feedback, to say no, to present, to write plainly and to adjust your directness across cultures. This is the stage that shows up in your career.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I have replaced *do the needful*, *revert*, *prepone* and *doubt*.
- ☐ My status update is under sixty seconds and starts with a status word.
- ☐ I open client calls with an agenda and close with a summary.
- ☐ I speak within the first ten minutes of a meeting.
- ☐ I show what I have already tried when I ask for help.
- ☐ I can receive criticism without explaining or over-apologising.
- ☐ I have said a clear no, or a conditional yes, this stage.
- ☐ I have a one-sentence message and three points for my next presentation.
- ☐ My emails put the ask in the first line with a deadline.
- ☐ I give a recommendation instead of waiting to be asked.

## RECORDING TEST

Record a three-minute mock client update: the opening with an agenda, a status report on a real project, one problem with two options and a recommendation, and a closing summary with owners and dates. Then listen for four things: Indianisms, status word present, whether you gave a recommendation, and whether your closing summary had names and dates in it.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Dropping Indianisms

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Status updates

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Speaking up in meetings

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Feedback in both directions

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Boundaries and recommendations

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If speaking up is still the hard part, the obstacle is usually a specific person rather than the language. Prepare one sentence for that specific meeting each week and say it in the first ten minutes. Preparation beats confidence, and confidence follows afterwards — never the other way round.

# When It Counts: Interviews and High-Stakes English

DAYS 81-90

Interviews, group discussions, visa windows and speaking tests all share one feature: you have a few minutes, the other person has almost no information about you, and your English is carrying everything. These are also the most preparable conversations in existence, because the questions barely change. Ten days to build a bank of answers, learn the structures that hold under pressure, and rehearse the specific formats used in Indian hiring.

## BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Answer “*tell me about yourself*” in ninety structured seconds.
- Tell six work stories in STAR form, each under ninety seconds.
- Handle strengths, weaknesses, salary and “*why should we hire you*”.
- Enter and lead a group discussion without shouting or staying silent.
- Recover when you go blank, instead of freezing.

## DAY 81

DAY 81 OF 100

## Tell Me About Yourself

Focus: Ninety seconds: now, then, why here.

This is the first question in almost every interview, and it sets the interviewer's frame for everything after it. Most candidates either recite their whole life from school onward or give a fifteen-second answer. A structured ninety seconds signals judgement before you have said anything technical.

### LEARN

- **Three parts: now, then, why here.** What you do currently (twenty-five seconds), the relevant path that led there (thirty-five seconds), why you are in this room (thirty seconds).
- **Start with the present, not with birth.** “I currently lead a team of four in ...” Not “I was born in ... I did my tenth standard in ...”
- **Include one number.** Team size, years, volume, percentage. Numbers make you concrete and memorable.
- **End pointing at them:** “which is why this role interested me — it is the same problem at a larger scale.”

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Myself Rajesh. I am basically from Pune. My father is...*

*I'm Rajesh. I currently manage the Pune warehouse for a logistics firm — about forty staff.*

*I did my schooling from... then my twelfth...*

Start with now; mention education only if it is relevant

*I am hardworking and a quick learner.*

*I have cut dispatch errors by about a third in eighteen months.*

*That's all about me, sir.*

*... which is why this role interested me.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Write your answer in three labelled paragraphs: now, then, why here. Cap the whole thing at 200 words.
2. Add one number to the *now* section and one to the *then* section.
3. Say it aloud and time it. Target: eighty to ninety-five seconds. Cut, do not speed up.
4. Record it. Listen for filler words, for whether you started with the present, and for whether it ends pointing at the role.
5. Say it aloud five more times over the day, until you no longer need the paper.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“I'm Priya. I currently handle enterprise support for a payments company — about two hundred tickets a week across four analysts.”*

*“I moved into support from testing three years ago, because I wanted to be closer to the customer. This role is that, at a much bigger scale, which is why I applied.”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The standard Indian interview answer often begins with family background and full education history, which is expected in some Indian panels and is a serious weakness in most corporate and international interviews. Prepare both versions and choose based on the room.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Write my answer's three parts, one line each.

## DAY 82

DAY 82 OF 100

## Six Stories in STAR Form

Focus: Situation, Task, Action, Result — ninety seconds each.

Most interview questions are variations on “tell me about a time when ...”, and you cannot invent a good answer under pressure. Six prepared stories will cover almost every behavioural question you will ever face. The structure matters because unstructured answers wander through context and never reach the result, which is the only part being assessed.

## LEARN

- **Situation (fifteen seconds):** just enough context. Where, when, what was at stake.
- **Task (ten seconds):** your specific responsibility. Yours, not the team's.
- **Action (forty seconds):** what you did, in steps, using *I*. This is the bulk and where interviewers listen hardest.
- **Result (twenty seconds):** the outcome with a number, plus one line on what you learned.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*We faced many problems and we solved it somehow.*

*I called the client the same day, brought finance onto the call, and sent a written timeline within twenty-four hours.*

*Sixty seconds of background, ten of result*

Fifteen of background, twenty of result with a number

*We did it. (throughout)*

*I did X, then I asked Y to ... (use I where it is honest)*

*No result at all*

*They renewed, and billing errors fell by about eighty per cent.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Choose six real experiences: a success, a failure, a conflict, a leadership moment, a time you changed your mind, a technical challenge.
2. Write each in STAR form, under 180 words.
3. Say each aloud and time it. Cut anything over ninety seconds — always cut the Situation, never the Result.
4. Count the *we*s in each Action section and change most of them to *I* where honest.
5. Record two of them and check that a number appears in each Result.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Last spring our biggest client threatened to leave after a billing error. I was asked to own the recovery.”

“They renewed, and we cut billing errors by about eighty per cent by adding one approval step.”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Indian candidates often over-use *we* out of genuine modesty and team culture, and interviewers then cannot tell what you did — which reads as either exaggeration or as no personal contribution. Saying *I* about your own actions is accurate, not boastful.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

Which of my six stories is weakest? Is the gap in the action or the result?

## DAY 83

DAY 83 OF 100

## Strengths, Weaknesses, Why You

*Focus:* Answer the three predictable questions with evidence.

These three questions appear in almost every interview and almost everyone answers them badly — with adjectives instead of evidence, or with a fake weakness. Because they are so predictable, a prepared, specific answer stands out disproportionately.

## LEARN

- **Strength: name it, prove it, size it.** *"I am good at calming angry customers. Last quarter I handled every escalation for the team — about thirty — and we lost one account instead of four."*
- **Weakness: choose a real one, then show the system you built.** Not *"I am a perfectionist"*, which everybody says and nobody believes.
- **Why you: match your evidence to their problem.** Read the job description, pick the two hardest requirements, and give a story for each.
- **Never criticise a previous employer.** State what you are moving toward, not what you are escaping.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*My weakness is I am a perfectionist.*

*I used to take on too much and miss deadlines. Now I confirm scope in writing before I start, and I have not missed one this year.*

*I am hardworking, sincere and a fast learner.*

*I learn fast — I picked up the reporting tool in two weeks and now train new joiners on it.*

*My previous manager was very bad.*

*I want more ownership of the customer relationship than my current role allows.*

*You should hire me because I need this job.*

*You need someone who can handle escalations without a script. That is what I have done for three years.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write two strengths in the name-prove-size form, each with a number.
2. Write one real weakness plus the specific system you built to manage it. Say it aloud three times — it will feel uncomfortable, which is why you rehearse.
3. Take a real job description. List its two hardest requirements and write one story for each.
4. Practise the reason-for-leaving answer, framed as moving toward something. Five times aloud.
5. Record all four answers and check that each contains one specific fact.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"I am good at getting angry customers back on side. Last quarter I took every escalation — about thirty — and we retained all but one."*

*"I used to under-communicate when a task slipped. Now I flag anything at risk on the same day, in writing."*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Two habits from Indian interview coaching to unlearn: reciting adjective lists (*sincere, hardworking, punctual*), which carry no information; and the fake weakness. Interviewers hear both hundreds of times. One real number beats five adjectives.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my real weakness and the system I use to manage it.*

## DAY 84

DAY 84 OF 100

## Salary and Offer Conversations

*Focus:* Say a number calmly, and negotiate without apology.

This is the highest-value five minutes in your career, and most people rush it because talking about money in English feels doubly uncomfortable. The language is simple; the discomfort is the obstacle. Rehearsing the sentences out loud until they are boring is the entire technique.

## LEARN

- **Prepare three numbers:** your ideal, your minimum, and your alternative if there is no agreement. The alternative is where your calm comes from.
- **Deflect early questions politely:** *"I would rather understand the role fully first. Could you tell me the band for this position?"*
- **When you give a number, give a range with a reason** and stop talking. *"Based on my experience and the market, I am looking at eighteen to twenty-two lakh."*
- **Negotiate on the whole package:** notice period, joining date, title, learning budget, remote days, review timing.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Whatever the company policy is, sir.*

*Could you tell me the band for this role?*

*Sorry to ask, but what about salary?*

*Can we talk about compensation?*

*I need at least 15, because I have loans.*

*Based on the market and my experience, I am looking at 18 to 22.*

*Accepting instantly on the call*

*Thank you — could I have until Thursday to confirm?*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write your three numbers down. Then write the one-line justification for your ideal.
2. Say the number sentence aloud twenty times, until your voice does not change when you say it. This is the actual drill.
3. Practise the deflection five times, and the range-with-reason five times.
4. Practise the silence: say your number and then count three seconds without speaking. Most people talk themselves down in that gap.
5. Practise the thinking-time request: *"Could I have until Thursday to confirm?"*

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"Based on my experience and what I am seeing in the market, I am looking at eighteen to twenty-two lakh."*

*"Thank you — that is close. Would you be able to look at twenty, given the notice period I am giving up?"*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Discussing your current salary and personal financial need is common in Indian hiring and is a weak position: it anchors your offer to your past, not to the role's value. Where you can, talk about the market rate and the scope of the job instead.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my three numbers and the one-line justification.*

## DAY 85

DAY 85 OF 100

## Group Discussions

*Focus:* Enter early, build on others, and never shout.

The group discussion is a standard filter in Indian campus and corporate hiring, and it is scored on behaviour as much as content. Two failures dominate: staying silent and being overlooked, or shouting and being marked as aggressive. The winning position is early, structured and generous.

## LEARN

- **Enter in the first ninety seconds**, even briefly. Later entry means competing against an established flow.
- **Structure beats volume.** *“There are two sides to this. Let me take the economic one first”* wins more marks than loudness.
- **Build on people by name:** *“Adding to what Anil said ...”* Evaluators specifically look for this.
- **Summarising is the highest-scoring move**, and almost nobody does it: *“So far we have agreed on two things and we are split on the third.”*

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Shouting over someone to get in*

*“Can I add one point to that?”* said at normal volume

*Staying silent for the whole discussion*

*“Can I start by framing the question?”* in the first ninety seconds

*You are completely wrong.*

*I see it differently — my concern is ...*

*Repeating a point already made*

*“Building on Anil's point, the same applies to ...”*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Learn four entry lines by heart: *“Can I add a point?”* *“Can I start by framing the question?”* *“Building on what Anil said ...”* *“Can I bring in a different angle?”*
2. Take five common discussion topics and prepare a two-point structure for each: one economic point and one social point.
3. Practise the summarising move five times aloud.
4. Speak for ninety seconds on one topic with a clear structure, recorded. Then do a second topic cold.
5. If you can, run a real group discussion with four friends for fifteen minutes and ask each other who spoke most usefully.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“Can I start by narrowing the question? I think we are discussing two different things.”*

*“So far we agree on the cost point, and we are split on the timeline. Can we take the timeline?”*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

In many Indian group discussions the loudest candidates dominate, so the instinct is to match the volume. Evaluators are usually scoring the opposite: clarity, structure, listening and bringing quiet people in. Being the person who organises the discussion is the strongest position in the room.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which entry line will I use next time, and what is my two-point structure?*



## DAY 86

DAY 86 OF 100

## The HR Round and Campus Placement

*Focus:* Answer the standard questions without sounding rehearsed.

The HR round is a screening for judgement, stability and fit, not for technical skill, and it uses a small fixed set of questions. Preparing them removes almost all the anxiety. The one risk is sounding memorised, which you avoid by learning the structure and the facts rather than the words.

### LEARN

- **The standard set:** why this company; where do you see yourself in five years; why should we hire you; are you willing to relocate; how do you handle pressure; tell me about a conflict.
- **Research one specific thing about the company** and use it. *"I saw you launched in Indonesia last year"* beats any general praise.
- **Five-year answers should be about capability, not titles:** *"I want to be the person the team brings the hardest customer problems to."*
- **Learn structures and facts, never sentences.** A memorised paragraph collapses at the first follow-up question.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Your company is very reputed and big.*

*You are the only firm in this space doing your own last-mile delivery — that is the part I want to work on.*

*In five years I want to be a manager.*

*In five years I want to be leading a small team and owning a product area.*

*I can handle any pressure, sir.*

*During the March migration I worked two weekends and kept the client updated daily. That is how I handle it — by over-communicating.*

*I am willing to do anything.*

*I am open to relocating for the first two years.*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write one-paragraph answers to all six standard questions. Facts and structure only, no memorised sentences.
2. Research one specific, checkable fact about a company you are targeting, and write the sentence that uses it.
3. Say each answer aloud twice, then have someone ask them out of order so you cannot rely on sequence.
4. Record three answers. Listen for whether you sound rehearsed — if the rhythm is unnaturally smooth, you memorised words instead of facts.
5. Prepare five questions of your own about the role, not about the company's marketing.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"What does someone doing this job well look like six months in?"*

*"I handle pressure by over-communicating — during the March migration I sent the client a daily update, even on the bad days."*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Campus coaching often supplies model answers that entire batches then repeat word for word, and experienced interviewers recognise them instantly. Use the structure, supply your own facts. One specific true detail beats a perfect generic paragraph.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my five-year answer in one sentence, about capability rather than title.*

## DAY 87

DAY 87 OF 100

## Visa and Consular Interviews

*Focus:* Short, true, consistent answers with documents ready.

A visa interview is not a conversation — it is a short verification, often under two minutes, in a noisy room, through glass, with an officer who has done fifty already that morning. Brevity and consistency matter far more than eloquence, and over-explaining is the commonest self-inflicted problem.

### LEARN

- **Answer only what is asked, in one or two sentences.** Then stop. Volunteering extra information invites more questions.
- **Be consistent with your paperwork.** Every spoken answer must match your forms exactly — dates, employer, purpose, funding.
- **Know your core facts cold:** purpose of travel, duration, who is paying, where you will stay, what you do for work, when you will return.
- **Speak up and slow down.** Through glass, with background noise, clarity beats everything. Repeat the number if you are unsure it landed.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*A ninety-second answer to “why are you travelling?”*

*“A five-day conference in Berlin. My employer is paying.”*

*Actually, sir, my uncle also lives there, so maybe...*

Answer the question asked; do not volunteer more

*Vague dates or amounts*

*“The fourteenth to the nineteenth of March. About three thousand euros.”*

*Speaking quietly through the glass*

Speak up twenty per cent and slow down twenty per cent

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write one-sentence answers to the eight core questions: purpose, duration, dates, funding, accommodation, employer, salary, return plans.
2. Say each aloud ten times until it is automatic and short.
3. Have someone ask them rapidly, out of order, in a slightly unfriendly tone. Practise not expanding.
4. Practise the two safe repair lines: “Sorry, could you repeat the question?” and “I do not have that document with me, but I can send it.”
5. Read your own application form aloud and check every spoken answer against it.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“A five-day conference in Berlin, from the fourteenth to the nineteenth of March. My employer is covering it.”

“Sorry, could you repeat the question?”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The instinct to be polite and thorough — explaining background, offering extra context, mentioning relatives abroad — works against you here. Officers are checking consistency, not assessing your English. Short, true, consistent. Then stop talking.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my one-sentence answers to purpose, duration and funding.*

## DAY 88

DAY 88 OF 100

## Speaking Tests

*Focus:* Extend your answers and organise them out loud.

If you take an international English test, the speaking section rewards specific behaviours: extended answers, range of vocabulary and structure, coherence markers, and self-correction that does not derail you. These are trainable in ten days and are useful outside the test as well.

## LEARN

- **Never answer in one sentence.** Answer, then add a reason, then add an example. Three parts minimum, always.
- **Use discourse markers audibly:** “First of all ... On top of that ... Having said that ... In the long run ...” Examiners listen for these.
- **In the long-turn task, spend your preparation minute writing four bullet points,** not sentences. Then speak from the bullets.
- **Self-correct once and move on.** Repairing shows control; stopping and restarting costs you marks.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Do you like reading? — Yes.*

*Yes, mostly non-fiction. I read on my commute, which is about an hour a day. At the moment I am reading a book about logistics.*

*Silence during the preparation minute*

Four written bullets: what, when, who, why it mattered

*Restarting the sentence three times*

Say the corrected word and continue

*Memorised, unrelated material*

Answer the actual question with your real experience

## PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Take ten simple questions (*Do you like your city? Do you prefer tea or coffee? How do you travel to work?*) and answer each in three parts, aloud.
2. Practise the long turn: choose a topic card question, take exactly one minute to write four bullets, then speak for two minutes without stopping. Record it.
3. Learn eight discourse markers and use each five times: *first of all, on top of that, having said that, in the long run, as far as I am concerned, that said, more importantly, to be fair.*
4. Do three long turns in one session. The third is always better than the first, which is the point.
5. Time yourself: if you dry up before ninety seconds, add examples rather than new ideas.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“First of all, the commute is the main issue. On top of that, the office does not have space for everyone. Having said that, I would still prefer to go in twice a week.”*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Memorised answers are penalised in these tests, and examiners are trained to detect them — the giveaway is unnaturally fluent rhythm on one topic and hesitant speech everywhere else. Prepare structures and vocabulary, never scripts.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which discourse markers did I actually use today?*

## DAY 89

DAY 89 OF 100

## Introducing Yourself at Events

*Focus:* Thirty seconds that make someone want to ask a question.

Conferences, meetups and industry events are where careers turn, and they run on a single repeated exchange: “So what do you do?” A prepared, specific, thirty-second answer with a hook is worth more than a hundred business cards, because it starts an actual conversation.

### LEARN

- **Four beats:** who you help, what problem you solve, what you are doing about it, where it is now.
- **Lead with the problem, not your job title.** “I work with small shops that lose a day a week to stock counting” beats “I am a business analyst.”
- **End with a hook — an open thread, a surprising number, the unsolved part.** This is what produces a follow-up question.
- **Have two versions:** one for people in your field, one for everyone else.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I am working as a software engineer in an MNC.*

*I build the tool that stops small shops counting stock by hand — it saves them about a day a week.*

*Myself Rahul, I am into sales.*

*I'm Rahul. I sell to hospital procurement teams, which is as slow as it sounds.*

*A two-minute answer*

Thirty seconds, then a question back

*No question back*

*“What about you — what brought you here?”*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write the four beats for your current work, one sentence each.
2. Say it aloud and time it. Trim to thirty seconds, then write the non-specialist version.
3. Add a hook: an open question, a surprising number, or the part that is still unsolved.
4. Test both versions on two people and watch where their attention lifts.
5. Practise the question back, five times: “What about you?” is not optional.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*“I work with about nine hundred small shops that lose a full day a week counting stock. I am building the thing that does it from till data instead. Three shops start next month — the hard part is the ones with no reliable internet.”*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Job titles mean nothing to people outside your company, and company names mean nothing outside your industry. Lead with the human problem you work on — it is understandable to everyone and it makes you memorable.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my thirty-second version, with the hook at the end.*

## DAY 90

DAY 90 OF 100

## When You Go Blank

*Focus:* Have a recovery script for the moment your mind empties.

Under pressure, everyone occasionally loses the word, the thread or the whole sentence. The difference between a candidate who recovers and one who collapses is not language ability — it is whether they have a rehearsed recovery. Three sentences, learned cold, will carry you through any blank moment.

### LEARN

- **For a lost word:** *"I cannot think of the exact word — it is the thing that ..."* Then describe it and continue. This is a skill, not a failure.
- **For a lost thread:** *"Sorry, let me start that answer again more clearly."* Allowed once, and it reads as control.
- **For a question you cannot answer:** *"I do not know. Here is how I would find out."* This scores better than a confident wrong answer, in interviews and at work.
- **Breathe out before you speak.** A long exhale physically reduces the panic response and buys you two seconds.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*Long silence, then "sorry, sorry, my English..."*

*"Let me put that another way."*

*Guessing confidently at an answer you do not know*

*"I am not sure. I would check with the vendor and confirm today."*

*I forgot. Next question please.*

*"Can I come back to that at the end?"*

*Speeding up in panic*

Two long exhales, then continue at normal speed

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Learn three recovery sentences by heart. Say each ten times until they arrive without thought.
2. Practise the word-workaround deliberately: describe five objects without naming them. *"The thing you use to ..."*
3. Practise the honest non-answer five times: *"I do not know, and here is how I would find out."*
4. Have someone ask you five hard questions rapidly. When you blank, use a recovery line rather than stopping.
5. Practise the physical reset: two long exhales, feet on the floor, then speak. Rehearse it calm so it is available when you are not.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

| *"I cannot think of the exact word — it is the process where two systems check each other's data."*

| *"I do not know that. I would check with the vendor and come back to you today."*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Apologising for your English at the moment you blank does double damage: it draws attention to the gap and tells the interviewer to lower their expectations. Nobody who speaks three languages owes anybody an apology for the second one. Repair and continue.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my three recovery sentences from memory.*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Nine Review

You now have a prepared bank for every high-stakes English situation: a ninety-second self-introduction, six STAR stories, answers for strengths, weaknesses and salary, group discussion moves, HR answers, visa answers, speaking-test technique, a thirty-second event introduction, and a recovery script for going blank.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I can answer *tell me about yourself* in ninety seconds, starting with the present.
- ☐ I have six STAR stories written and timed under ninety seconds each.
- ☐ Every story's Result has a number in it.
- ☐ I have a real weakness answer with a system attached.
- ☐ I can say my salary number without my voice changing.
- ☐ I have four group-discussion entry lines memorised.
- ☐ I have researched one specific fact about a target company.
- ☐ I have one-sentence answers to the eight core visa questions.
- ☐ I can extend any simple answer into three parts.
- ☐ I have three recovery sentences memorised for going blank.

## RECORDING TEST

Do a full mock interview: ask a friend to run twenty minutes with *tell me about yourself*, three behavioural questions, strengths, weaknesses, salary, and two hard questions. Record all of it. Then check four things: did every behavioural answer reach a result with a number; did any answer run past ninety seconds; did you say *we* where you meant *I*; and did you apologise for your English even once.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Self-introduction

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

STAR stories

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

The predictable questions

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Group discussion presence

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Recovery under pressure

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If you freeze in mock interviews but speak fine otherwise, the problem is arousal, not English, and the treatment is exposure. Do five mock interviews in one week with anyone willing. The fifth will feel completely different from the first, and no amount of preparation on paper produces that change.

## PART TEN

---

# Fluency, Polish and the Next Hundred Days

DAYS 91-100

The last stage is about making everything permanent. Accuracy you have practised deliberately becomes fluency only through volume — hours of listening, hundreds of repetitions, and a habit that survives after the book closes. These ten days build the shadowing programme, the listening habit, a vocabulary system, register control, a way to manage the anxiety that shuts your mouth, and finally your capstone talk and your plan for the next hundred days.

### BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Run a daily shadowing and listening routine without needing a teacher.
- Upgrade your vocabulary through collocations rather than word lists.
- Switch between formal, neutral and casual English deliberately.
- Manage the anxiety that stops you speaking, using a rehearsed routine.
- Measure your progress against Day 1 and write a plan you will actually follow.

## DAY 91

DAY 91 OF 100

## The Thirty-Day Shadowing Programme

*Focus:* Set up the one habit that does the most work.

Shadowing trains rhythm, stress, linking, intonation and listening at the same time, which makes it the most efficient speaking exercise available. Ten minutes a day for a month produces a change other people notice. This day designs the programme so you do not have to decide anything daily.

### LEARN

- **One clip per week, not per day.** Twenty to forty seconds. Repeating one clip until it is easy is what produces the change; new clips daily produce nothing.
- **The weekly cycle:** days one and two, listen and mark the transcript. Days three and four, read aloud with the audio. Days five and six, speak along without the transcript. Day seven, record yourself and compare.
- **Choose speakers you would be content to sound like,** on topics you would listen to anyway. Interest is what makes you finish.
- **Mark the transcript every week:** stressed words underlined, pauses slashed, linked words joined with a curve. The marking is half the learning.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Choose four clips now — one for each of the next four weeks — each twenty to forty seconds with an accurate transcript.
2. Print or copy the first transcript. Mark stress, pauses and linking.
3. Do a full session today: listen twice, read along four times, speak along four times, record once.
4. Put the ten minutes in your calendar at a fixed time, every day, for thirty days.
5. Save your Day 91 recording of clip one. You will re-record the same clip on Day 98.

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Shadowing a speaker whose accent you dislike, or a clip that is too fast, both cause people to quit in the first week. Choose something slightly *easier* than you think you need. The clip should feel comfortable by day four.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which four clips did I choose, and when exactly will I do my ten minutes?*



## DAY 92

DAY 92 OF 100

## Listening for Meaning, Not Words

*Focus:* Train your ear on real, fast, connected speech.

Most Indian learners have far more reading than listening input, which is why fast native speech feels impossible while written English is easy. Listening is trainable and it improves speaking indirectly: you cannot produce a rhythm you have never properly heard. Twenty minutes a day changes this within weeks.

### LEARN

- **Two kinds of listening, both needed.** Intensive: short, difficult, repeated, with a transcript. Extensive: long, easy, enjoyable, no transcript, for volume.
- **Do not chase every word.** Native listeners miss words constantly and reconstruct from context. Aim for the meaning, not for full coverage.
- **Use the transcript *after*, never during, the first listen.** Reading while listening teaches you to read, not to hear.
- **Vary the accents deliberately:** British, American, Australian, and Indian English speaking to international audiences. Your ear should not depend on one.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Intensive, ten minutes: take a thirty-second clip. Listen five times without the transcript, writing down what you catch. Then check the transcript and see exactly what you missed.
2. Note the *type* of thing you missed: weak forms, linked words, an unknown word, or speed. That tells you what to work on.
3. Extensive, ten minutes: listen to something enjoyable with no transcript and no pausing. Podcasts, interviews, commentary.
4. Do a dictation once a week: play fifteen seconds and write it out exactly, then check word by word.
5. Schedule both types daily. Extensive listening can be done while commuting or cooking; intensive needs your full attention.

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Watching subtitled content in English feels like listening practice and is mostly reading practice — your eyes take over within seconds. Use subtitles on the second viewing, never the first.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What type of thing did I miss most: weak forms, linking, vocabulary, or speed?*

DAY 93

DAY 93 OF 100

## Read Aloud Every Day

*Focus:* Five minutes of reading aloud, with a rotating focus.

Reading aloud is the most efficient solo drill in this book: it trains breath, articulation, pace, stress and intonation at once, with the content already supplied. It has no social cost, requires no partner, and five minutes a day for a month produces an audible difference.

### LEARN

- **Choose good prose.** Well-written journalism, essays or non-fiction. Badly written text trains bad rhythm.
- **Rotate the focus daily:** breath at punctuation, final consonants, one stressed word per sentence, weak forms, linking, pace variation.
- **Read as if explaining to one person across a table.** Not a performance; a clear explanation.
- **Record weekly, not daily.** Daily recording is discouraging; weekly shows real change.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Choose a 300-word text you find genuinely interesting.
2. Mark it up: breath marks at full stops, one underlined operative word per sentence, curves for the linked phrases.
3. Read it aloud following your marks. Record it.
4. Read it again thirty per cent slower and notice how much more control you have.
5. Schedule five minutes daily, with tomorrow's focus written next to it.

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Reading aloud in a dramatic “newsreader” voice trains a voice you will never use in a meeting. Keep it conversational. The goal is a better everyday instrument, not a broadcasting career.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What was today's focus, and what did I notice?*

## DAY 94

DAY 94 OF 100

## Vocabulary That Comes Out of Your Mouth

*Focus:* Learn words in their partnerships, and use each one five times.

You almost certainly know thousands of English words you never actually say. The gap is between recognition and production, and word lists do not close it because they teach words in isolation — so you produce combinations nobody says. Collocations and immediate use are what move a word into your speech.

### LEARN

- **Learn the partners, not the word.** Not *decision* alone but *make a decision, take a decision, reach a decision, reverse a decision*. Not *heavy* alone but *heavy rain, heavy traffic, heavy workload*.
- **Five uses in five days moves a word into production.** Say it aloud in your own sentence, five separate times, spread across days.
- **Upgrade precision, not obscurity.** Replace *do, get, make, thing, nice, very* with precise verbs. A common word used precisely beats a rare word used awkwardly.
- **Ten words a week is plenty.** Five hundred a year, actually usable, is a transformation.

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

*I did a mistake.*

*I **made** a mistake.*

*Heavy rain is falling. / strong rain*

*It is **raining heavily**. / heavy rain*

*I want to increase my English.*

*I want to **improve** my English.*

*Give me more informations about the thing.*

*Could you tell me more about the process?*

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Choose ten words or phrases you understand but never say. Look up the collocations of each — which verbs and adjectives it travels with.
2. Write one true sentence about your own life for each.
3. Say each sentence aloud five times, then use at least three of the ten in real conversation today.
4. Kill your five overused words. Find three precise alternatives for each of *do, get, thing, nice, very*.
5. Start a weekly page: ten items, their partners, one true sentence each. Review last week's ten every Monday.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“We **made** a decision on Friday, and I **raised** a concern about the timeline.”

“Traffic was **heavy**, so I **missed** the deadline by an hour.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Memorising long word lists for exams produces recognition vocabulary that never appears in speech, which is why many Indian learners have a large passive vocabulary and a small active one. Ten used words beat a hundred recognised ones.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which three new words did I actually say out loud today?*

## DAY 95

DAY 95 OF 100

## Formal, Neutral and Casual

*Focus:* Choose your register deliberately.

One English is not enough. The way you speak to a government officer, a foreign client and a colleague at lunch should differ, and using the wrong register is noticed more than a grammar error. Indian English tends to be more formal in writing and more direct in speech than international norms, so both directions need adjusting.

## LEARN

- **Formal:** full forms, no slang, hedged requests, complete sentences. For officials, legal matters, first contact with senior strangers.
- **Neutral, which is your default at work:** contractions, plain words, softened requests, friendly but not chatty. Most professional English lives here.
- **Casual:** reductions, idioms, incomplete sentences, humour. With colleagues you know and friends.
- **Match the other person, then adjust one notch.** If they are casual and you stay formal, you seem distant; the reverse seems careless.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Kindly revert at the earliest. (to a colleague)*

*Let me know when you can — no rush.*

*Hey, what's up? (to a client you have never met)*

*Good morning, Ms Rao — thanks for making the time.*

*I would be grateful if you could... (to a teammate)*

*Could you take a look at this?*

*Yeah, whatever works. (in a formal negotiation)*

*Either option works for us.*

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take one request and write it three ways: formal, neutral, casual. Say all three aloud and hear the difference.
2. Do the same for a refusal, an apology and a greeting. Twelve sentences in total.
3. Sort your last ten messages by register. Was each one appropriate to its reader?
4. Practise the register switch: say the same sentence to an official, a client and a friend, back to back.
5. Identify which register is your weakest and use it deliberately twice today.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*Formal: "I would be grateful if you could confirm by Thursday."*

*Neutral: "Could you confirm by Thursday?" Casual: "Can you let me know by Thursday?"*

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Most Indian learners are strongest in formal English, because that is what school and examinations rewarded, and weakest in casual English — which is where colleagues actually become friends and where teams form. Practise the casual register on purpose; it is the one that builds relationships.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which register is my weakest? Where will I practise it?*

## DAY 96

DAY 96 OF 100

## Idioms and Phrasal Verbs, Carefully

*Focus:* Learn the fifty that are actually used, and use them lightly.

Phrasal verbs are unavoidable in real English — *follow up, sort out, bring forward, catch up, run into* — and they are where a formally-educated learner sounds bookish, because school taught the Latin verb instead. Idioms are a smaller win and a bigger risk: a few common ones help, and an unusual one used wrongly is worse than plain speech.

## LEARN

- **Phrasal verbs are the high-value half.** *follow up, sort out, figure out, find out, come up with, deal with, put off, bring forward, catch up, run into, look into, get back to, carry on, hold on.*
- **Use plain phrasal verbs in speech, formal verbs in writing.** “*I will look into it*” in a meeting; “*I will investigate*” in a report.
- **Stick to genuinely common idioms:** *on the same page, in the loop, a long shot, off the top of my head, touch base, the bottom line.* Six is enough.
- **Avoid translated idioms.** An idiom translated from your first language will not exist in English and will simply confuse people.

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*I will investigate the matter. (in a standup)*

*I will look into it.*

*Please intimate me.*

*Please let me know. I Keep me in the loop.*

*We shall postpone the meeting. (casual)*

*Let's push the meeting. I Let's put it off.*

*Using a rare idiom you read once*

Plain English: it is always safe

## PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Learn fifteen phrasal verbs from the list. Write one true sentence for each, about your own work.
2. Say each sentence aloud three times.
3. Practise the pairs: *look into / investigate, find out / ascertain, put off / postpone, bring forward / prepone.* Say the plain one in speech.
4. Learn six common idioms and use two today in real conversation.
5. Note any idiom you have been using that you learned from a book but have never heard anyone say. Retire it.

## MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“*I will look into it and get back to you by Thursday.*”

“*Let me check with the team so we are all on the same page.*”

## MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Learners often collect elaborate idioms to sound advanced, and the effect is the opposite: unusual idioms used slightly wrongly are the clearest possible signal of a non-native speaker trying hard. Fluent-sounding English is mostly plain English delivered with good rhythm.

## JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Which five phrasal verbs will I use this week?*

## DAY 97

DAY 97 OF 100

## The Fear That Stops Your Mouth

*Focus:* Manage the anxiety, rather than waiting for it to go.

For most Indian learners the real barrier is not vocabulary or grammar — it is the fear of being judged, usually installed by years of being corrected harshly at school or laughed at for an accent. That fear produces silence, and silence prevents the only thing that would fix it. This day addresses it directly.

### LEARN

- **The fear is learned, and it is specific.** Most people can name the exact situation or person that installed it. Naming it reduces its size.
- **Nobody is grading you.** Listeners are working out your meaning, not scoring your grammar. This is true even in interviews, where they are assessing whether you can do the job.
- **Physical routine first:** two long exhales, feet on the floor, shoulders down, then speak. Arousal drops within seconds and this works every time.
- **Exposure in small doses, daily.** One thirty-second exchange with a stranger, every day. Volume of low-stakes practice dissolves the fear; waiting to feel ready does not.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write down the specific memory or situation that made you afraid to speak English. One paragraph. Nobody will read it.
2. Write down what you actually fear will happen. Then write what has actually happened the last five times you spoke English imperfectly.
3. Practise the physical reset ten times: two long exhales, feet grounded, then speak a sentence.
4. Do three deliberate low-stakes exposures today: three strangers, thirty seconds each, in English.
5. Write the sentence you will use instead of apologising: *“Let me put that another way.”*

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Let me put that another way.”

“Give me one second — I want to say this properly.”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Two beliefs do the most damage: that you must be perfect before you speak, and that your accent makes you less intelligent. Both are false, and both are extremely common among Indian learners. If anxiety about speaking is affecting your work or health seriously, this is worth taking to a professional — it responds well to treatment.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What do I actually fear? What has actually happened the last five times?*

## DAY 98

DAY 98 OF 100

## Measure Yourself Honestly

*Focus:* Compare Day 1 with today, and build an error log.

Memory is a terrible judge of your own progress: you adapt to your current level and it feels like it was always this way. Recordings do not adapt. Today you measure against Day 1 with evidence, and set up the error log that will keep improving you after this book ends.

### LEARN

- **Compare, do not remember.** Play Day 1 and today back to back. The difference will be larger than you expect and different from what you expected.
- **Count, do not judge.** Words per minute, fillers per minute, dropped endings, missing articles. Numbers, not feelings.
- **The error log is the engine.** One page: the mistake, the correction, and a tally each time you catch it. Habits die when they are counted.
- **Re-record the same clip and the same question every month.** Same material is the only fair comparison.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Re-record the Day 1 question, one take, sixty seconds: *"Tell me about yourself and what you do."*
2. Play Day 1 and today back to back. Write down three specific audible differences.
3. Count four things in each recording: words per minute, fillers, dropped endings, missing articles. Write both sets of numbers side by side.
4. Re-record your Day 91 shadowing clip and compare it with your first attempt.
5. Build the error log: one page, your five current errors, correction, and a tally column. Start counting today.

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Do not judge the recording as good or bad — that produces either complacency or discouragement, and neither helps. Count the four numbers. Numbers tell you what to practise; feelings tell you nothing.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write the four numbers from Day 1 and the four from today.*

## DAY 99

DAY 99 OF 100

## Your Capstone: Speak for Five Minutes

*Focus:* Give a real five-minute talk to real people, recorded.

Ninety-eight days of practice deserves a test that matters. A live talk to actual humans is where you discover that the individual skills have fused into one competence rather than remaining a list of things you know.

### LEARN

- **Real audience, however small.** Two colleagues, a family gathering, a team meeting, a video call, a community group. Two people is enough; zero is not.
- **Five minutes with questions.** Long enough to need structure, short enough to prepare properly.
- **Apply the whole book:** one message, three points, designed opening and close, warm-up before, deliberate pace, falling endings, no apology.
- **Record it.** This is the recording you will compare with Day 1, and it is the reason you made the first one.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 40 MINUTES

1. Choose a topic you genuinely know: something from your work, your city, your field, a skill you have.
2. Write the one-sentence message and three points, each with one example. One page only.
3. Write and learn the first thirty seconds and the last thirty seconds.
4. Rehearse aloud, standing, three times. Time each run. Warm up your voice before the third.
5. Deliver it live and record it. Take questions. Then ask two people: what is the one thing you remember, and what one thing would you change?

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

“Three things, five minutes, and then I would like your questions.”

“Let me finish with the one thing worth remembering: ...”

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

Do not postpone this until conditions are ideal or your English feels ready. A five-minute talk to three colleagues this week is worth infinitely more than a perfect talk you never give. Book it before you close the book today.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*What did people say they remembered? Was it the message I intended?*



## DAY 100

DAY 100 OF 100

## Your Next Hundred Days

*Focus:* Write the plan that keeps this from fading.

Spoken English decays quietly. Nobody notices their own fillers returning or their endings softening. The people who keep improving after a course like this are simply the ones who scheduled something. Today you keep three habits, choose two new targets, and put a date in your calendar.

### LEARN

- **Keep three habits, not thirty:** ten minutes of shadowing, five minutes of reading aloud, and one real English conversation every day. Those three carry everything else.
- **Choose two targets for the next hundred days,** chosen by cost to you — not by interest. One pronunciation target, one situation target is a good split.
- **Attach it to an obligation, not an intention.** A monthly talk, a weekly recap you own, a language partner with a fixed slot. Habits survive when someone else is expecting them.
- **Re-measure in ninety days.** Same question, same clip, same four numbers.

### PRACTICE TODAY — 35 MINUTES

1. Read your journal from Day 1 to today. Mark the three entries where something visibly shifted.
2. Redo the twelve-statement self-check from the front of the book. Compare with your original ticks.
3. Write your one-page plan: three daily habits with times, two targets with a weekly drill each, one repeating real-world commitment, and the date you will re-measure.
4. Put all of it in your calendar now, not later. Ninety days from today is the usual re-measure date.
5. Tell one person what you are working on next. Stated commitments survive far better than private ones.

### MODEL SENTENCES — SAY EACH ONE FIVE TIMES

*"I am keeping three things: ten minutes of shadowing, five minutes of reading aloud, and one real conversation in English every day."*

### MOTHER TONGUE TRAP

The most common outcome after finishing a course like this is a quiet slide back over six months, purely because nothing was scheduled. Ten minutes daily beats two hours on Sunday, and a calendar entry beats a good intention every single time.

### JOURNAL, IN ENGLISH

*Write my three habits, my two targets, and my re-measure date.*

## CHECKPOINT

## Stage Ten Review

You have a shadowing programme, a listening routine, a daily reading habit, a vocabulary system based on collocations, register control, the phrasal verbs that matter, a way to handle the fear, an evidence-based measurement of your own progress, a delivered talk, and a written plan for the next hundred days.

## SAY IT OUT LOUD — TICK ONLY WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO

- ☐ I have four shadowing clips chosen and a fixed daily slot.
- ☐ I do both intensive and extensive listening.
- ☐ I read aloud for five minutes daily with a rotating focus.
- ☐ I learn words with their collocations and use each five times.
- ☐ I can say the same request in formal, neutral and casual English.
- ☐ I use plain phrasal verbs in speech instead of formal verbs.
- ☐ I have a physical reset routine for when anxiety rises.
- ☐ I have compared my Day 1 and Day 100 recordings and written the numbers.
- ☐ I have delivered a five-minute talk to real people.
- ☐ My next hundred days are written down and in my calendar.

## RECORDING TEST

The final measurement. Put four things in one place: your Day 100 recording, your four counted numbers beside your Day 1 numbers, your redone twelve-statement self-check, and your one-page plan with a calendar date on it. Then say your plan out loud to one other person. That last step is not decoration — it is the single biggest predictor of whether any of this survives the next six months.

## SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Shadowing and listening habit

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Vocabulary in use

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Register control

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

Confidence and recovery

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

A plan I will actually follow

|   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|

## IF IT IS NOT WORKING YET

If you did not manage the capstone talk, the course is not unfinished — it is unscheduled. Book five minutes in a team meeting within the next two weeks. And if your progress feels smaller than you hoped, go and listen to your Day 1 recording again. It will not agree with you.

## APPENDIX A

## The Sound Drill Bank

Minimal pairs and tongue twisters for every sound in Stages Two and Three. Say each pair ten times, alternating, in front of a mirror. Five minutes a day on your two worst sounds beats an hour on all of them.

## Minimal pairs by sound

|                           |                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>v / w</b>              | vest / west · vine / wine · veal / wheel · vary / wary · verse / worse · vet / wet · van / wan · viper / wiper |
| <b>th / t</b>             | thin / tin · three / tree · thick / tick · thought / taught · path / part · both / boat                        |
| <b>th / d</b>             | they / day · then / den · those / doze · breathe / breed · other / udder                                       |
| <b>p / f</b>              | pan / fan · pine / fine · copy / coffee · pour / four · pace / face · pull / full                              |
| <b>b / v</b>              | best / vest · ban / van · berry / very · boat / vote · bat / vat · curb / curve                                |
| <b>s / sh</b>             | sip / ship · said / shed · sort / short · seat / sheet · sock / shock · sell / shell                           |
| <b>ch / sh</b>            | chair / share · cheap / sheep · watch / wash · chin / shin · chop / shop                                       |
| <b>s / z</b>              | price / prize · ice / eyes · bus / buzz · place / plays · race / raise · loss / laws                           |
| <b>p / b (aspiration)</b> | pot / bot · pin / bin · pear / bear · pack / back · punch / bunch                                              |
| <b>t / d</b>              | tie / die · town / down · tore / door · tent / dent · write / ride                                             |
| <b>k / g</b>              | coat / goat · cold / gold · came / game · back / bag · lock / log                                              |
| <b>/ light / dark</b>     | light · love · believe // full · well · people · milk · help · school                                          |

## Vowel pairs

|                      |                                                                                                  |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>ship / sheep</b>  | sit / seat · fill / feel · live / leave · bin / bean · hit / heat · this / these · still / steal |
| <b>full / fool</b>   | pull / pool · look / Luke · could / cooed · foot / food · should / shooed                        |
| <b>bad / bed</b>     | man / men · sat / set · bat / bet · and / end · hand / hen · tax / text · bank / bench           |
| <b>cot / caught</b>  | not / naught · cost / caught · shot / short · want / wall · stock / stalk                        |
| <b>caught / coat</b> | law / low · saw / so · born / bone · fall / foal · caught / coat                                 |
| <b>cut / cart</b>    | but / part · hut / heart · much / march · bun / barn · cup / carp                                |
| <b>Vowel length</b>  | bat / bad · seat / seed · cap / cab · back / bag · life / live · rice / rise                     |
| <b>Numbers</b>       | thirteen / thirty · fourteen / forty · fifteen / fifty · sixteen / sixty · eighteen / eighty     |

## Tongue twisters, by target

|                             |                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>v and w</b>              | "We were very worried about the vivid winter weather in the village."                   |
| <b>th</b>                   | "The thirty-three thieves thought that they thrilled the throne throughout Thursday."   |
| <b>t and d on the ridge</b> | "The letter about the better water bottle got to the city on time."                     |
| <b>s and sh</b>             | "She sells sea shells on the sea shore, and the shells she sells are surely seashells." |
| <b>Clusters</b>             | "The sixth sick sheikh's sixth sheep's sick." "Strange strategic statistics."           |
| <b>p and f</b>              | "Peter prefers the perfect coffee from the phone-order place."                          |
| <b>r (no roll)</b>          | "Really rural red lorries carry rare berries."                                          |
| <b>Word endings</b>         | "He asked, worked, walked, talked, stopped and finished."                               |
| <b>Articulation warm-up</b> | "Red leather, yellow leather." "Unique New York."                                       |

## The daily five-minute warm-up

- Breath (1 min):** ten low breaths, four counts in, six counts out.
- Face (1 min):** drop the jaw and wobble it, roll the neck, blow through loose lips, stretch the tongue out and around.
- Voice (1 min):** hum up and down your range on *mmm*; slide *woo* from low to high five times.
- Mouth (1 min):** two tongue twisters from the table above, hugely over-articulated, three times each.
- Sentence (1 min):** read one sentence aloud three times, marking the stress with a tap on the table.

## APPENDIX B

## Mother Tongue Trap Tables

Find your first language, work on its rows first. These are *commonly reported tendencies*, not rules about you personally — individuals vary enormously, and education, region and exposure matter as much as language. Record yourself first and confirm which rows actually apply. Everything here affects intelligibility only; none of it is about removing your accent.

**Shared by almost all Indian language backgrounds.** Work on these regardless of your first language, because they come from structural features common across the family: no articles (*a, an, the*); retroflex *t* and *d* instead of alveolar; syllable-timed rhythm instead of stress-timed; an extra vowel inserted into consonant clusters; full value given to unstressed vowels instead of the weak *uh*; and the *-s* and *-ed* endings left off in fast speech.

## Hindi, Urdu, Haryanvi, Rajasthani speakers

|                               |                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>v and w merge</b>          | One sound serves both. Drill Day 11 with a mirror: teeth on lip for <i>v</i> , rounded lips for <i>w</i> . |
| <b>Articles dropped</b>       | "going to office" -> "going to <b>the</b> office." Day 41.                                                 |
| <b>Cluster vowels</b>         | <i>is-kool, fil-um</i> . Day 18: start the word on the consonant.                                          |
| <b>Aspiration misplaced</b>   | Your script has aspirated letters, but English uses them by different rules. Day 17, paper test.           |
| <b>th becomes aspirated t</b> | Tongue <i>between</i> the teeth, not behind them. Day 12.                                                  |
| <b>Continuous overused</b>    | "I am having two brothers" -> "I <b>have</b> ." Day 42.                                                    |

## Bengali and Assamese speakers

|                              |                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>v becomes b</b>           | <i>bery</i> for <i>very</i> , <i>adbice</i> for <i>advice</i> . Day 14: teeth on lip, buzz through. |
| <b>s moves toward sh</b>     | <i>shix</i> for <i>six</i> . Day 15: narrow the channel, pull the tongue forward for s.             |
| <b>z becomes j</b>           | <i>jero</i> for <i>zero</i> . Day 16: keep the air flowing continuously, do not stop it.            |
| <b>a vowel rounding</b>      | The <i>cat</i> vowel drifts toward o. Day 23: drop the jaw and spread the lips.                     |
| <b>Assamese s toward h/x</b> | Practise the clean s in isolation before words. Appendix A pairs.                                   |
| <b>Cluster vowels</b>        | Day 18. Slow motion, never faster.                                                                  |

## Tamil speakers

|                                     |                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Stress on the first syllable</b> | Tamil stress is regular; English is not. Day 4 is your priority — look up and drill every long word. |
| <b>Aspiration absent</b>            | <i>pot</i> can sound like <i>bot</i> . Day 17, paper test, ten minutes daily.                        |
| <b>Vowel added before clusters</b>  | <i>ish-tudy</i> , <i>is-cool</i> . Day 18.                                                           |
| <b>plb, tld, klg voicing</b>        | Tamil does not use these as separate letters. Drill the pairs in Appendix A daily.                   |
| <b>th becomes dental t</b>          | Very close, so rarely corrected. Push the tongue tip <i>past</i> the teeth. Day 12.                  |
| <b>sh and s merge</b>               | Day 15.                                                                                              |

## Telugu, Kannada, Odia speakers

|                                            |                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Extra vowel at word end</b>             | <i>cricket-uh</i> , <i>thanks-uh</i> . Stop cleanly on the final consonant. Days 3 and 6.   |
| <b>Final syllable lengthened</b>           | Flattens the word's stress shape. Day 4: shorten the end, strengthen the stressed syllable. |
| <b>Retroflex t and d</b>                   | Day 13 — the highest-value change for international calls.                                  |
| <b>v and w</b>                             | Day 11, with a mirror.                                                                      |
| <b>Aspiration by local rules</b>           | Day 17.                                                                                     |
| <b>Vowel length replaces vowel quality</b> | <i>ship/sheep</i> and <i>full/fool</i> need mouth shape, not duration. Days 21 and 22.      |

## Malayalam speakers

**Extra vowel inserted and appended** Days 3, 6 and 18. Stop cleanly; do not add a vowel.

**Aspiration and voicing pairs** Days 14 and 17 — the paper test.

**zh and / colouring** Practise the light / before vowels and the dark / at word ends. Day 19.

**Fast speech rate** Malayalam is typically spoken quickly and the habit transfers. Day 7 — slow twenty per cent and open the mouth more.

**th becomes dental t** Day 12.

## Marathi and Gujarati speakers

**v and w merge** Day 11.

**Cluster vowels** *fil-um, is-treet*. Day 18.

**Aspiration misplaced** Day 17.

**Gujarati s/sh variation** Day 15.

**Articles dropped** Day 41.

**a vowel** The *cat* vowel drifts. Day 23: more jaw.

## Punjabi speakers

**Pitch patterns from tone** Punjabi uses pitch lexically, so English intonation can carry unintended meaning. Days 36 to 38 are your priority.

**Aspiration and voicing** Day 17, paper test.

**v/w and flp** Days 11 and 14.

**Cluster vowels** Day 18.

**Articles dropped** Day 41.

## If your language is not listed

Work the shared list at the top of this appendix, then record two minutes of your own speech and compare it against the checklists in the Stage Two and Stage Three reviews. Your own recording is a better guide than any table, because it describes you rather than a tendency. Record, listen, choose the two sounds that a stranger would find hardest, and drill only those for a month.

## APPENDIX C

## Indianisms and International English

None of these are wrong in India, and most were standard British business English at some point. They are simply not used internationally, so they mark your English as local. Keep both sets and switch by audience — that is bilingual skill, not self-correction.

## Office and email

## INSTEAD OF

## SAY THIS

*Please do the needful*

Could you approve it and send it back?

*Kindly revert / revert back*

Please reply / get back to me

*Prepone the meeting*

Move the meeting earlier / bring it forward

*He is out of station*

He is out of town / away this week

*Kindly find the same attached*

I have attached the file

*Please intimate me*

Please let me know

*Awaiting your revert*

I look forward to your reply

*Thanking you in anticipation*

Thanks in advance

*Respected Sir / Madam*

Dear Mr Sharma / Hi Anil

*We discussed about it*

We discussed it

*I will order for it*

I will order it

*Cope up with the workload*

Cope with the workload

*Today itself / yesterday only*

Today / just yesterday

*Do one thing, you send it*

Could you send it?

*I have a doubt*

I have a question



## Conversation and introductions

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

|                                       |                                                |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Myself Rajesh</i>                  | I'm Rajesh                                     |
| <i>What is your good name?</i>        | Sorry, what was your name?                     |
| <i>Where do you stay?</i>             | Where do you live?                             |
| <i>What is your native place?</i>     | Where are you from originally?                 |
| <i>He is my cousin brother</i>        | He is my cousin                                |
| <i>She is my real sister</i>          | She is my sister                               |
| <i>My co-brother</i>                  | My wife's sister's husband / my brother-in-law |
| <i>He is elder to me</i>              | He is older than me                            |
| <i>I passed out in 2019</i>           | I graduated in 2019                            |
| <i>Same to same</i>                   | Exactly the same                               |
| <i>Like that only</i>                 | Something like that                            |
| <i>It is like this only</i>           | That is just how it is                         |
| <i>Tell me. (answering the phone)</i> | How can I help?                                |
| <i>No issues / no problem only</i>    | No problem                                     |
| <i>I am not getting your point</i>    | Sorry, I do not follow                         |

## Grammar habits

### INSTEAD OF

### SAY THIS

|                                      |                                      |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <i>I am having two brothers</i>      | I have two brothers                  |
| <i>I am knowing him for years</i>    | I have known him for years           |
| <i>I am working here since 2020</i>  | I have been working here since 2020  |
| <i>What did he said?</i>             | What did he say?                     |
| <i>Where you are going?</i>          | Where are you going?                 |
| <i>You are coming, isn't it?</i>     | You are coming, aren't you? / right? |
| <i>Give me some informations</i>     | Give me some information             |
| <i>He gave many advices</i>          | He gave a lot of advice              |
| <i>Our staffs are trained</i>        | Our staff are trained                |
| <i>New furnitures and equipments</i> | New furniture and equipment          |
| <i>She told that she will come</i>   | She said she would come              |
| <i>He don't have it</i>              | He doesn't have it                   |
| <i>Yesterday I go to the office</i>  | Yesterday I went to the office       |
| <i>Myself and my friend went</i>     | My friend and I went                 |
| <i>Return back / repeat again</i>    | Return / repeat                      |

## Words that mean something else internationally

|                                 |                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>doubt</b>                    | In India: a question. Internationally: suspicion or disbelief. Say <b>question</b> .                  |
| <b>pass out</b>                 | In India: graduate. Internationally: faint. Say <b>graduate</b> .                                     |
| <b>revert</b>                   | In India: reply. Internationally: go back to a previous state. Say <b>reply</b> .                     |
| <b>prepone</b>                  | Not an English word outside India. Say <b>bring forward</b> or <b>move earlier</b> .                  |
| <b>intimate (verb)</b>          | Internationally reads as odd or over-formal. Say <b>inform</b> or <b>let me know</b> .                |
| <b>out of station</b>           | Not used internationally. Say <b>out of town</b> .                                                    |
| <b>lakh, crore</b>              | Correct in India, unknown elsewhere. Convert: one lakh = a hundred thousand; one crore = ten million. |
| <b>cent per cent</b>            | Say <b>a hundred per cent</b> .                                                                       |
| <b>mugging up</b>               | Say <b>memorising</b> or <b>cramming</b> .                                                            |
| <b>hotel (for a restaurant)</b> | Internationally a hotel has beds. Say <b>restaurant</b> .                                             |

## A note on which of these to keep

If you work only with Indian colleagues and clients, most of this list is irrelevant — *do the needful* is perfectly effective in an Indian office and everyone understands it. Change your vocabulary when your audience changes. The items genuinely worth fixing in all contexts are the grammar habits in the third table, because those are marked as errors in international writing, interviews and language tests, not merely as local usage.

## APPENDIX D

# The Chunk Bank

---

Around two hundred ready-made word groups, arranged by what you need to do. Learn ten a week, say each five times in your own sentence, and use three in real conversation the same day. This is the fastest route to fluency in the whole book.

## Buying time and thinking aloud

- That is a good question. · Let me think for a second. · The short answer is ... · It depends, really. · I would say ... · Off the top of my head ... · Let me get back to you on that. · How can I put this ... · I am not sure, but my guess is ... · Give me a moment to put that in order.

## Opinions

- I think ... · In my opinion ... · My view is that ... · The way I see it ... · I tend to think ... · It seems to me that ... · I could be wrong, but ... · My instinct is that ... · If you ask me ... · As far as I am concerned ... · I am fairly confident that ... · I have no strong view on that.

## Agreeing, partly agreeing, disagreeing

- Exactly. · That is a fair point. · That makes sense. · You are right about ... · I agree up to a point, but ... · That is true, although ... · I see what you mean, but ... · There is something in that, though ... · I am not sure I agree. · I see it slightly differently. · My concern with that is ... · I would question whether ... · Can I offer a different view?

## Explaining and clarifying

- What I mean is ... · Let me put it another way. · In other words ... · To put it simply ... · For example ... · The point I am making is ... · Just to be clear ... · Sorry, do you mean ...? · Could you say that again more slowly? · I did not catch the last part. · Am I making sense so far?

## Cause, effect and sequence

- because · since · due to · so · therefore · as a result · which means · that is why · first · then · after that · once that is done · finally · in the end · it turned out that · the reason is · what caused it was

## Softening and hedging

- a bit · quite · slightly · it seems · I am afraid · unfortunately · it looks like · to be honest · I think there might be · would it be possible to ... · I was wondering if ... · do you think you could ... · if it is not too much trouble · I may be wrong here

## Requests, offers and refusals

- Could you ...? · Would you be able to ...? · Do you think you could ...? · Would you mind ...? · Shall I ...? · Do you want me to ...? · Let me know if you need ... · I am happy to ... · I cannot take that on this week. · I can do X if Y moves. · That would be difficult, I am afraid. · Can I come back to you on that?

## Meetings and work

- Can I add something here? · Sorry, can I jump in? · Before we move on ... · Adding to what X said ... · Can I check one thing? · So where we are is ... · Let me summarise. · Who owns that, and by when? · What does done look like here? · What are we assuming? · Shall we take this offline? · I will follow up on that. · Just to confirm ...

## Small talk and social

- How is it going? · How have you been? · Good to see you again. · What brought you here? · How did you get into that? · What is the hardest part? · Anything planned for the weekend? · How was your weekend — anything good? · Whereabouts in Pune? · It was good talking to you. · I should let you go. · Can I message you about that?

## Describing and comparing

- much better · slightly cheaper · far more expensive · significantly higher · a bit slower · roughly the same as · similar to · different from · compared to · whereas · on the one hand ... on the other hand · the main difference is · about a third · just over half · nearly double

## Numbers and trends

- rose sharply · increased slightly · fell steadily · dropped by about a third · stayed roughly flat · more than doubled · around · roughly · just over · just under · in the region of · give or take · that is one-five, not five-zero

## Phrasal verbs worth knowing

- follow up · sort out · figure out · find out · come up with · deal with · put off · bring forward · catch up · run into · look into · get back to · carry on · hold on · take over · hand over · turn down · point out · sign off · roll out · back up · sum up

## Recovery and repair

- Let me put that another way. · What I mean is ... · Sorry, let me start that again more clearly. · I cannot think of the exact word — it is the thing that ... · I do not know. I will find out and confirm today. · Can I come back to that at the end? · Bear with me for a second.

## APPENDIX E

# Situation Scripts

Complete skeletons for the conversations that recur. Learn the shape, not the words — then the words come out in your own voice. Say each one aloud five times before you need it.

## Making a phone call

## THE FIVE STAGES OF A CALL

- | *"Hi, this is Rajesh from Acme Logistics. Am I speaking to Ms Rao?"*
- | *"I am calling about invoice four-five-two-one. Is now a good time, or shall I call back?"*
- | *"Sorry, the line is breaking up — could you repeat that?"*
- | *"Let me confirm: Thursday the fifteenth, at two thirty. Is that right?"*
- | *"So I will send the revised invoice today and you will confirm by Friday. Thanks for your time."*

## Receiving a call

## SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Good morning, support team, Priya speaking. How can I help?"*
- | *"Let me take a note of that. Could I have your account number?"*
- | *"Could you hold for a moment? I will be right back."*
- | *"I am sorry about that — let me find out what happened and call you back within the hour."*

## Starting a client meeting

## SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Thanks for making the time. Three things today, about twenty minutes: where we are, two options, and one decision I need from you."*
- | *"That is the problem. Now the options."*
- | *"Let me pause there — does that match what you are seeing at your end?"*
- | *"So: you confirm by Friday, I send the revised plan on Monday. Anything I have missed?"*

## The job interview: first ninety seconds

### NOW, THEN, WHY HERE

| “I’m Priya. I currently handle enterprise support for a payments company — about two hundred tickets a week across four analysts.”

| “I moved into support from testing three years ago, because I wanted to be closer to the customer.”

| “This role is the same problem at a much larger scale, which is why I applied.”

## The job interview: hard moments

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “That is a good question. Give me a second.”

| “I do not know that. I would check with the vendor and come back to you today.”

| “I cannot think of the exact word — it is the process where two systems check each other’s data.”

| “Based on the market and my experience, I am looking at eighteen to twenty-two lakh.”

| “Thank you — could I have until Thursday to confirm?”

## In a shop or restaurant

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Could I have a coffee and one plain dosa, please?”

| “Do you have this in a larger size?”

| “What would you recommend?” “Is it very spicy?”

| “Could we get the bill when you have a moment?”

| “Sorry, I think there is a mistake in the bill — could you check this item?”

## Travel

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Sorry, does this train stop at Dadar?”

| “Which platform does the Chennai train leave from?”

| “How long does it take from here, roughly?”

| “I think I am on the wrong bus. Which stop should I get off at for the airport?”

## At a counter: bank, office, hospital

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I am here to update the address on my account. I have brought the ID proof and a rent agreement."*
- | *"What documents do I need, and how long does it usually take?"*
- | *"Who should I follow up with if I do not hear back?"*
- | *"Could you email me a confirmation, or is there a reference number?"*

## Describing a medical problem

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I have a pain in my lower back. It started about three days ago."*
- | *"It hurts most in the morning, and it comes and goes during the day."*
- | *"I have had a fever since Monday, and a dry cough."*
- | *"I am not taking any other medicine. I am allergic to penicillin."*

## Complaining effectively

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I want to explain the problem, and then I would like to agree what happens next."*
- | *"The order arrived on the twelfth, three days late, and one item was missing."*
- | *"I have already spoken to two people and sent the photographs."*
- | *"What I would like is a replacement by Friday, or a refund. Which can you do?"*
- | *"Could I have your name, and a reference for this conversation?"*

## Saying no at work

### SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I can see why this matters. I cannot take it on this week."*
- | *"I can do it by Wednesday, not Monday. Which matters more?"*
- | *"If I take this on, one of the other two will move. Your call which."*
- | *"That sits with the platform team — shall I introduce you?"*



## APPENDIX F

## Spoken Grammar Quick Reference

The rules from Stage Five, on two pages, for when you need to check one quickly.

## Articles

|                           |                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Singular countable</b> | Always needs something: <i>a, an, the, my, this, one</i> . Never nothing.                                         |
| <b>a / an</b>             | First mention, or one of many. <i>an</i> before a vowel <b>sound</b> : <i>an hour, a university</i> .             |
| <b>the</b>                | Second mention, or only one possible: <i>the manager, the office, the first one</i> .                             |
| <b>No article</b>         | General plurals ( <i>I like dogs</i> ), uncountables ( <i>water is expensive</i> ), most place names, most meals. |
| <b>Fixed phrases</b>      | <i>at home, at work, in bed, by car, on foot, go to school</i> — but go to <b>the</b> office.                     |

## Tenses in speech

|                           |                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Present simple</b>     | Habits, facts, states: <i>I work in Pune. I have two sisters. I know him</i> .                                 |
| <b>Present continuous</b> | Now, or a temporary period: <i>I am working on the migration this month</i> .                                  |
| <b>Never continuous</b>   | <i>have, know, understand, want, need, like, love, hate, believe, remember, prefer, own, mean, seem, agree</i> |
| <b>Past simple</b>        | Finished time stated: <i>I sent it yesterday</i> .                                                             |
| <b>Present perfect</b>    | Unfinished time or no time stated: <i>I have sent it. I have worked here for five years</i> .                  |
| <b>Perfect continuous</b> | Ongoing with <i>since/for</i> : <i>I have been working here since 2020</i> .                                   |
| <b>since / for</b>        | <i>since</i> + a point (2020, Monday); <i>for</i> + a length (five years, two days).                           |

## Questions and negatives

|                                |                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Yes/no</b>                  | Auxiliary first: <i>Are you free? Did you send it? Have you finished?</i>           |
| <b>With <i>do/does/did</i></b> | Main verb returns to base form: <i>Did he <b>say</b>? not did he said.</i>          |
| <b>Wh-questions</b>            | Question word, then invert: <i>When did you send it?</i>                            |
| <b>Indirect questions</b>      | Do <b>not</b> invert: <i>Could you tell me where the office <b>is</b>?</i>          |
| <b>Negatives</b>               | One negative only: <i>I did not see anything, never did not see nothing.</i>        |
| <b>Tag questions</b>           | Reverse the auxiliary: <i>You are coming, aren't you? Or just use <i>right</i>?</i> |

## Prepositions that Indian English changes

|                       |                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>No preposition</b> | <i>discuss something · order something · request something · reach a place · join a company · marry someone · contact someone · answer something</i>   |
| <b>Fixed</b>          | <i>good at · interested in · depend on · listen to · wait for · apologise for · arrive at (place) · arrive in (city) · married to · different from</i> |
| <b>Time</b>           | <i>at four o'clock · on Monday, on the fifteenth · in June, in 2026, in the morning · at night</i>                                                     |
| <b>No back</b>        | <i>revert, return, repeat, reply already contain it.</i>                                                                                               |

## Uncountable nouns: never add \*-s\*

*information · furniture · equipment · advice · luggage · baggage · staff · machinery · stationery · homework · work · research · feedback · progress · traffic · news · money · software · evidence · permission · accommodation*

To count them, add a counting phrase: *a piece of information, an item of furniture, a piece of advice, a bit of feedback, two pieces of equipment*. Note *the news **is** good* and *the staff **are** ready*.

## APPENDIX G

## The Practice Plan and Partner Guide

Everything you need to keep going after Day 100, plus instructions you can hand to a practice partner who has not read the book.

### The thirty-day shadowing cycle

|                  |                                                                                                                              |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Days 1-2</b>  | Listen to the clip four times. Mark the transcript: underline stressed words, slash the pauses, join the linked words.       |
| <b>Days 3-4</b>  | Read aloud along with the audio, four times per session. You will fall behind; rejoin and continue.                          |
| <b>Days 5-6</b>  | Speak along without looking at the transcript, four times.                                                                   |
| <b>Day 7</b>     | Record yourself, then play the original immediately after. Write the one difference you most want to close.                  |
| <b>Next week</b> | New clip, same cycle. Twenty to forty seconds, with an accurate transcript, by a speaker you would be content to sound like. |

### The daily minimum, after Day 100

- **Ten minutes of shadowing.** The single highest-value habit in this book.
- **Five minutes of reading aloud,** with a rotating focus: breath, endings, stress, weak forms, linking, pace.
- **One real conversation in English.** With a human being. One sentence counts on a bad day.
- **Twenty minutes of listening** while commuting or cooking. No transcript, no pausing, enjoyable material.
- **One weekly recording.** Same question every week: *"Tell me about yourself and what you do."*

### Solo drills, five to ten minutes each

- **Minimal pairs.** Ten pairs from Appendix A for your two worst sounds, in front of a mirror.
- **Tap the beats.** Five sentences, tapping the stressed words, squashing everything between them.
- **The one-minute answer.** Random question, two seconds of silence, sixty seconds of structured answer.
- **Filler count.** Two minutes explaining anything; count the fillers; repeat and replace them with pauses.
- **Narrate your day silently in English** while commuting. Free, invisible, effective.
- **Ten collocations a week,** each used aloud five times in your own sentence.

## For your practice partner

Hand this page to whoever is helping you. Ten minutes a week is enough, and they do not need to be a teacher or a fluent speaker — they only need to listen and report.

1. **Two-minute listening test.** They talk for two minutes about anything. Afterwards, I repeat back the three main points. They tell me how accurate I was.
2. **Question interview.** They ask me five questions about my work. I answer each in under sixty seconds. They tell me which answer was longest and which was clearest.
3. **Minimal pairs test.** They read ten pairs from Appendix A in random order and I say which word they said. This tests my ear, which is what limits my mouth.
4. **Hostile questioner.** They ask my five hardest interview questions rapidly, in a slightly cold tone. I practise answering briefly and not apologising.
5. **One honest observation.** At the end they tell me one thing they noticed: speed, a repeated word, a sound, an ending I dropped. One thing only, never a list.

## Free practice partners, if you have nobody

- **Strangers in shops and queues.** Thirty seconds each, twice a day. No history, no consequence, unlimited supply.
- **Your own recorder.** Ask yourself a question, answer it aloud, play it back. Most of this book works alone.
- **Online language exchange partners.** Offer your first language in return; the exchange makes it sustainable.
- **Read to a child, or to nobody.** Reading aloud needs no audience at all.
- **Voice notes.** Send a friend a two-minute voice note in English instead of a text.

## What to do when you plateau

Everyone plateaus, usually around month two, and it almost always means the practice has become comfortable. Three ways out: raise the difficulty (a faster shadowing clip, a harder listening source), raise the stakes (speak in a bigger meeting, record yourself for someone else), or narrow the target (pick one sound and do nothing else for a week). Comfortable practice maintains; slightly uncomfortable practice improves.

## APPENDIX H

# Self-Assessment, Sources and Further Reading

Score sheets for Day 1 and Day 100, the four counts that measure real progress, and the sources this course draws on.

## The four numbers that matter

Record sixty seconds answering “*Tell me about yourself and what you do*” on Day 1 and again on Day 100. Count these four things in each. Numbers, not feelings.

**Words per minute** Day 1: \_\_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_\_ (target 130-150)

**Fillers per minute** Day 1: \_\_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_\_ (*um, actually, basically, means, na*)

**Dropped endings** Day 1: \_\_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_\_ (missing -s and -ed)

**Missing articles** Day 1: \_\_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_\_ (*a, an, the*)

## The twelve-statement self-check

Tick what is true. Do this on Day 1 and again on Day 100, without looking at your first answers.

**Day 1 total** \_\_\_\_\_ / 12 Date: \_\_\_\_\_

**Day 100 total** \_\_\_\_\_ / 12 Date: \_\_\_\_\_

## Skill scores, out of ten

**Sounds and clarity** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_

**Rhythm and stress** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_

**Grammar in speech** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_

**Fluency and hesitation** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_

**Listening** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_

**Confidence** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ Day 100: \_\_\_\_

**Total** Day 1: \_\_\_\_ / 60 Day 100: \_\_\_\_ / 60

## My next hundred days

Three habits I am keeping, two targets I am adding, one repeating commitment, and the date I will re-measure.

---



---



---

## Sources and further reading

This course is an original piece of writing, but its structure and its diagnosis of the specific problems Indian speakers face draw on established teaching practice and on the sources below. All were consulted and paraphrased; none are reproduced. If you want to go deeper, these are good next steps.

### COURSE STRUCTURE AND TEACHING METHOD

- **British Council India, Spoken English course outline** — the level structure and the division of pronunciation into word stress, sentence stress, intonation and connected speech, together with the input-practice-output cycle, informed the shape of Stages One to Four and Stage Nine.  
[britishcouncil.in/english/courses-adults/spoken-english-course-face-face](http://britishcouncil.in/english/courses-adults/spoken-english-course-face-face)
- **British Council, Spoken English module outcomes and FAQs** — level descriptions and module outcomes. [britishcouncil.in](http://britishcouncil.in)

### MOTHER TONGUE INFLUENCE

- **EngVarta, on reducing mother tongue influence** — language-specific tendencies including article dropping, the v and w merge, first-syllable stress and lengthened final syllables.  
[engvarta.com/best-apps-to-reduce-mother-tongue-influence-in-english](http://engvarta.com/best-apps-to-reduce-mother-tongue-influence-in-english)
- **Juno School, on mother tongue influence in professional calls** — MTI as an effect on pronunciation, intonation and rhythm rather than a defect. [junoschool.org](http://junoschool.org)
- **Clapingo, on the effect of MTI on spoken English** — consequences for clarity at work.  
[clapingo.com/blog/mother-tongue-influence-problem-english](http://clapingo.com/blog/mother-tongue-influence-problem-english)
- **Language in India and academic papers on L1 interference in Indian English pronunciation** — substitution of English sounds with the nearest first-language equivalents. [languageinindia.com](http://languageinindia.com)

### INDIANISMS AND INTERNATIONAL USAGE

- **Linguix, Indian English replacements** — neutral alternatives for region-specific business vocabulary.  
[linguix.com/english/common-mistake/indian\\_english](http://linguix.com/english/common-mistake/indian_english)
- **Regina Coeli, common mistakes Indian speakers make** — words rarely used by speakers elsewhere, and their replacements. [reginacoeli.com](http://reginacoeli.com)
- **The Times of India, on phrases to avoid in job application emails** — on *Respected Sir* and *do the needful*. [timesofindia.indiatimes.com](http://timesofindia.indiatimes.com)

### FLUENCY TECHNIQUE

- **Published guidance on shadowing and imitation practice** — listening to natural speech and repeating it immediately to train rhythm, stress and intonation together, which underpins Day 40 and Stage Ten.
- **Research and teaching guidance on repeated oral reading** — the basis for the daily reading-aloud habit in Day 93.
- **Chunk and collocation learning** — the basis for Stage Six and Day 94: learning multi-word units rather than isolated words.

*Content from these sources was rephrased for compliance with licensing restrictions. Any errors of interpretation are the author's.*

## What this book does not cover

This is a speaking course. It will not treat a stammer, a speech or hearing disorder, or a serious anxiety condition — all of which respond well to the right professional help, and none of which are language problems. It is also not an exam preparation guide, although Stage Nine will help with the speaking sections of international tests. And it will not remove your accent, because that was never a defect to be

removed.

# Day 101

---

You will not wake up on Day 101 speaking like a newsreader, and that was never the target. What you should have is different: people stop asking you to repeat yourself, you stop rehearsing sentences before you say them, and you stop avoiding the phone.

Keep three habits and the rest maintains itself: the weekly sixty-second recording, ten minutes of shadowing, and one real conversation in English every day.

And stop apologising for your English. Nobody who speaks three languages owes anybody an apology for their accent in the second one.